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BESTSELLING AUTHOR
KIRSTEN MCCURRAN

UNDERCOVER
WIFE
NULL:ECHO

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A woman with long, wavy red hair and freckles is wearing a dark green, lace-trimmed spaghetti-strap dress. She is standing in a dimly lit bar or club, looking over her shoulder at the camera. In the background, other patrons are visible but out of focus.

**UNDERCOVER
WIFE**



undercover wife

Null:Echo

kirsten mcurran



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2009

Just outside of Moscow

“BE a dear and refresh our drinks, Milica,” Reznikov said in Russian. He held out his glass and shook it like she was the help.

“Of course. My pleasure,” the woman responded. Her pronunciation was perfect, like she’d been speaking Russian her entire life. But Russian was only one of four languages she spoke. And her name wasn’t Milica. It was Madison Byrne.

Anatoly Reznikov didn’t know either of those facts. To the FSB official, she was Milica Jovanovic, a former Serbian ballet dancer. They’d met in a Moscow nightclub where she’d been a shot girl. Life had not been kind to Milica after an injury ended her dance career. Those circumstances made her ripe for Reznikov’s attention. He liked the pretty, wounded bird type. He enjoyed the control it gave him. She was very good at playing the role and attracting men like him.

The large study in Reznikov’s dacha was chilly, despite the roaring fire in the hearth. Madison only wore a thin, silvery velvet dress with a low, scooped neckline and a high slit. The velvet looked poured over her, the

better to show off her former dancer's body. Of course, she'd never been a dancer, but she was incredibly fit.

Madison poured fresh drinks for the men. Reznikov was serving his guest the best American bourbon in his bar. Kemal Arslan had been pampered all weekend, treated like a king instead of the high-ranking Turkish military official he was. Madison had endured the burly man's lustful gaze and casual touches because she understood her role and what Reznikov expected from his latest pet project. The Russian gave his women an extravagant lifestyle, but there was a price. She wondered how far she'd have to take this before her mission was complete.

Arslan accepted his drink with a paternal smile and a hand on her hip, which slid around to her ass. Madison warmly smiled and accepted it, even leaned into it. Only when he traced the line between her cheeks and began pressing the velvet into it did she dance away and hand Reznikov his drink. The Russian sat her on the arm of the ornate, overstuffed burgundy couch, hand lingering on her bare leg left exposed by the dress's high slit.

"We've been dancing around this all weekend, Kemal. All you need to do is wire the money, and we can close this deal." Reznikov could bury his brutal side and charm anyone, but he had his limits.

"Perhaps, your company is best enjoyed for longer," Arslan replied. His broken Russian had been grating on Madison all weekend. She fought the urge to correct him every time he spoke.

"You're welcome to enjoy my hospitality for as long as you like, Kemal. That doesn't have to end when our deal is completed. Feel free to enjoy any of the pleasures I have to offer here at my dacha. But I must insist you wire the money. I have people to answer to, just as you do, my friend."

Reznikov's hand slid higher on Madison's thigh, fingertips brushing into the slit. She knew the dress was perfect for her host when she chose it. Although she felt nothing for the man—the heavy, balding Russian was the

antithesis of the men she went for—the intimate touch still stirred a reaction in her. His power and entitlement *were* an aphrodisiac.

“Any pleasures?” Arslan asked, eyes poring over Madison like he was planning every filthy thing he wanted to do to her. The woman shuddered.

“Of course, my friend. And if you don’t see anything you like, I can procure other options.”

Please procure other options, she thought. Madison had memorized Kemal Arslan’s file and knew exactly the sort of pleasures the Turkish general enjoyed. She would do what the mission required—she’d done it for Reznikov for over a month—but she was firm on one thing. *That hairy bastard is not having my ass.*

“No, that is necessary,” Arslan replied, eyes locked on Madison. He paused to correct his Russian. “No, I am pleased with what you have, Anatoly. We dispense with business, yes? Then pleasures. No stops.”

“Excellent. If you’d just come to my desk, you may initiate the transfer on my computer. You’ve seen the weapon system outside in the truck. I’ll have the targeting system brought up from my vault, so that you may inspect it for yourself.”

Arslan frowned, not understanding the Russian. Reznikov dumbled it down. “The software to run the system is here. I’ll bring it up.”

“Very good,” the other man nodded.

You’d better hurry, Damien. We’re almost out of time, she thought, and it wasn’t about the Turk violating her ass.

Right on cue, a voice crackled in her ear. “I’m going to need more time, Maddy. Our intel was bad. The model year for Reznikov’s safe is wrong. I need to pull up the right code to crack it. You’re going to need to stretch up there.”

Madison smiled tightly. The men in the room thought it was for them, but it was her response to Damien. She couldn’t answer him, not until she was alone. Her earpiece was nearly undetectable, rendered even more so by

the waves of her flaming hair. *I hope he doesn't expect too much stretching. Not with these two.* She'd done enough *stretching* with Reznikov. She'd been looking forward to being out of his dacha after tonight.

"Cough if you heard me," Damien said. His voice was like warm honey in her ear. She kind of hated how sexy his voice was. She didn't need the distraction. Madison cleared her throat. "Good girl. Sorry to have to do this to you. Promise to make it up in Paris on our way home. You can tell me all about how you hated every second of this mission." His low laugh annoyed her. Damien enjoyed hearing the sordid details of her missions way too much.

If she'd been able to speak to him, Madison would have told Damien, *I'm engaged. There won't be a romantic pit stop in Paris. Things have changed.* He was having trouble accepting that. She pushed that, and any other thoughts of Charles, out of her head.

Madison pulled out the chair for Arslan and rubbed his shoulders when he was seated behind the desk. Reznikov stood behind her, roughly kneading her ass. The man was disgusting, but she couldn't deny the thrill of being treated like a possession. She actively avoided thinking about why she liked certain parts of her work. Back when she was a confident, independent International Studies student, Madison never thought she'd let men treat her like an object, or that she could enjoy it—even in service of her country. But that was before the Agency recruited her.

"No record of this, yes?" Arslan asked, handling the mouse like a man who'd never touched a computer before.

"The weapon system will be untraceable, my friend. I know you do not want your plan for the Kurds to be traced back to you."

Reznikov slid his hand inside Madison's dress, his fingers resting on the heated inside of her thigh. The slit gave him such easy access. Her breath hitched. The man smelled like bourbon and savory meats, but his possessiveness still did something to her. It was an asset that her body

reacted that way, but she didn't like what it said about her. She forced herself to focus on the task at hand.

"You'll do whatever he asks. Do you understand, sweet Milica?" Reznikov growled in her ear, his fingers seeking higher.

"*Da*," she replied breathlessly, willing her thighs to relax for the vile man. Just because he turned her on, it didn't mean she wanted *him*. She was just chasing something he made her feel. *It better not come to that*, she thought. *Hurry the fuck up, Damien*.

Reznikov watched the monitor and waited for his money to appear in the unmarked Cayman Islands account. The FSB officer was not strictly acting on behalf of Mother Russia. A security officer's salary didn't secure one a luxury dacha. He knew he was in the clear as long as he kept greasing the right palms. He hated being under the thumb of other men, but then he was always under someone's thumb.

Milica was under his thumb. Her willing *Da* made his cock stiffen in the expensive slacks he'd had custom-tailored in London. The pretty redhead was the best distraction he'd had in a long time. He loved the way her long, lean body responded to him, the way her flaming hair bounced when her mouth bobbed on him. She was a woman who truly needed a strong hand to guide her.

Reznikov only wished he had more time to spend with her, but his wife also demanded attention. Still, he visited Milica at his dacha when he could. And when she was all used up? Well, he knew men who would still pay for her. That time might come sooner than he'd hoped if the rumors he'd heard about Arslan were true.

He relished the hitch in her breath and the blush of her pale, freckled cheeks when his fingers brushed the lace edge of her panties. Milica was so pliant, so enthusiastic. And god, did she know how to use that tight body. He traced circles on her thigh, feeling the heat radiating from her sex, while Arslan completed the transaction.

“There. Is done. Happy to finish business?” Arslan said, twisting to find Milica’s chest right in his face. The man’s eyes narrowed. Her nipples seemed to be staring at him.

“Yes. Very good. Now we can celebrate,” Reznikov said.

The threesome moved back to the cozy sitting area by the fire. He raised a toast to their deal, noting how Arslan watched Milica. The girl noticed it, too. For the first time since he’d known her, she seemed nervous. He’d never seen her tense before. Reznikov had enjoyed many pleasures with her, but he had not shared her yet. She must have sensed what was coming. Perhaps she needed something to calm her anxiety.

“May I offer something to help begin our celebration?” he offered, retrieving a small steel capsule containing several pink pills from an ornate gold box on his desk.

He poured a pill into Arslan’s hand. The Turk tossed it back and washed it down with the bourbon without question. Reznikov swallowed his. Milica hesitated.

“What is this, Anatoly?” she asked.

“Something to help you relax, dear.”

She smiled. “Thank you, but I already feel good.”

“We’re going to have a party, and I expect you to join us, Milica.”

“I will. I look forward to celebrating your success.” She stroked his arm.

Reznikov tightened his grip, hand locked on her hip. His annoyance at her resistance was only tempered by the knowledge that she would surely pay for it soon. It was the first time she had challenged him, and he was not pleased. All women showed their true colors eventually, in his experience. Perhaps she was not the easy party girl he’d thought. It didn’t matter. She didn’t have a choice anymore.

“You will celebrate with us, Milica. Take your medicine.” His voice carried an edge he hadn’t had to use with her before.

She looked like she wanted to push, but the smile was back after faltering. She popped the pill in her mouth. “Of course, Anatoly. I just didn’t want you to think I needed help to enjoy my time with you.”

Milica’s blood-red nails raked his scalp, giving him chills. Her hungry kiss and keen tongue conveyed her desire. *There’s my eager girl*, he thought.

“Let me call down and have the laptop with the targeting system brought up for your perusal, my friend. Perhaps Milica will make you comfortable while we wait.”

“You are most gracious host, Anatoly,” the Turk said, taking her hand and leading her back to the couch.

“WHAT THE FUCK?” Damien muttered under his breath. He watched the numbers on the screen flash through combinations like he was waiting to hit the jackpot on a slot machine.

The small device was attached to Reznikov’s vault by the thin ribbon of a serial cable. It looked like the Blackberry any businessman would carry, but it was a specialized decoding device developed by the Agency. Damien was always impressed by the new gadgets those nerds in the DS&T came up with. Even he had to admit that a pistol and a knife weren’t enough to complete most modern missions. His earpiece was a perfect example. He had no idea how they packed the needed electronics into such a tiny device, but it worked.

Sounds of Reznikov’s study came through the earpiece while he waited for the gizmo to unlock the Russian’s vault. He heard their target urging Arslan to complete their transaction. Damien was running out of time. The mission could not fail. Innocent lives depended on it. If the Turks got their hands on the advanced targeting system, the Kurds were screwed.

“I’m going to need more time, Maddy. Our intel was bad. The model year for Reznikov’s safe is wrong. I need to pull up the right code to crack it. You’re going to need to stretch up there.”

Damien understood what he was asking of her. Reznikov was hardly a prize, and Madison had already been taking one for the team for over a month. That night, *stretching* might mean taking more than one. He understood the Russian’s expectations as well as Madison did. *I’ve got to get into this vault*, he thought, squeezing the faux Blackberry tighter, as if that would make it work faster.

Over their years as partners, Damien had witnessed a lot of Madison’s work up close, and he’d always had mixed feelings about it. In many ways, she had the harder task on many of their missions. She put her body on the line just as often as he did, just in different ways. Her country asked her to do things most conventional women would never even consider, even for the greater good. But Madison had always been up to the task. Enthusiastically so, one could say.

Mostly rustling noises and the men speaking in Russian came through his earpiece. Damien’s Russian wasn’t nearly as good as Madison’s, but he got the gist. Arslan was wiring the money. *Fuck, come on*, he thought. He wasn’t only worried about whatever his partner may have to do to keep the men distracted. Once the money was wired, Reznikov would send for the laptop, and Damien would have a serious problem. He already had two dead Russian security agents at his feet. If he didn’t get in and out soon, more security would be by, and the alarm would be raised, and all hell would break loose. *Come on, Maddy. Slow them down.*

More numbers clicked into place on the screen, but it was still too slow. Damien heard talk of celebrating in his ear. Madison sounded enthusiastic. She always was, and it turned him on in a way that was hard to admit. They were supposed to keep it all professional, detached, but he knew it wasn’t

always like that for her, and it wasn't for him either, especially since they had become involved.

Part of him hated what she'd been doing with Reznikov, but there was that other part... The part that thrilled to her adventures and burned to *reclaim* her afterward. It was hard now that Madison wasn't his to reclaim. She was going to marry *Charles*. Damien tried to cope with that, but he hadn't been doing well.

The faux Blackberry beeped. The vault door rumbled as tumblers clicked and locking bolts disengaged. *Yes! Fucking finally!* he thought. But he'd been so caught up in thinking about Madison that he'd lost focus.

"Hey! Who are you?" a gruff voice called out in Russian.

Damien looked up to see a burly Russian agent coming down the hallway. He was so wide, he *filled* the hallway. "Hey, man. It's not what you think," he replied in Russian with a Moscow-by-way-of-Northeast-Philly accent. "They tripped."

The Russian picked up speed, rushing toward Damien. In a single smooth motion, the CIA agent drew the suppressed Sig Sauer P228 from his belt and fired. The single shot emitted a quiet cough, and red mist bloomed from the Russian's throat. Damien's physicality was perfect, whether he was killing or in bed. *That takes care of that*, he thought.

As the Russian reached for his throat and folded to the floor, he touched a remote on his belt. Blinding lights strobed, and a piercing alarm sounded. *Oh fuck*, he thought.

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Madison peeled the satin away from her curves. She was athletic but didn't believe she had a convincing ballerina's body—even a former dancer's. Madison was tight and toned like a ballerina, but she had curves. The men greedily watched her expose her body. Stripping was her idea. It bought time for Damien to get his shit together and hold up his end of the mission. Her hips swayed to music only she heard. In this case, it was Alicia Keys.

Reznikov slid behind her, hand curling around to cup her breast. She whimpered when he lightly twisted her nipple. She'd tucked his drug under her tongue until she could spit it out, but enough of it had dissolved that she was feeling the effects. Madison thought it was some Ecstasy derivative, but different. Every touch radiated liquid heat through her body.

The Russian made a lot of money shipping designer drugs to Western Europe. He had fingers in many different pies. She felt the drowsy sensitivity and racing heart of ecstasy, but none of the stifling warm blanket feeling. It was hard to get off on Ecstasy, but the way Reznikov's drug spread heat through her body, she knew that would not be a problem.

"You're not going to make my friend just watch, are you, Milica? Go be friendly." His gentle shove nearly dropped her in the fat Turk's lap.

The drug was making her clumsy. Madison focused. She'd been trained in how to keep a clear head when drugged. It was part of the interrogation resistance program at The Farm. But these men did not plan to interrogate her. That might have been more pleasant. Arslan's shirt was already damp with sweat.

Arslan had bad breath and a thick tongue, but Madison kissed him like she loved it. She kissed him the way Milica would. Milica was pliant if she was getting what she wanted. His hands were clumsy on her breasts, but the drug made it feel good anyway. Everything felt good, which could be a problem. She concentrated on a silver-framed portrait on the mantle. That was part of her training to keep a clear head. But she still gasped when his thumbs twiddled her nipples. Madison couldn't imagine how amazing it would feel if she'd had a full dose of the drug.

"You like that girl?" Arslan panted in his poor Russian.

"Mmm... Feels good," she moaned, only half-lying.

It wasn't just the drug that was allowing her to enjoy Arlan's rough hands. She felt Reznikov watching her. His possessive gaze pierced her to the core, where it throbbed within her. Being watched, his power, they were a turn-on, even if the man was a zero.

In certain situations, Madison saw enjoying her work as a bonus, but that night, she couldn't let herself slip too far into those feelings. She couldn't show any vulnerability to these men. They'd wield it as a weapon. She just had to let them get far enough to think they were getting what they wanted. And once Damien was in the vault, she'd find an excuse to slip away. *What are you waiting for?* she thought. *Reznikov's man is on his way down there.*

Arlan had a thick, but comically short cock. Madison didn't understand why he was so eager to show it to her, but the women in his life probably had to pretend to be impressed. She plastered on a smile and widened her

eyes, trying to suppress the growing buzz of arousal where he touched her. *Just rubbing against the couch would turn me on right now*, she reflected.

Madison was accepting that she'd have to touch that thing when the alarm sounded. *Damn it, Damien! What did you do?* she thought. Despite the fresh complication, she was relieved she wouldn't have to handle the Turk's grubby cock after all.

"What is that?" she asked, springing off the couch. "Is something happening?" *Do I sound like a convincing, dumb Russian shot girl?*

Arslan sputtered with panic, struggling to tuck his cock away. Reznikov told him to be calm. The Russian explained, "There must be a security breach, but I'm sure it's nothing my men can't handle. Maybe an animal tripped a sensor outside, or one of your men wandered where he shouldn't have."

"Are we safe?" Madison asked, conveying the proper amount of panic while she calculated her next move. The Russian was calm, but he still walked around to his desk and reached into a drawer for his gun. She could not let him get that in his hands. Her situation would go from bad to much worse if he did.

"Just be calm and stay out of my way," he replied.

"Sorry, that's going to be a problem."

Reznikov had just enough time to look confused before Madison kned the drawer closed on his hand. He yelped and tried to pull his hand free with the gun. She pulled the drawer open and slammed it again. He cursed and backhanded her. She saw stars and tasted copper, but punched him back. He got his other hand free, minus the gun.

"What are you doing, Milica?" he asked, holding his throbbing hand.

"I need to go now, and I can't let you stop me, Anatoly."

"What are you talking about?"

Madison felt ridiculous fighting the man wearing nothing but a thong and clear Lucite stripper heels—he had a thing for them—but the sway of

her tits distracted him. Her nudity was an asset in that moment. She punched him again.

“Have you lost your mind, crazy bitch?” Reznikov sneered.

Reznikov took another punch to the face, but he fired one right back, sending Madison careening into a bookshelf. The heels proved impossible to fight in, so she slipped them off, throwing one at the Russian to buy an extra second. He dodged the shoe, but it slowed his advance.

Arslan had his pants on and joined the fight. He was surprisingly strong for such a fat man, grabbing Madison from her blind side. His fingers clawed in her hair close to the scalp, wrenching her head back before dragging her forward and tossing her toward the couch. She sprawled onto the couch, ass in the air. The drug made her clumsy. She was fighting to regain her balance when the Turk grabbed her hair again and shoved Madison face down into the cushions. The strangest thing was that even the rough pulling of her hair spiked intense pleasure through her, making her scrambled brain question resisting him.

“Take care of problem. I have her,” Arslan directed Reznikov.

“Leave some for me, my friend,” his host replied.

Madison struggled for purchase on the hard, overstuffed brocade and painfully broke a nail. Blood from her nose smeared the fabric and her face. She fought to drag in even the smallest breath. The less oxygen she had, the weaker she became. She was in serious trouble.

“When we find out who you are, I send piece back to your father. Feed the rest to dogs. But first, I enjoy, you suffer,” Arslan laughed and sounded winded.

That was a real possibility if Madison didn’t get it together. His hand slid between her legs, and he found her wet from earlier from the effects of the designer drug. The pig mistook it for genuine desire, grunting with satisfaction. She used what she had and leaned into it with a moan, which wasn’t entirely fake. The touch made her throb. But men like Arslan and

Reznikov always underestimated women. Madison had realized long ago that her sexuality was a weapon, and it just might save her life once again.

Madison pressed back against his fingers, and the fool loosened his grip on her hair. She sucked in a deep breath, centered herself, and shoved off the back of the couch. One of the Turk's knees buckled when she crashed into them with her full weight, and they both tumbled to the floor, landing in a heap. Importantly, she landed on top.

"Bitch!" Arslan cursed, grabbing for her hair once again. It was the easiest target.

Her elbow landed in his sternum, knocking out what little breath he'd drawn with Madison on top of him. Arslan released her with a grunt. She spun, straddling him. He thought the night would go there at some point, but not like that. Everything felt like it was in slow motion, but she was still faster than the fat Turk. She bunched her fingers and struck a nerve cluster. Arslan yelped like a little girl. The second strike crushed his Adam's apple. He clutched his throat.

"Keep...your...fucking...hands...to...yourself..." Madison spat, striking his head back against the hardwood floor with each word. His eyes were unfocused, but she kept going. "You...do...not...fucking...own...me..."

Crimson pooled around the Turkish general's head when she was finished. His glassy eyes stared at her with dull surprise. She cruelly smirked, recalling all the photos in Arslan's file, evidence of his brutality toward women.

"Was it as good for you as it was for me?" she asked the corpse. Madison would have to answer for killing the Turkish general. That was not part of the mission. There would be diplomatic blowback, but she could live with her actions. She always did.

Madison planted her palm on his face to push up to her feet. She swiped her hair out of her face and willed her heart to stop pounding. She had to

either control the adrenaline spike or keep it going, but if it ran out, she'd be left exhausted. She needed it with Reznikov's drug in her system.

The gun she'd made Reznikov leave in the drawer was gone. He must have taken it with him while she was face down on the couch. "Damien, can you hear me? What's going on?" No answer. Madison realized her earpiece had been knocked loose in the struggle. She didn't have time to find it. After wiggling back into the tight velvet sheath, she realized it was too restrictive and tore at the slit. It gave with a rending sound, the fabric splitting much higher than she would have liked. Her ass was left hanging out, but fortunately, modesty had departed hours—weeks ago.

Madison found a Soviet-era NR-40 in another desk drawer and took a moment to judge the knife's feel before she ran from the study on bare feet, heading toward Reznikov's vault.

DAMIEN WENT TO ONE KNEE, took a shooting stance, and dropped the first three guards who rounded the corner, adding to the number of bodies collecting in the hallway. He waited a beat, and when no one else came running, he pulled the heavy vault door open.

A light came on when the heavy steel door swung open, rolling on thick wheels. The interior was the size of a well-appointed walk-in closet, two of the walls lined with steel shelves. The back wall held three paintings, which Damien was sure had been stolen or looted. He was sure the landscape was a Cezanne that had been stolen from a British museum a decade earlier. There was no time to repatriate artwork.

Gold bars lined one shelf. Jewelry boxes another. Damien did pause to slip one of Reznikov's Patek Philippe's over his wrist. It was the least the Russian could give him for his trouble. Looted artifacts that belonged in a museum lined more shelves.

Finally, he found the heavy, ruggedized laptop that surely contained the advanced targeting system. It had to be the one because it was the only laptop in the vault. He slipped the thick computer into his bag, along with several hard drives stacked beside it. No telling what useful information might be on those drives.

Damien stepped out of the vault to find four more guards. He raised his hands and smiled. "Guys, let's all be reasonable about this." He spoke in English.

"Put down the bag," one of the guards said in Russian, gesturing with his PP-19 Vityaz.

Damien was unsure if the guard understood him, but it didn't matter. Actions spoke louder than words in his situation, and he moved very slowly, keeping one hand up while he slowly lowered his backpack to the floor with the other. He kept the smile plastered on. "Sorry about your friends, but they were like that when I got here."

"Down." The guard gestured with his Vityaz.

"Sure thing, buddy," Damien continued in English. He slowly knelt on the polished concrete floor, but as he touched the polished stone floor, he swung hard with his elbow, connecting with the guard's knee.

The guard fell to his right, giving Damien room to duck back, putting the falling Russian between him and the other guards. He had a 50-50 shot that they wouldn't fire anyway. But the injured man did fire, his finger tightening on the trigger as he went down. The Vityaz was deafening in the enclosed hallway, rounds chipping stone out of the wall beside the vault door.

Damien slid on his side, drawing the P228. He took out another one of the guards before a comrade kicked the gun out of his hand. He wrapped his arms around the guard's legs, simultaneously trying to pull the man down and use him to climb up. He was halfway to his feet when the butt of the guard's Vityaz connected with his skull.

Blinking the flash of pain out of his eyes, Damien kept trying to pull the man down, but the Viyaz connected again, and his thinking got fuzzy behind the fresh bloom of pain in his skull. His arms slipped from the guard's legs, and he curled into a ball to protect himself from a vicious kick. The blows kept coming, the other three upright guards joining in. He pulled tighter, trying to protect his head and soft parts, and hoped he found an opening before they killed him. He wondered how Madison was faring upstairs.

"Don't kill him. I need answers," Reznikov called out. It wasn't a good sign for his partner if the man was downstairs at the vault.

Damien tried to get to his feet again, only to be rewarded with a kick that jarred some teeth loose. He fell back to the floor. The guards laughed and cursed him in Russian. He clung to the remote possibility that he'd pay them all back for this.

"I don't know who you or your bitch partner upstairs are, but I'll enjoy finding out," Reznikov said from above him. "I assume you're working with Milica. I hope Arslan leaves enough of her to question."

"Motherfucker," Damien cursed, trying to lunge at the man.

Reznikov's pistol barked, and a round cored through his leg just above the knee. "Stay down, my American friend. Or don't. On second thought, I probably only need one of you alive, and sweet Milica will be much more fun to interrogate."

Damien winced away from the barrel of Reznikov's pistol. Even then, he was unwilling to believe it all ended huddled on the floor in the dank basement of a Russian dacha, but it was probably always destined to go that way. If he'd wanted to play it safe, he would have been riding a desk at Langley. His only real regret was failing Madison.

Madison came tearing down the hallway, bare feet slapping the stone floor, shrieking like a banshee. She saw that Reznikov had the Makarov pointed at Damien's head and knew surprise was her only weapon. But she

still had four armed men to get past, and she'd probably be shot dead before she got ten feet. Standing and watching the Russian shoot her partner dead was not an option. She could not live with that. The shriek was a distraction. Her body was one, too. The men stared at her wild copper hair and the way she almost bounced out of the torn dress with every stride.

The Russian combat knife she'd taken from Reznikov's drawer was thrown hard. It was a stupid action movie move—the weapon wasn't balanced for throwing—but another distraction could only help, and she was unlikely to get close enough to use it properly anyway, and the drug in her system made a lot of stupid things seem like good ideas. But the heavy blade arced through the air like it was guided by angels and embedded in a guard just above the collarbone.

Going low and dodging to the right, Madison felt a barrage of bullets cut through the air above her. She crashed into another guard with her shoulder, catching him in the gut. Her momentum carried them both to the floor. They fell beside the guard who took her knife. Moving quickly blunted the physical effects of the drug. While batting away the hands of the man beneath her, she pulled the knife from the downed guard and thrust it into her new target as rapidly as she could, shredding his side.

"Don't you stop? Bitch!" Reznikov shouted. *Who is this woman?* he wondered.

The Russian fired the Makarov at Madison, but she turned, pulling the useless guard with her, and the bullets tore into his back. Another of his hapless guards got in the way and took the shots from his pistol. Reznikov cursed. He'd put this bitch in her place yet. He'd string her up in his wine cellar and enjoy her unravelling. She'd beg for everything he did to her, even the brutal, painful parts. He'd have the truth from her—and everything else.

When she was clear of his men, the guard's sidearm was in her hand, pointed up at him. Her pistol barked before he got another round out of the

Makarov. Bullets tore into his chest, knocking him back. The pain came a moment later. Another round took Reznikov in the head, and a moment after the shock of it all hit, he dropped to the floor with a puppet with cut strings.

Madison panted, pushing fully free of the dead guard. Men never got off her quickly enough when they were finished. Her torn dress was slick with blood, smearing it across the floor when she pushed up. She wiped her hand on the guard's uniform shirt. She thought it was all Russian blood, but with the fight done, she finally felt the searing pain in her side. She hadn't been as lucky as she'd thought coming down that hallway.

"Fuck," she cursed, pressing a hand to the wound. The pain bloomed, and her hand came away slick with fresh blood. She didn't have much time to get out of the situation.

Madison hobbled over to where Damien lay on the floor. He looked even worse than she felt. His face was crusted with blood. His nose was crushed. His eyes were unfocused. *Concussion*, she thought. The bullet wound in his leg bled worse than hers. He had less time than she did.

"Maddy... You made it..." he weakly moaned.

"Just in time to save your ass. Again." She smiled.

"I had this handled."

"Sure, you did. If only you were as tough as you think you are."

Madison unbuckled his belt and pulled it free.

"You know I always want you, Maddy, but I don't think we have time for that..." Damien winced when he laughed.

She kissed his forehead. It was habit. She tasted copper. "Only ever one thing on your mind."

"Two things," he insisted, thinking about how much he wanted to kill Reznikov if Madison hadn't already finished him. She hovered above him, his lethal, battered angel. Even with the blossoming bruises and blood, she was still the most beautiful thing he'd ever seen.

“The only thing you need to be thinking about is getting your shit together so we can get out of here,” she said, moving away.

Damien forced himself to sit up. Everything hurt. Some of the damage felt like it might be permanent. Thinking was too difficult. The flashing lights and blaring klaxon made him want to claw his brain out.

He focused on Madison, ruthlessly efficient, as always. She evaluated the guards, picked the best candidate, and stripped off his boots and pants. She couldn't go outside in just that torn, bloody dress. It barely covered her perfect, tight body. He wanted her, despite the situation. He always wanted her.

Madison's tits bounced when she pulled up the pants, hopping to get them in place. The pants were too big, but they'd do. Her tits spilled free when she leaned forward to roll up the pants and pull on her boots. She was almost too perfect. Damien knew it was part of why she was so good at this job. Men were so distracted that they never saw the other part coming. She scooped herself back into the dress and tucked it into the borrowed pants.

Lifting one of the discarded Vityaz submachine guns, she checked the ammo. Satisfied, she slung it over her shoulder. She slung the backpack with the laptop, too. The mission still mattered, or it was all for nothing. Damien helped as much as he could, but Madison had to pull him to his feet, grunting with the effort.

“Okay, handsome, time to go,” she said.

“I'll go anywhere with you.”

Madison hated the way his puppy dog grin made her heart miss a beat. *Never should have felt that. Can't feel it anymore. It wasn't real. Charles is real.*

“Okay, let's go,” she said. “I'll get us out of this.”

Madison pulled Damien down the hallway, willing herself to believe it.

three

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Present Day

M cLean, VA

“WHAT THE F—” Madison began, shouting down from the bleachers. She paused when Charles tugged her fitted, faux-vintage Red Sox t-shirt. She knew the look she spied from the corner of her eye. It said, *don't yell fuck at our daughter's soccer game*.

Charles Sinclair was a conservative man—one might even say uptight—and often sought to tame her wildness. She knew it was her fire that initially attracted him to her—maybe made him fall in love—but he always wanted her to tone it down when he thought it would bring the wrong kind of attention. That had only increased in recent years as they'd moved into middle age and expectations of proper behavior had changed.

Madison knew how to fit in anywhere. She didn't really need her husband's guidance. She was a chameleon like that, but watching Penny on the soccer pitch was the one place she lost her cool. She was against injustice anywhere, but it especially made her blood boil when it fell onto her daughter.

“She did not deserve a goddam yellow card,” Madison complained, taking her seat beside Charles.

“Penny did kind of body check that girl,” he conceded.

“Whose side are you on?” She shot him a look.

“Hey, I’ll go down and punch the ref if you want me to.”

Charles gave her that charming smile that made her fall in love with him eighteen years ago. They both knew that if one of them was going to punch a ref, it would be Madison. He was a man who got his way with words, not fists. It was why he’d become one of the top lobbyists in Washington.

“I would actually love to see that,” she replied, tucking a stray strand of copper hair behind her ear. It was a breezy morning in McLean.

“No one is punching anyone. And you need to be careful these days. Do you want to end up on the internet?”

“I’m not that bad! And you’re right, my punching days are over. I have to be a good mom and set an example. I’d probably hurt my hand anyway.” The last part was a lie. It had been ages, but Madison was sure she could still throw a solid jab if she had to.

Charles kissed her. They were still an affectionate couple, to their teenagers’ chagrin. “You can take the girl out of Southie...”

“I think I’ve done a very good job of taking the Southie out of the girl,” she huffed, proud of the fact that her voice carried none of her native accent. She fit right in with all the other neutral, Mid-Atlantic accents in their tony suburb.

“Just don’t forget all of it.” He gave her hand a squeeze.

“Don’t worry. I’ll never be a boring suburban soccer mom.”

Even as she said it, Madison worried that ship had sailed. Too much of her time was occupied with the minutia of being a middle-aged mom in the well-to-do suburbs of Washington, D.C. Too much of her social life was book clubs and pottery, and wine with the girls. Madison enjoyed time with her friends, but maybe that was the problem. They didn’t try to do anything more exciting. She’d spent the last week gathering signatures for the neighborhood association to fight a zoning change that would bring a new

box store to the edge of their neighborhood. Then there were all the Parent Teacher Association meetings and fundraisers, and shuttling kids to activities.

Pushing the kid chauffeur duty off onto the nanny even felt like suburban mom behavior. Yes, they still had a nanny with two teenagers. Both hers and Charles's schedules could be unpredictable. His lobbying work required a lot of late dinners and cocktail hours, and she never knew when some random hotspot in the Middle East would flare up. They needed help, and neither Charles's parents nor Madison's mom was local. She cringed to think of how excited she got when the new Williams Sonoma catalog came.

It felt like only yesterday when she was the girl going to foam parties in Ibiza and doing Ecstasy at raves in London—when she needed the thrill of danger like a drug. The most dangerous thing she did these days was race through camera-monitored speed zones and reach out to a contact in DS&T to erase the record of it before she got a ticket. Sometimes, Madison wondered, *What happened to that girl?*

An alarm vibrated her smartwatch. Madison silenced it. She hated wearing the thing because she understood exactly how dangerous it was, but she needed the help to keep track of everything in her life. It freed her brain up to focus on work. Fucking up there was not an option.

"I need to run and work my shift at the snack bar," she said, kissing Charles. "Come find me when the game is over?"

"Have fun with that," he replied with a smile that said he knew exactly how much she hated being trapped in the tight space, making banal small talk with one of the other parents.

"It won't be so bad. I made sure to schedule myself with Sarah. We'll whip that snack bar into shape."

Sarah Van Holt was one of Madison's better friends in their small community, a fellow traveler who didn't want to completely surrender her

identity to motherhood and middle age. But Sarah was not who Madison found in the snack stand.

“Oh, hey, Maddy,” Bill said. Bill was Sarah’s husband. He was already in the process of taking over for the parents who’d been working the shack for the first shift of the day’s soccer games. “Sarah got hung up and asked if I’d cover her shift.”

“Great,” Madison replied, hoping to mask her disappointment.

Bill Van Holt was an economist who worked at the Fed. Many of the people in their neighborhood worked for the government. He was also one of those men who carried himself like he thought he was the smartest guy in the room. She tolerated him because he was married to her friend, but she didn’t like him much. Bill being a world-class leech, didn’t help

Madison always felt like her friend’s husband paid too much attention to her. Even though she’d become more invisible to most men the further removed from forty she was, Madison still remembered how a man looked at her when he had one thing—that thing—on his mind, and that was exactly how Bill looked at her. She never said anything to Sarah, but her friend knew who she was married to.

“Don’t worry, honey, we’ll bang this right out today,” he said, staring at her chest in that tight t-shirt. She hadn’t known she’d be contenting with him when she’d chosen it, not that men should dictate her wardrobe choices. Yes, the faux-vintage top was snug, and the cotton was thin, but that wasn’t a license to gawk at her.

“I’m not worried. Two professional adults should be able to work a snack stand, Bill.”

“Two government employees. A lot of people would say we can’t do anything right.”

Madison thought about spending the day before poring over the latest intelligence on piracy in the Gulf of Oman, and how high the stakes were.

“Well, they’d better hope we’re all better at our jobs than they think we are.”

The line at the window was building. They couldn’t just banter all afternoon. She was happy to get to work and ignore the way Bill looked at her. He offered to work the fryer and microwave while she took orders. Madison knew that it wasn’t because he was an enlightened male who wanted to do the cooking. It just meant he could stare at her ass in that tennis skirt.

She wanted to flash him the built-in shorts underneath, just to burst his bubble, but she was too busy. *Let him look. It’s harmless*, she thought. She’d long ago learned to let go of the annoyance that men like Bill Van Holt thought she was there to be their eye candy. If it were twenty years ago, and he was better looking, Madison might have even welcomed his attention. But twenty years ago, he also wouldn’t have been her friend’s husband. The built-in disrespect of that made a difference.

They made a good team, she grudgingly admitted. She took orders, fetched ice cream, sodas, and snacks, while Bill dropped corn dog nuggets and fries into the fryer, microwaved cheese for nachos, and heated pretzels. All the while, she felt his eyes on her. Years in the field had given her that sixth sense when someone was watching her. She smiled when Bill cursed at the fryer.

“Is everything okay back there?” she sweetly asked, handing change through the window. They only took cash or Venmo.

“Burned my fucking arm on the fryer. Damn, that hurts.”

“Don’t ice it. Just run it under water if you need to.”

Madison went back to grab a basket of corn dogs that a little boy was waiting for. As she took it, she whispered, “Maybe you’d be more careful if you watched what you’re doing instead of staring at my ass all afternoon.”

“What the hell, Maddy?”

“Don’t insult us both by denying it. Don’t worry. I’ve never told Sarah before, and I’m not going to tell her now. But try to be subtle about it, Bill. Respect me that much.” She took the corn dogs, leaving him stunned by the fryer.

Bill seemed to make an attempt at subtlety for the remainder of their shift, but Madison still felt his gaze. She wondered if he was a nightmare to the women in his office, or if he just saved it for the women in their neighborhood. *Maybe I’m just special*, she thought, laughing to herself. *Would serve him right if I did tell Sarah.*

The snack bar closed about forty-five minutes before the last games of the day ended, to give them time to clean up and get out of there with everyone else. Madison took pity on him and did most of the washing because of his burned hand, letting Bill take care of tallying the register and putting things away.

Madison was at the large, steel industrial sink when Bill crowded behind her. She stiffened, white-knuckling the dish rag. His hands landed on her hips. “What do you think you’re doing?” she asked.

“Well, now that we’re being so upfront about what’s happening...”

“What do you think is happening, Bill?”

He pressed into her rear. She barely felt the bulge in his khaki shorts and rolled her eyes. *I hope he doesn’t think that’s impressing me.* His rough grind wasn’t even rhythmic. It wasn’t that she didn’t sometimes miss a stranger’s touch, but even if she’d ever cheat on Charles—and she wouldn’t—it would be with someone who knew what they were doing. Bill was just a suburban dad trying to feel up one of his wife’s friends in the sports complex snack bar.

“Don’t tell me you’re not interested, Maddy. There’s a reason you’ve never said anything to Sarah.” Bill buried his face in her copper locks and inhaled.

Okay, this is not happening, she thought. Madison dropped the dishrag, found Bill's hand on her hip, and curled her fingers around one of his. Bending the finger back, she dug her thumb in the fleshy part of his hand, her French manicured nail biting into him. He yelped when she wrenched his finger back and tried to step away, but she didn't let go. She used the bent finger to drive him back into a metal rack. Little bags of chips tumbled to the floor. She had total control of Bill with just his finger.

"Does this seem like I'm interested, Bill?" Madison hissed. Her body pressed against him, grinding his back into the unyielding edge of the wire shelf. It was not the way he thought he'd be feeling her body.

"Shit, Maddy, let go," he whined.

"Why do you think you're entitled to put your hands on me, Bill? If you can grab me, why can't I return the favor?"

"I didn't... I'm sorry..."

Madison twisted, and Bill went to his knees. He finally got it, because instead of staring at her tits, which were right in his face, he met her crystal clear blue eyes with a plea.

"Have I made my point, Bill?" Her voice was hard, cold.

He nodded vigorously. She released his finger, and he slumped, holding his injured hand. At least, she hadn't chosen his burned hand. She was being nice. Freed, he stared up at her with venom.

"Fucking psycho. What the fuck, Maddy? Did you learn that in one of your little moms' self-defense classes?"

Madison took a step toward him, and he flinched. She was tempted to tell Bill exactly what she could have done to him if she'd chosen to. Instead, she simply told him, "Stay away from me."

Bill struggled to his feet while she walked back to the sink. She tensed for a moment, wondering if he'd be stupid enough to come back at her, but he was soft, just as she suspected. He was still groaning when Charles came through the back door of the small hut.

“Hey Maddy, are you about ready to...” He looked between Madison and Bill. “...go? Penny is waiting. Is everything okay in here?”

“Yep. I’m good,” she replied, plastering on a bright smile. She dropped the dishrag and grabbed her purse. With a hand on his chest, she kissed her husband. “Bill just slipped and fell, but he’s fine. Aren’t you?” He didn’t answer. “Can you finish cleaning up so we can take off?”

“Yeah, get out of here, Maddy.” Bill was all coiled tension.

Charles warily looked between his wife and Bill again, but let it drop. He knew better than to ask too many questions.

four

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Charles answered emails in bed, but he kept looking over the top of his phone to watch Madison moving around their bedroom as she got ready for bed. After going out for water ice, they'd forced the kids to sit down and watch a movie with them. Charles Jr.—Chazz these days—had the pick, and no one was happy with that. Penny was out about halfway through, and he watched with amusement while Madison forced herself to sit through the end of it. He could see her making a mental checklist of all the things wrong with the dumb plot.

Madison went into the master bath wearing baggy shorts and a tank top and came out in the baggier t-shirt and shorts she wore to bed. *When did we stop changing in front of each other?* he wondered. She was rubbing lotion into her hands when she slipped into bed with him.

"Did you check all the doors and set the alarm?" she casually asked. After sixteen years of marriage, he knew there was nothing casual about it.

"You know I did, Maddy, because you checked yourself before you came up."

She offered a slight smile. "Just making sure. I feel better knowing you remember to do it on the nights I'm stuck at work."

"I always remember. Why? Are you going to be working late next week?"

“Not that I know of, but you know how crazy time zones are. If something goes crazy at one of our embassies, I’ll be stuck.”

“I know.”

“Do you have any client dinners this week?” She set the old-school digital clock she insisted on keeping on her side of the bed. Madison didn’t use modern technology when she could avoid it. Her smart watch had been a compromise he’d forced on her.

“Drinks with Senator Lewis’s chief of staff on Monday. That barbecue fundraiser for Rep. Shelby on Thursday. You’re still coming to that, right? It’s all on the family calendar, by the way.”

“I know. And I plan to be there Thursday. Promise. Unless something comes up with work.”

“I don’t know how so many emergencies pop up when all you do is process visas. Isn’t that done during normal business hours?”

“Normal business hours *their* time. And sometimes the paperwork has to be rushed. It’s not exciting, just pushing paper, but it is urgent sometimes. I’ve told you, I work with a lot of VIPs. The State Department never closes.”

“That’s what they say,” Charles agreed.

Madison always talked about her work in the vaguest of terms, making it intentionally boring. He never questioned it—not to her—but he was pretty sure she did not just process VIP visas for the State Department. Charles was not a stupid man.

“I need to wear a western-themed outfit, right?” She made a face.

“You’ll be a cute cowgirl, hon.”

“My cute days are behind me.” She laughed.

“Not to me.” He kissed her. Maybe some of their heat had faded over the years with the stress of kids and work, but Madison was still as beautiful to him as the day he first saw her across the room at that conference.

She held his hand, played with his wedding ring. “You have to say that. You’re my husband.”

“I only have to say what my clients pay me to say.” Charles laughed. “Now, are you going to tell me what happened with Bill in the snack bar? I know I walked in on something.”

Madison stared at her husband, wondering how much to tell him. Charles Sinclair was a temperate man, but he just might take a swing at Bill the next time they were all together if he knew the man had put his hands on her. She didn’t need Charles to fight her battles. She didn’t need any man for that, although there had been those who wanted to be that for her.

“Don’t freak out, but Bill made a pass at me in the snack bar shack. I handled it. There’s nothing you need to do.”

“I saw the state he was in. You must have handled it pretty well. But where does he get off...”

Charles didn’t finish the sentence, leaving Madison to wonder what was in his head. He got the strangest look before he corrected himself. She’d seen that look before. Sometimes, when they were out and other men paid attention to her—it still happened on occasion—Charles got a look on his face like perhaps he enjoyed other men appreciating what was his.

Most wives would have missed it, but she was trained to focus on body language, on every little detail. She couldn’t just turn that off in her private life, as much as she wished she could sometimes. It only happened in unguarded moments, and Madison would never call him out on it. Charles was not the sort of man who’d discuss such things. She chose to dismiss it instead. Surely, a straight arrow like him was not one of *those* men, although she knew better than that from her work. The most uptight people were often the biggest freaks.

“I don’t know where he got the idea that he could just put his hands on me,” she continued. “He’s lucky I know how to keep a secret. Marci would murder him.”

“He touched you. Touched you how? Maybe I do need to take a swing at him.” Charles sounded genuinely offended, but he got that look again, for just a second.

“Charles, sweetheart, it’s fine. He’s not going to be a problem.”

Madison placed a reassuring hand on his thigh and felt him jump. She smoothly slid lower to grip him through the boxers he always slept in. It was nice to know she still made him hard without touching after so many years together.

Their sex life wasn’t what it had been, but how many couples married for as long as they’d been could say that it was. Maybe she missed the fire sometimes, the way he’d look at her when she showed him her wilder side, but was a mom in her late forties supposed to have a wild side like that? It still felt good when they made love. It was satisfying, comfortable even, and she appreciated Charles being her safe place more than he could ever understand.

He moaned and ran his fingers through her hair. Twenty years ago, Madison would have taken that as a sign her lover wanted her to go down—and she probably would have done it. The gesture was simply tenderness from Charles, but sometimes she missed when a man would press her mouth down there. She smiled at the memory and let it carry her to a spontaneous place.

“Maddy... You don’t have to... I wasn’t...” he moaned.

She flipped back her hair and smiled up at him. “Did you consider that maybe I want to?”

“*Christ...Maddy...*”

His words dissolved into moans when she slipped her lips over his head. Her tongue gathered the salty leak of his excitement and smeared it all over. Madison used to really enjoy giving head, even when it was for work purposes. She couldn’t recall when she got out of the habit, and it stopped being a regular thing with Charles. The way he trembled when she locked

her lips tighter and took him deeper made her tremble to her core. She gripped Charles at the base, but her other hand slipped inside her shorts to stroke her wet furrow. *Did putting Bill in his place today make me hot?* Madison thought the idea was silly, but she found her clit and sucked her husband deeper.

Charles loved the fire he saw dancing in her blue eyes. She opened wider and took more, letting him press to the back of her throat. It was hard to believe this was the same woman who was handing out ice cream to families at the snack bar just a few hours ago. *That asshole Bill would kill to see Maddy like this...to feel her mouth on him...* he thought. Bill thought she was hot, but he had no idea. On a deep, dark level, Charles almost wished Bill *could* feel how incredible Maddy was, just once, so he could know what he was missing and envy Charles. He'd love to see how that asshole would react to it. His cock surged in her mouth at the forbidden thought.

Maddy could have given him a quick one in the snack bar shack, he thought wildly. They could have slipped into the corner where no one would see them from the serving window. She could have gone to her knees and taken care of him so quick no one would even notice they were gone. Maddy is that good. Goddam it, she's that good.

"Uhhnn...damn...Mad...Maddy..."

She hummed into his cock with a soft moan. It made his balls tighten. *Christ, is her hand in her shorts? Maddy's touching herself while she does this? Oh, goddam, I'm not going to last.* It had been over a week since they'd last made love—like this was making love—and he was backed up. Madison's hungry mouth was going to drain him quickly.

Charles's head filled with memories of his wife before the kids, before she was even his wife, when they would meet at the Blue Duck Tavern for lunch and she would slip his hand up her skirt under the table. Or she'd call

him over to her apartment in The Luzon when he could get away for a long lunch. He'd never met a woman like Madison. She just blew him away.

"Maddy...I'm...going to..."

His warning was a low moan. It wasn't altruistic. He wanted to finish in her mouth. A dark vision of Bill finishing in her mouth in the snack bar flashed through his mind. No, he warned her because he thought she'd want to have actual sex so she could finish, too. But she didn't lift off him. She sucked harder.

Madison didn't want to think about what had gotten into her that night. She didn't want to pull off and finish Charles like a lady, or even properly make love. She wanted him to finish in her mouth. She wanted to feel the heat of doing something that had somehow become inappropriate. He got that wild look in his eyes one more time, and he released in her mouth with a final groan of her name.

Her mouth and throat worked to swallow every drop. Some skills never went away. The two fingers rubbing tight circles on her slick clit got her there just after Charles finished. She moaned hard into her mouthful and released him with a lip smack and a final gasp, resting her head on his thigh while enjoying the rapid beating of her heart. Madison felt like something strange and forbidden had passed between them just then, but she couldn't put her finger on it.

"Thanks, hon. That was incredible. I was not expecting that tonight," Charles murmured, stroking her hair.

"Isn't that the best kind of blowjob, when you're not expecting it? I should probably do that more often."

He laughed. "Are you just going to drop to your knees in the kitchen?"

Madison smiled, but with her face turned the other way, he couldn't see it. "Maybe."

"God, I love you, woman."

"Love you, too, sweetheart," she replied, kissing his thigh.

five

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Madison had spent the first three hours of her day staring at SIGINT until she felt like she was going cross-eyed. She was engaged in her work, but there was only so long that she could read communication reports before they all began to blend together. She hit the Fieldhouse gym before work as she always did, but she was unusually distracted that morning. Her settled, predictable life just didn't feel very settled.

Getting up to stroll around the office every so often was essential. She usually walked the campus at Langley during lunch, but that was still a couple of hours away. Hoping another cup of coffee would leave her more alert than jittery, she left her small office for the break room.

Stopping to chat with coworkers on her way to get her fresh cup, Madison was like any other woman working in any other office building in the D.C. area. One of the most jarring things about working at George Bush Center for Intelligence in Langley, VA, headquarters of the CIA, was how stunningly ordinary it was. They had offices and cubicles, and most of the people occupying them were dressed in business casual wear like anyone else in any other office. They all wore lanyards like people in any other office, except that theirs bore the CIA logo.

The only telling sign that this wasn't a regional Amazon office was the complete absence of mobile devices, including smartwatches. Madison's

watch and phone were sealed in a locker far from the SCIF—Sensitive Compartmented Information Facility—floor where she worked. No devices whatsoever were allowed near a SCIF, where the most classified information was reviewed and discussed.

Being out of touch wasn't always a bad thing. She'd gotten a text from Marci on her way into work asking if the Sinclairs were up for a couples night that coming weekend. Madison thought it was too soon after her run-in with Bill in the snack bar and used arriving at work as an excuse to wait before returning her friend's text.

The veneer of normalcy concealed the deadly serious work that the officers at Langley did on behalf of the American people, and it was not where Madison had envisioned her career going when the Agency recruited her in college. She'd loved field work. It gave her purpose and kept her adrenaline junkie side nourished.

She didn't lack ambition and had thought that perhaps she'd end up as a station chief in some exotic locale. But life had other plans for Madison, and there she was, working one of the Middle East desks in Langley. She spent much of her time combing through SIGINT because of her facility with languages and attention to detail. The job being a natural fit didn't make it any more exciting.

Peter White, the Middle Eastern section chief, was waiting when she returned to her office. He was her immediate superior. "I need you to come with me, Madison. The deputy director would like to see us."

"Did we miss something? Is something going on?" She tensed. In all her years working a desk at Langley, she'd never been called to the deputy director's office, but she didn't think such a summons could be for anything good.

"I can't answer that." Seeing her reaction, he added, "I don't know, Madison. Word just came down that Bristow wants to see us. You,

specifically. I'm sure it's not because we missed something. We both know you're good at your job. I don't know what this could be about."

In the cutthroat world of intelligence, Peter White was one of the good guys. Everyone was always looking for an advantage and ways to make it to the next level, even if that meant stepping on someone else to get there. Worse, when an op went wrong or a piece of crucial intelligence was missed, the ambitious scattered like roaches under the light to leave the slowest to take the blame. But Peter wasn't like that. He'd climbed the ladder the right way, and he was one of the few people at the Agency she trusted completely. Peter would tell her if he knew something.

Madison grabbed her folio and pen and replied, "Let's go."

The duo was silent on their walk to the New Headquarters Building. Madison often ate her lunch in the courtyard, staring at the Kryptos sculpture to clear her head, but they didn't pause to reflect. No one kept Deputy Director Bristow waiting. She still appreciated the moment of fresh air.

They were ushered directly into the deputy director's office, and the woman gestured to the large, glass oval meeting table positioned by the large windows that overlooked the campus. Bristow offered coffee, which her guests declined.

"You've been doing some fine work with the COMINT from the Gulf, Ms. Sinclair. The work you do has specifically led to three Predator strikes in the last month on Houthi pirates that have kept the shipping lanes through the Strait of Hormuz clear. It would seem that nothing gets past you."

Deputy Director Bristow spoke casually as she gathered files and a tablet and brought them to join her guests at the table.

"Thank you, ma'am. I'm just doing my part for our country," Madison replied with a humility she didn't feel. She knew how good she was, just as

she knew the deputy director had not called her in for a pat on the back. That wasn't Bristow's way. "And please, ma'am, call me Madison."

Bristow was a political animal, which was how she ended up in her seat. However, unlike other political appointees, she had the background to do the job. She had been a deep-cover officer for years, staying in the field far longer than Madison had. Whispers of her work were the stuff of legend. When she finally came in from the cold, Bristow had been a woman on a mission, making all the right connections on Capitol Hill to ensure her swift ascent. Hard-nosed and calculating, she was known to be a good ally and a worse enemy. Madison admired that about the woman.

"Madison," Bristow said with a nod, taking her seat. There was no reciprocal invitation to call the Deputy Director *Jennifer*. "I'm sure a smart woman like you knows I didn't call you up here to jerk you off for your analysis skills."

"I did not think that, ma'am." Madison offered a thin smile.

"Is there something brewing in the region we should know about?" Peter asked.

"If something were brewing in the region, I'd hope you'd be the one to tell me, Peter. That is your job, isn't it?"

"Then what is this about, ma'am?" Madison asked. She didn't like the way Bristow dismissed her boss.

"I'm afraid I need to ask for your help, Madison. We've had a situation arise that requires your specific set of skills and knowledge."

"I'm at the Agency's, your, disposal, of course."

It was Bristow's turn to offer a tight smile. "I hope you don't come to regret that eager offer. This isn't analyst work, Madison. I need you to go back into the field."

Madison barely stifled her laugh. "I haven't done field work in years. In over a decade. I've only worked outside of Langley a handful of times, and that was coordinating from an embassy. It wasn't field work. Surely, you

have operations officers out there far better prepared to undertake this mission, whatever it is, than I am.”

“But you’ve kept up your qualifications, haven’t you, Madison?”

“We’re required to, ma’am.”

Bristow laughed and spared a side-eye for Peter. “I know how observant you are, Madison. I’m sure you’re aware that not all of your fellow desk jockeys are as dedicated as you are in that regard.”

“Keeping up my field qualifications doesn’t mean I’m ready to go back out there. It’s been... I don’t know how long. Whatever this is, I can’t believe I’m your best option.”

“It’s been sixteen years. Silent Edge was your last field op, wasn’t it? That one ended in something of a mess, didn’t it?”

“The intel wasn’t right,” Madison snapped. “But we did what we needed to and accomplished the mission.”

“And the fallout was dealt with. I didn’t call you up here to rehash old mistakes, Madison. The point is, you are still field qualified, even if you’re a bit rusty, you have the required knowledge of the region, you know the players, and you have other *assets* that we believe are essential to this operation. Believe me when I tell you I’m confident you’re the best woman for this mission.”

Madison was not going to succumb to the ego stroke. She didn’t need it, and she wouldn’t be talked into taking on a mission she was unprepared for. There was a reason she’d left the field sixteen years ago, and it wasn’t just because of the way that last mission with Damien Kane ended.

She still kept tabs on her old partner, but it had been too long since she’d thought about him—something that was inconceivable back when they worked together. No, the way Silent Edge had ended only confirmed what she’d already been thinking, that her time in the field was over. Her life was changing back then, and there were risks she could no longer afford to take.

“What is the mission?” Peter asked. “It feels like you’re being intentionally cryptic, Jen.” He was one of the few people under Bristow who got away with using her first name. They went way back.

“How much do you know about Kharabat, Madison?” Bristow addressed her instead of answering Peter. It felt like Madison’s boss was only there as a courtesy.

“They’re in our region, so quite a lot. They provide a lot of logistics support to the Houthi rebels’ raiding vessels in the Gulf of Oman. That’s why their tankers are never hit. Kharabat is a small, oil-rich nation in the Persian Gulf with an insular, sovereign royal family. And despite nominally being allies, they use their endless Petro-dollars to fund Islamic terror groups all around the world and spread their strict interpretation of Islam.”

“And what of King Zaman al-Kharabati’s sons?” Bristow asked.

“King Zaman Al-Kharabat has four sons and an unknown number of daughters. We don’t know exactly how many daughters, since women don’t really count in Kharabat, of course. They practice a similarly restrictive version of Wahhabism Islam to Saudi Arabia.

“His two best-known sons are Crown Prince Omar bin Zaman al-Kharabati, the heir, and Prince Zaydan bin Zaman al-Kharabati, the youngest son. Omar is as much a hardliner as his father and is known for being even more extreme and pious. Zaydan, however, is better known for his many tabloid appearances. The young prince is hardly an avatar for the Kingdom’s interpretation of Islam. He’s the poster boy for useless nepo babies. His *job*, if you can call it that, is investing for the Sovereign Fund.”

“Thank you, Madison. As I’ve been told, you know your stuff. That knowledge is one of the reasons you’re so qualified for this operation. You know all of the players and minutia of the political situation not only in the Gulf in general, but specifically in Kharabat.”

Madison smiled. “I find their particular brand of hypocrisy fascinating. I’d be happy to work on the operation and advise in any way that I can, but

why would you need me in the field? What is it that you think Kharabat is up to?”

“The information I am about to share is Top Secret. Only a handful of people in our government and MI-6 are aware of it. I don’t need to tell you to keep it to yourself, but I will. Don’t even share it with anyone else who shares your security classification. Am I clear, Ms. Sinclair?”

“Crystal, ma’am.”

“Months ago, MI-6 began hearing whispers about a new cryptographic cipher developed by Russian cyber terrorists. These aren’t the ones who work for Putin, but independent hackers controlled by Russian organized crime and rented out to the highest bidder.

“Supposedly, this cipher is unlike anything we’ve ever seen. It uses quantum computing to slip into virtually any system in seconds, do its master’s nefarious work, and then slip right back out without leaving any trace. There is nothing this cipher can’t crack. So far, they’ve mostly been using it to crack crypto wallets, but they’ve decided they can get a much bigger payday if they put it on the open market. They call it Null:Echo.”

“With all due respect, ma’am, we hear rumors of this sort of thing all the time. This sounds like something out of a spy movie. Chinese, Iranian, and Russian nationals have already proved they can penetrate many of our critical infrastructure systems, often inserting their code undetected. And color me skeptical, but quantum computing is still a pipe dream, and crypto wallets are uncrackable. So even if some version of this cipher does exist, what makes it so special?”

Bristow sipped her coffee and watched Madison through her glasses. She was the kind of pretty that mostly went unnoticed unless she accentuated it, which had been an asset in the field. In her cream blouse and no-nonsense suit, the woman in her early fifties looked like any other business executive. Beneath that bland exterior was a keen intelligence, and Madison felt herself being evaluated in real time.

“I understand your skepticism, Madison. I shared it myself before I saw all the intelligence. Yes, our foreign adversaries have many access points to critical systems in our country, something we’ve sadly allowed to happen. But we know that because we’ve discovered the code in our systems. We catch these bad actors. That’s the point. But imagine if they had access to a tool like Null:Echo?”

“If it exists,” Peter interrupted. He shared his subordinate’s skepticism.

“Yes, Peter, if it exists,” Bristow continued, annoyed with the interruption. Not only is Null:Echo completely undetectable, but with its quantum computing base, there is no algorithm it can’t crack. There is no connected system that it can’t penetrate. Think of the implications for world markets. For national security. We can’t take everything offline. We couldn’t function. Someone with Null:Echo could slip in, crash the markets, and make it look like a panic. They could access critical weapons systems.

“Right now, we’re able to use drones because our communication with them utilizes unparalleled encryption. Imagine if a bad actor could take command of a Predator and turn it on a target of their choosing. With Null:Echo, there would be no proof of a hack. It would appear that the United States launched an unprovoked attack. Think of the conflicts that could be ignited. The wars that could be started.”

“Okay, let’s assume for a moment that Null:Echo is real and not another scam from the Russian underworld. Are you saying that Kharabat is attempting to acquire it?” Madison asked.

“As I’m sure you can imagine, a tool like Null:Echo carries a high price tag. There aren’t a lot of players out there who could afford it. China could swing it, but they share your skepticism and assume that if it’s possible to create such a cipher, they can do it themselves. The Russians could just seize it if they could find it, but they don’t have the money to buy it.”

“King Zaman does. The royal family of Kharabat has more money than they know what to do with,” Peter interjected. “They can’t invest it all in

local construction and foreign assets. But they aren't militaristic. They aren't going to unleash something like Null:Echo against us."

"Not directly, no," Bristow agreed.

"If they put something like Null:Echo in the hands of their terrorist clients..." Madison said.

"Now you're getting it," Bristow replied.

"But the King has too many business interests in the West. Sure, he supports the global jihad on paper, even funds it, but he doesn't want to burn down the world. He has too much to lose," Madison argued.

"The Crown Prince is a firebrand. He hates the way he thinks the West has corrupted his family and made them weak. Omar would burn it all down because he believes Allah will build a better world," Bristow explained.

"Omar must love his brother then," Madison cracked. "And the King is onboard with this?"

"You know the King is slipping, Madison," Bristow replied.

"Rumors are Crown Prince Omar is already running the day-to-day," Peter said.

"Could he—would he—try to pull off something this major with his father still around?" Madison asked.

"We believe he would, and he is," Bristow concluded.

"The mission is to stop Null:Echo from falling into Kharabat's hands. Or anyone's. I'm skeptical it's a real thing, but I understand why we can't take the chance that it's not. I'm still unclear why you need me to go back into the field for this."

Bristow shifted in her chair. "There are particular details regarding the deal between the Kharabatis and the Russians that require a particular sort of officer. Crown Prince Omar has chosen his brother, Prince Zaydan, as the point person on this."

“The fuck-up playboy?” Madison snorted. “Pardon my French. Baby brother represents everything Omar hates. Besides, who’d trust Prince Zaydan to run to the store for eggs, let alone make a deal for the ultimate cyberweapon?”

“We have closely held intel that Prince Zaydan is not the, as you said, *fuck-up* the world thinks he is,” Bristow answered. “It’s all a smokescreen. A cover that allows him to carry out the kingdom’s nastier business in plain sight. He believes in the cause as much as his older brother. He just happens to be one of those individuals with the flexible morality to believe that he’s above the rules. He can have his fun without corrupting his soul.”

Madison smiled. “Like most men with power.” She spared a look for Peter. She wasn’t bashing all men in general, just acknowledging a reality.

“Exactly. And while all of Prince Zaydan’s debauchery is a cover, it isn’t a lie. He’s every bit the playboy he presents to the world. He’s even worse than his public image, actually. The models he *dates* aren’t his true passion. The young prince has darker tastes that he prefers to keep private. Specific tastes,” Bristow said.

Madison began to connect the dots, but it still didn’t make sense. She understood how the particular work she often did in the field could come in handy to hook a dirty little pervert like Prince Zaydan bin Zaman al-Kharabati, but she hadn’t done anything like that in almost two decades.

Her seduction skills were beyond rusty. They were fossilized. Even her husband was thrown for a loop when she wanted to blow him the other night. Besides, the prince was a young man in his twenties. He wasn’t looking for a suburban soccer mom. Madison would be embarrassed to even try and seduce him, even if it was for her country.

“Surely, I’m not the most qualified for this sort of operation. Maybe I have the knowledge, but you need someone with...*fresher* skills,” Madison suggested, almost saying the quiet part out loud.

“That’s the thing, Madison,” Bristow said. “Prince Zaydan enjoys all sorts of women. We know that from the paparazzi, but there is one particular flavor that really gets him going. Perhaps it comes from having such a restrained, cosseted mother, but our young Prince Zaydan very much enjoys women of a *certain vintage*.”

Madison tilted her head and shot the deputy director a look. “*Certain vintage*? Ma’am, are you suggesting...”

“The prince likes MILFs?” Peter blurted out. His cheeks flushed when both women stared at him, and he added, “Zaydan likes older women?”

“Who are you calling older, Peter?” Madison asked. The man looked horrified until she clarified, “It’s fine. I know how old I am and how old he is.” She turned her attention to their boss. “My mission would be to seduce Prince Zaydan bin Zaman al-Kharabati and somehow get my hands on Null:Echo? That seems oddly broad and ill-conceived. I’m assuming we already have eyes on the prince. There must be a thousand other ways to disrupt this deal.”

“The prince spends a lot of time in New York City at the royal family’s penthouse. Outside of London, it’s his favorite party town. Everything is available in New York City, and he’s far from the prying eyes of his family. In particular, Prince Zaydan enjoys seducing the unsuspecting wives of decadent Western businessmen. New York is a target-rich environment for that pursuit. While in New York, he will be meeting with his new Russian friends at Nox Venari. And that is the problem. Are you familiar with it?”

The name tugged at Madison’s memory, but she couldn’t quite pull the details loose. “It’s some kind of private club for the rich and famous, isn’t it?”

“Correct,” Bristow confirmed. “A specific sort of club. This isn’t Studio 54. Nox Venari is a lifestyle club that caters to the most exclusive of exclusive clientele. Being rich or famous often isn’t enough. Applicants are

required to submit headshots, although that requirement is waived for men with enough juice.”

“Because of course it is,” Madison added. “We have to be 10s, but with enough money, a man can be a six.”

“In the case of Nox Venari, I’m afraid we have to be elevens.

Madison laughed. “I’m sorry, ma’am, but I don’t think my family Christmas photo is getting me into Nox Venari, if you’re implying what I think you are. I didn’t even enter the drink cart girl charity auction at our country club because I didn’t want to be disappointed by the bidding.”

“You’re still quite an attractive woman, Madison. You’re underselling yourself. We believe that Prince Zaydan would eat you up, pardon the phrase,” Bristow said.

Madison hung up on the *still*, of course.

“You’re pretty, Madison,” Peter added. “I, uhm, sexy...”

“Thanks, Peter. You can stop helping,” she replied, patting his arm.

“And now I think you see that for all of those reasons, you are the perfect officer for this operation,” Bristow said. “Perhaps, the *only* officer for this operation. We need to get into Nox Venari and get close enough to the prince to have eyes and ears on the deal. We believe you can do that, Madison.”

Madison took a minute to let it all sink in. What the Agency was asking of her felt impossible for so many reasons. For every reason. She wasn’t prepared to go back into the field for any mission. Certainly not *this* mission. Getting that close to a man like Prince Zaydan was too dangerous. Too many things could go wrong. What kind of backup would she have in a place like Nox Venari?

Was there anywhere on earth she’d be more out of place than a sex club for the world’s elite? *She’s insane if she thinks I can seduce a man like Prince Zaydan*, Madison thought. *Pigs like Bill van Holt are the men who chase me now. This must be a mistake. Maybe they want me to train another*

officer? I was pretty good at what I did back in the day. But that day was so long ago.

“So, you’re asking me to come off a desk after sixteen years, get into a sex club, and fuck the details of this deal out of Prince Zaydan bin Zaman al-Kharabati? Am I clear on the mission?”

“I wouldn’t put it so crudely, Madison, but something along those lines. Yes. We believe you’re the best-suited to go in there and get close enough to disrupt this deal and obtain Null: Echo for the United States.”

“Jen, this is nuts,” Peter protested. “Madison hasn’t been in the field in sixteen years. This wouldn’t even be easing her back into it. You want to throw her right into the fire. With all due respect to your skills, Madison, you can’t do this. There are like three ways for this to go right and a thousand ways it can go wrong. Jen, I can’t stand by and let you ask this of her.”

Bristow’s look for him dropped the room temperature ten degrees. “No one is asking for your sign-off, Peter. You’re here because Madison works under you, for now, not because I need you to agree to anything. The only person we need buy-in from is Madison.”

“I can’t do this, ma’am. What you’re asking is too much. There has to be another way.”

The Deputy Director looked at her subordinates like she wanted to toss them out the window. She sighed. “Peter, give us the room. I need to speak to Madison in private.”

Six

. . .

“Are you going to win me over with some girl bonding now?”

Madison asked from the veranda, as she poured herself a glass of water. She got up to stretch when Peter excused himself. She needed to move. The faint buzz she’d always gotten from danger had started—even though she had no intention of agreeing to anything—and she was antsy.

“I wouldn’t insult either of us with that, Madison,” Bristow replied. “Besides, we’re hardly girls, are we?”

“No, we’re not, ma’am.”

“Since it’s just the two of us, please call me Jen. I think we should be on a first name basis for what we’re about to discuss, Madison.”

“This is a terrible idea, Jen, and you know it. There is no way I’m sharp enough for a mission like this after sixteen years out of the field. Even if everything you say is true, there must be a better option than putting me out there. And I find it difficult to believe that you don’t know that. Especially if Null:Echo is the danger you believe it to be.”

“I’ll concede that pulling an officer off the desk after so many years isn’t ideal, but we have time to prepare you to go back out there, and I’m sure that you’ll find those old instincts just kick right back in.”

“Are you going to tell me that being a covert operative is like riding a bike?”

Madison walked back to the table but remained standing beside it. Standing while the deputy director remained seated made her feel like she had an edge. She realized it was an illusion.

Bristow laughed. It was the first emotion—besides annoyance—she'd shown since the briefing started. "Maybe like riding a bike naked while trying to balance a pitcher of water on your head and trying to make a hundred-yard shot all at the same time. Don't think that I don't understand what I'm asking you to do."

"I know you understand, maybe better than anyone here. You were in the field far longer than I was. And you're a woman. And I know it's your job to ask me to do this."

"My field work was somewhat different from yours, but similar in important aspects. Trust me when I tell you I understand the task here. I've also become intimately familiar with your file, Madison. Silent Edge aside, you were unequalled in finding creative ways to accomplish your mission goals. There was a reason you were the Agency's go-to officer for that work."

Madison laughed humorlessly. "Why does it feel like that's a nice way of calling me a slut?"

"You were doing a job that you were well trained for, Madison. No one is implying you were just some easy woman running around out there."

"A slut for my country? A patriotic slut? I own it, Jen. Every bit of it. I know the work I did was important. I know it made my country safer. And there is a long tradition of women using their feminine wiles, their bodies, in service of their country. I'll never be ashamed of what I did in the line of duty."

"Nor should you be. I'm the last person who will judge an officer for doing what they need to do in the field. But would it be wrong to suggest that you enjoyed your work, Madison? That isn't an accusation either. I

believe the best agents find ways to enjoy what they do—whatever that might be.”

Madison stared at Deputy Director Bristow and tried to imagine her as a younger woman, not unlike the one she’d been. She tried to picture the plain brown hair not pulled back into a businesslike bun, but down and flowing, maybe with highlights. She tried to imagine the woman with dramatic makeup and a slinky cocktail dress. Madison could just about see it. The girl-next-door transformed into a vixen to seduce an unsuspecting target. Or perhaps younger Jen Bristow’s angle *was* that she was the unassuming bookish type. The librarian you wanted to bring home to mom but would steal your secrets before she broke your heart—and maybe your neck, if she had to.

Bristow implied that she’d done work similar to Madison’s, but not the same. Madison didn’t even know what that meant. And it all could have been bullshit. A woman like Bristow knew how to lie as easily as she took a breath. Her cover had been so deep that no one even openly speculated about what she’d done. But none of that mattered. Neither of them was the woman who did those things—whatever they were—so many years ago.

“That felt like a lifetime ago. The girl who thrived on the thrill of field work had nothing to lose. I barely remember who she was, but that certainly isn’t who I am now, Jen. My life is completely different. Complicated.”

Madison avoided looking down at her wedding ring, but she did toy with it, using her thumb to turn it on her finger. Charles would never understand the things she may have to do—not that she could ever explain them to him anyway. But she had enough of a taste of it during their engagement—before she traded her old life for the security of a desk at Langley—to know how it tore her apart to do those things behind his back.

“I know all about your...*complications*, Madison. I’ve fully vetted you. Obviously.”

“Then you understand why I can’t possibly say yes to this. There must be another way.”

“If I thought there was a better option, one that gave us a better chance of success, you wouldn’t be sitting here. But you are. You’re experienced enough to know what that means.”

“Why aren’t you trying to intercept Null:Echo on the Russian end?”

“Because we don’t know who has it. The intelligence says it was developed by Glacier Flame, one of the most advanced Russian hacking groups, but they’re so good that we don’t know who the members are or where they’re based. We don’t even know who will be negotiating with Prince Zaydan on their behalf.”

Madison studied Bristow, but the woman betrayed nothing. If she had any difficulty asking for such a risky, life-altering commitment, she didn’t show it. “Are you comfortable pimping me out for Uncle Sam?”

“Come now, Madison, we both know it’s not quite that. I am asking you to undertake a mission, not sell your body for intelligence. Besides, I expect that you’re resourceful enough that you may be able to get what you need from the young prince without having to sleep with him. Play your cards right, get the timing right, and you can get in and get out.”

“It’s possible, sure. I’ve done a lot of missions where the tease was enough.”

“And let’s hope it’s enough here.”

“But if it’s not? If Prince Zaydan is the man you say he is, then it’s unlikely that flashing my tits and a hand on his thigh is going to get me close enough. I’m sure a lot of women are competing for his attention.”

“So, you recognize that he’s a handsome man? That’s good. Perhaps you’ll be able to enjoy aspects of this operation despite your reservations. That always makes it easier. If it comes to that, I know you won’t hesitate to do what’s necessary.”

“I am not looking to *enjoy* a handsome man, especially not a terrorist. I don’t care what he looks like. I also have no interest in cheating on my husband. I am happy at home.”

Madison hoped she didn’t sound like she was trying too hard to convince Bristow. She was happy at home.

“I didn’t imply that you were. But you did enjoy certain *freedoms* when you were in the field. You can’t tell me that you never miss that excitement, even after all these years.” Bristow paused, but Madison wasn’t going to answer. She continued. “And I wouldn’t consider it cheating. It’s simply doing a job.”

“I can’t ask Charles for permission.”

“No, you can’t. He doesn’t have clearance. We have a cover story to explain your absences.”

“That’s so thoughtful, but I haven’t agreed to anything. I don’t see how I can do this. You’re going to need to find another way, Jen.”

“I can’t force you back out there, Madison.”

“I would just resign, and you know that.”

Bristow pushed the files across the table. “All I ask is that you read all of the intelligence before you make a final decision. See if you still think Null:Echo is vaporware. And if you can come back to me and honestly say you don’t think stopping this is worth any risk, I’ll respect your decision.”

Madison recognized the trap, but she couldn’t tell Bristow no. She still planned to refuse anything that didn’t feel like it was world-ending.

“I’ll read the intelligence, but don’t count on it changing anything. I’d start working on Plan B, if I were you.”

“IS IT THAT BAD?” Peter asked, standing in the doorway of Madison’s small Langley office. She didn’t need to answer. Her grim expression said it

all.

“Peter, if this thing is real, and Bristow is right, the intelligence makes a good case for that, it really does change everything. There’s nothing Null:Echo couldn’t get into. No system it couldn’t penetrate. And the worst part is that we’d never know. We don’t even know that they haven’t already. They must have tested it. Supposedly, the Null:Echo package that’s for sale comes with a list of systems they’ve already penetrated. That information could be invaluable on its own.”

“The intel seems legit? This thing is real?”

“We can’t afford to take the chance that it’s not.”

He saw Madison trying to convince herself it was okay to say yes to the operation in real time, and it broke his heart. Not only was she one of Peter’s best analysts, but she was a genuinely decent person in a profession that jaded nearly everyone eventually. The people they worked with at the Agency were all—well, mostly—trying to do the right thing, but the job took a toll. He’d always been impressed that Madison resisted that and kept her soul intact. He wondered if it would survive if she had to go back into the field and do the things Bristow expected of her.

“But you don’t have to be the one taking the chance, Madison. Bristow told you there’s no better option, but we both know there are always plans on top of plans.”

“I really don’t think they would be asking someone like me to go out there and do this if they believed there was a better option. I wouldn’t. Bristow is right. I’ve kept up my field qualifications, but that doesn’t mean I’m ready to go back out there. Not even getting into whether I still have the same judgment or ability to read all the players, there’s the physical.”

“You’re still in great shape. I, er, didn’t mean still. You’re just in great shape, Madison.”

She smiled. “Thanks, Peter.”

He hoped it didn't sound creepy, but realized there wasn't an appropriate way for him to comment on a female subordinate's fitness or appearance. Peter worked hard to intentionally not notice how gorgeous Madison was, but she was one of those striking women who was nearly impossible not to notice.

It wasn't just her striking mane of fiery hair or the curves that tempted a man to break every vow he'd ever made. Her heartbreaking beauty was rendered approachable by the dusting of freckles and her warm smile. She was the kind of woman who demanded attention but was still the sort who'd go down to the local dive bar for a beer.

Madison Sinclair did not carry herself like a femme fatale, but he had no doubt she could turn it on in a snap. Peter understood why she'd been so good at twisting targets around her finger back in her field days. And if Prince Zaydan bin Zaman Al-Kharabati truly did have a thing for MILF types, Madison could have the young man eating out of the palm of her hand. *Hell, he doesn't need to have mommy issues for Madison to seduce him. I'm sure she could get whatever she wanted out of him, anyway*, Peter thought.

"There is no way I am as quick or sharp as I was back in the day. I'm fully trained, but do I still have the muscle memory? I don't even want to think about what my reaction time would be in a real life or death situation. Bristow didn't give me a timeline, but I doubt I have months to train."

"It doesn't sound like this is a combat assignment, Madison," Peter said. "I believe Bristow is relying on your *other skills*." He'd overseen plenty of field ops in his position as the head of the Middle Eastern desk, but somehow Peter still flushed under the collar when discussing her section skills. She smiled as if she found it cute.

If she were in a better mood, Madison might have played with Peter's discomfort, but her decision weighed her down. He was a good man, and she hoped that if she said yes to this mission, he would be there to lean on.

If she said yes. She needed to believe it was still an open question. At least Peter's slight blush lightened her mood a little bit.

"I might be more comfortable if it were," she replied. "I don't know if I remember how to be that person. I don't know that I want to find out. I haven't done anything like that since Charles put his ring on my finger."

"We have married field officers, men and women, who do what it takes to get close to their targets every day, Madison. It's not uncommon, and I don't believe you would have to feel guilty if you did whatever the job required. It's not the same as cheating."

Madison had been wrestling with that all afternoon. She understood the wisdom of Peter's words. She didn't consider field officers to be cheaters, but knew that being with another man would feel like adultery. The act was the same, even if the motivation was pure. She'd crossed those lines when she first met Charles. She told herself she'd never do it again.

"Maybe he would give me his blessing if he knew the stakes," she said.

"You can't tell Charles, Madison."

"I know that. Of course, I know that. But it would be an easier decision if I could discuss it with him. Charles is one of the sharpest men I know. I trust his judgment implicitly."

"One of the hardest parts about this job is how much we have to keep hidden from the people who love us. We can't go home and unload about the terrible day we had. When we witness unspeakable things, we just have to carry it ourselves.

"We don't have to luxury of sharing it with a partner—even if we wanted to. Some of the things we've seen, especially during the War on Terror? I would never put those in Cheryl's head, even if I could. It wouldn't be fair. The people who survive this and retire to have normal lives find a way to compartmentalize. The ones who can't unravel over time."

"I know Charles could handle it. He could carry it."

“But would it be fair to ask him to? Let’s say that Charles had Top Secret clearance, and you told him everything about Null:Echo, and he understood the gravity of the situation. I’m sure he would tell you to do it. He’d understand the import of the mission. But does that mean he’d like it?

“Could he live with the things that would put into his head? Or, every time he closed his eyes when you were off working, would Charles picture you in some dark room of a sex club with a young Kharabati prince all over you? I don’t know many men who could carry that, Madison.”

“Could you? If you were him, I mean.”

Peter weighed the question. It was one he’d never confronted. His wife of twenty-nine years, Cheryl, was a high school principal. When he left Langley, Peter led an entirely normal life. He’d mastered the compartmentalization. But he considered it. He considered having a wife like Madison, stunning, sexy, going out there and seducing another man. Would it matter if she were doing it for her country?

Christ, Peter thought. *Why am I going there?* The thought of Madison using her charm to get in *deep* with Prince Zaydan bin Zaman al-Kharabati caused blood flow in all the wrong places. The forbidden thought was hot, but it made him uncomfortable to imagine this married mother of two that way, and he was just her superior. Peter knew he would lose his mind if Madison were his wife.

“I don’t think most men could,” he finally answered. “We’re just not wired that way. Men are generally jealous creatures. We don’t want to share what’s ours.”

Madison laughed. “You sound like a caveman when you put it that way, Peter. Charles and I made a commitment to each other, but he doesn’t own me. However, I take your point. I would kill any woman who tried to lay hands on my husband, so I understand what you’re saying. If I have to do this, it’s probably better that he doesn’t know—that he can’t know.”

“See, Madison, you’ve already rediscovered the violence in you.”

She thought out how she took Bill down in the snack bar over the weekend and hoped she wasn't as rusty as she feared. However, dropping a soft suburban dad was not the same as taking out a Kharabati security agent or a Russian mobster.

“It sounds like you've already decided to say yes, Madison.”

“I don't want to, Peter. But I don't see an alternative. If I don't, and Null:Echo slips away, I won't be able to live with the consequences. Perhaps literally. I don't want Penny and Chazz to grow up in that world.”

“Then find a way to make peace with it. At least, you'll make Bristow happy.”

Madison laughed. “Well, that alone makes it all worthwhile.”

seven

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Madison was home late, and Charles knew right away that she'd had a day. He was used to his wife not talking about work, and he knew better than to pry too hard, but something was on her mind. It had been ages since he'd seen her so tense and distracted.

The kids didn't seem to notice, but they didn't notice much about their parents since becoming teenagers. Penny was a good kid and had always been close to her mother, but as she got older, the sixteen-year-old had begun to chafe under Madison's high expectations and constant vigilance about the dangers of the world. Penny was slowly withdrawing from the tight bond mother and daughter had always shared. Chazz just had his nose buried in his phone like every other fourteen-year-old boy.

Charles heated up leftovers over her protests and was pleased when Madison wolfed down the lasagna and salad their nanny had made. She could get so into her head, especially with work, that she often didn't realize she was hungry until food was put right in front of her. She was through a second glass of wine before she finished eating, more proof that she'd had a particularly hard day.

Madison ran up for a quick shower while Charles cleared her dishes. She'd barely said two words, letting him prattle on about his meeting to convince the rep from Tennessee that allowing expanded online betting on

college football was a good thing. She usually badly feigned interest, but Madison pretended to be absolutely fascinated, like she needed the distraction. After dinner, he expected her to stay upstairs and hang out in bed, but she came bounding back down, changed into a tank top and comfy shorts, and asked if he wanted to watch TV. Charles wasn't going to refuse that offer. It felt like they had too little time to just hang out.

Castaway was their favorite show, and they were several episodes behind. They had to catch up if they wanted to be current when the season finale aired. The program, one of those strand-strangers-on-an-island-together reality shows, had something for both of them. Madison loved the sense of adventure and the politics between the players. Charles loved the negotiating and the drama. And looking at sexy women in bikinis or their underwear, even when they were grimy from weeks on the island, wasn't so bad either.

The show was down to six people on a combined tribe. That was his favorite part of the show, when people in an alliance had to start eating their own. He saw it every day in D.C., and watching ordinary people behave the same way restored his faith that people working in the Capitol weren't especially evil. They were just like everyone else. They were just under enormous pressure and had access to power. Charles acknowledged that a million dollars was a lot of money, but on *Castaway*, people from all walks of life were willing to stab each other in the back for far less money than the people in Washington dealt with every day.

"Do you think Brittani will offer up Rocco to stay on the island?" Madison asked. She had her legs tucked up under herself and leaned into Charles.

"Probably. I know they've been tight since day one, and they've got that flirtation going, but if she doesn't turn on him, she might be the next one voted out. Besides, I never bought that the flirting was serious. She's way too hot to fall for that nerd."

“Hey, they’re young and single. Anything can happen.” She ran her nails across his chest, lightly scratching through his old Yale Law t-shirt in that way that always gave him goosebumps. “Besides, you got me, didn’t you?”

“I was not a nerd! I rowed crew back in college.”

Madison laughed. “Exactly my point. A sporty nerd. A fit nerd.” She paused to rub his chest. Charles was proud that he’d kept himself up. The four days a week at the sporting club in the city was worth it. He didn’t know many other guys in their mid-fifties as fit as he was. Besides, with a wife as hot as Madison, he didn’t have a choice. There’d always be someone trying to take his place—as Bill Van Holt proved. She added, “A very fit nerd, but still, you weren’t exactly a ladies’ man when I met you, honey.”

“Okay, maybe I didn’t have much game, but did I really need it?” He pointed to the words on his shirt. They both laughed.

“Did you want a woman who was only after you for money and comfort?”

Charles feigned a confused look. “Isn’t that why you’re with me?”

“Oh yes, honey, this is the life I always dreamed of.”

Her words dripped with sarcasm. Part of him always wondered about that. Most people would give their eye teeth to live like they did—Charles knew exactly how privileged they were—but he suspected Madison was bored with their comfortable suburban existence, that it was more of a trap to her.

She cut off his musing by pulling him closer by his t-shirt and attacking with a hungry kiss. Her insistent tongue made his head spin. Charles wasn’t complaining, but something had gotten into her ever since Bill made that pass in the snack bar.

“I really just wanted you because of what a stud rower you were. You know that, right? I saw those arms and I got wet in, like, two seconds.”

“Maddy!” he complained, only half-shocked.

“Don’t you like hearing that you made me wet?”

Charles smiled. “I’d probably feel better if you weren’t using the past tense.”

She kissed him again. “Sorry, hon. You definitely still make me wet. Feel free to check.”

“Maddy...”

Madison took his hand and started putting it down her shorts, but paused. “Unless you don’t want to?”

His hand was far enough down her shorts that he felt the damp heat between her thighs before he even touched her there. But she paused, denying him. The playful tease annoyed him, but Charles was not a man who’d just force his hand down her shorts, so he didn’t fight her when she withdrew his hand.

“Okay, let’s watch *Castaway*,” she announced.

Charles never went completely soft. His wife’s familiar weight against him was as comforting as arousing after over sixteen years together, but he didn’t easily forget Madison putting his hand down her shorts, nor that she was clearly aroused before he even touched her. He tried to focus on the show and not the increasing signs that she might be having some kind of midlife crisis. He was pretty sure women got those, too.

Madison was not the sort of woman who would get off on her best friend’s husband making a pass at her, so Charles didn’t seriously consider that was the cause of her sudden, odd behavior. Some women certain liked that kind of attention, and he was sure she didn’t mind the knowledge that a man wanted her on some level, but she didn’t want that. Certainly didn’t like that Bill presumed he could make a claim on her.

But something had reignited a spark in Madison that had been sadly absent in recent years as they’d become settled into their comfortable suburban existence. It only highlighted that her spark had dimmed

somewhere along the way, and he hadn't noticed. Charles had to take responsibility for that.

Have our lives become too routine? he wondered. *Maybe we need a weekend away?* One thing he was sure of was that boredom was the death of any marriage, and he didn't want that.

When he was younger, he had a tendency to date women for their looks first. Arm candy was important. They had to be hot, but classy. He came from an old-money family in upstate New York, and whoever he dated had to be acceptable to his parents. He dated a lot of pretty, brittle, WASPy blondes. In private, they ran either missionary-in-the-dark cold or so dirty they even shocked him. He'd never known a woman like Madison, and certainly never thought someone as vibrant as her would be interested in someone like him.

Charles certainly liked the idea that other men desired what he had. What man wouldn't be proud to have a woman like Madison on their arm? He'd been complimented on his earlier girlfriends, but the kind of attention his wife drew was very different from those women. Madison wasn't just gorgeous and sexy. She was smart, with a sharp wit.

He'd heard her complain about becoming invisible after turning forty, but Charles didn't believe it. He still caught the looks men gave her, and it made him prouder than ever. Maybe she'd become a forty-eight-year-old suburban mom, but she was the hottest mom in their social circle. Perhaps she didn't get attention from hot, younger guys she'd received back in her single days, but Madison was as desirable as ever, and he loved it. Maybe a little more than he should.

Sometimes, in his unguarded moments, Charles had dirtier thoughts about his wife. They'd never had explicit discussions about their pasts—she shut that down early, and he knew it wasn't his business—but Madison had implied a wild, hedonistic past. Maybe it was because her hot past was left

to his imagination, but sometimes he pictured his wife in sexy situations, surrendering to her desires in the dirtiest possible way.

Often, those fantasies didn't even involve him, like thinking about Madison going to her knees in the snack bar. The idea of his wife cheating was abhorrent to Charles, but these fantasy scenarios where she was just too horny to resist drove him mad. He knew he was only secure enough to indulge them because he knew Madison would never cheat. The thought of her *actually* being with another man left him in a cold sweat.

"Do you remember that showmance from last year? Chelsea and Todd?" Madison asked.

They were about two-thirds through the episode, after the immunity challenge and into the scheming part. Madison knew Charles always found this section of the show boring. The machinations were edited to be highly deceptive to make the episode's elimination more dramatic—especially when it was clear who was going home. And it was very obvious that week. It was the perfect time to feel him out. She couldn't get the Null:Echo mission out of her head. Every time she looked at her husband, Madison thought, *How can I do this to him?*

"I do. She was kind of bookish, and he was one of those strutting alpha male types?" he replied. Chelsea's girl-next-door quality had her particularly appealing, but he never liked Todd. Being somewhat uptight and bookish himself, Charles did not care for the strutting studs of the world.

"Everyone kind of thought she was just playing him because she had to change her game when her first ride or die got voted out. They had chemistry, but Chelsea just seemed a little shady."

"There was something else, wasn't there? Something outside of the show?" Charles had no memory for gossip. He certainly didn't care what went on with contestants outside of the show. Some of them made money doing personal appearances, which amazed him.

“It turned out that Chelsea was married all along. That meant she was definitely leading Todd on to win the game, or she was cheating on her husband. Neither is a good look.”

“I do remember something about that. You’re right, neither is flattering, which is why I’m baffled that any sane person would want to go on these shows. It’s pretty hard to win if you play a clean game that doesn’t make you look terrible. Although I think you could do pretty well, Maddy.”

“You think so?” Madison was surprised. He enjoyed watching *Castaway*, but she knew he didn’t hold the contestants in high regard.

“Well, you’re athletic, so you could definitely handle the challenges and the endurance parts. A month on an island would be a breeze for you. Everyone likes you, so the social game should be easy. You fit in with any group you’re tossed into. It’s like you’re a chameleon sometimes.”

Madison gave him a look. Of course, she could blend into any situation. *Have my spy skills bled into my personal life?* “Are you saying I have no personality? That I just become whatever the people around me expect?”

“Not at all,” he defensively replied. “I just mean that you fit in everywhere, with everyone.”

“It sounds better when you put it that way. Good save, hon.” She laughed.

“I know you know what I mean. And lastly, you’re hot, and being hot usually gets you pretty far out there.”

“I think you’re biased because you’re my husband, but thank you. Does that mean you wouldn’t mind if I leveraged this alleged *hotness* to win the game, like Chelsea did? I don’t think just being hot is enough. I’d have to use it to wrap men around my finger.”

She trailed her nails down his bare arm, giving Charles goosebumps. *Is she teasing me with that or is it in my head?* he questioned. He didn’t think Madison would do the things he remembered Chelsea doing, but the possibility turned him on.

“Are you talking about leading some guys on to get a million dollars? Or would this be a full-blown showmance? Did they ever get to the bottom of what Chelsea was actually up to?”

“She made some confessions on the live reunion show, but she and Todd were coy about what actually happened. They’re not admitting to anything on national TV anyway. But a million dollars is a lot of money, and you know how competitive I am. The temptation would be strong to do whatever the job required.”

“Are you saying you’d sleep with someone else for a million dollars? Everyone has a price, or so they say.”

Charles was shocked that Madison would actually suggest it, and that the forbidden possibility was pulsing life into his cock. All those fantasies came rushing into his head. *But I’d never want her to do any of them. That’s insane. Maddy wouldn’t do any of those things. Would she? No, Maddy would not sleep with another man on national television for a million dollars. She’s just messing with me.*

“We’re talking about a reality show here. I’m not suggesting I become a call girl and hook some ridiculously wealthy client. Maybe everyone does have a price, but does anyone seriously know what it is? But if the prize was big enough, or if the sacrifice was worth it... Who can say? And I’m not suggesting I’d ever just go sleep with some guy. But if the stakes were high enough, could you, I don’t know, look the other way?”

Madison had an odd look when she asked the question that made Charles think she was at least half serious. *Is she really asking if there’s a situation where I’d be okay with her fucking someone else? Isn’t the answer obvious?*

“A million dollars is a million dollars, but we don’t really *need* the money. I can’t imagine I’d ever say, *sure, Maddy, go screw that guy. Just make sure the check clears.* But you’re talking stakes, not money. Like what, if one of the kids needed a kidney or something? I have no idea,

Maddy. The very idea is so far-fetched. But sure, I guess there's some situation where I'd have to be okay with an infidelity. Yeah, sure."

Charles couldn't suppress his chuckle. The scenario really was crazy. And yet, putting any possible morbid situation aside, when he thought about Madison being so desperate—or dedicated, depending on one's perspective—that she'd give her body to another man, his cock throbbed harder. He was fully hard in his shorts. *It's only because there's no possibility of this happening*, he reasoned. Even the hypothetical made him slightly nauseous, despite his erection.

Madison was surprised by his reaction. Her husband was a traditional, conventional man, not the sort of man who she expected could ever live with his wife being with another man for any reason. And she saw that. Charles looked queasy, and she knew it was because he was trying to really imagine her with someone else.

But he was also a pragmatist and understood that everything had a price. *Everyone* had a price. He wouldn't be a lobbyist if he weren't. It was an outlook they shared, even though they each worked in very different fields. And he wasn't above having Madison slip into a cocktail dress and swanning her around an event because someone he needed to get close to might appreciate her beauty. There was a reason he wanted her at that fundraiser later in the week. Charles would never pimp her out to close a deal, but they were on the same spectrum, weren't they?

Madison couldn't disclose a thing to Charles because he lacked the required security clearance—this mission was eyes-only anyway—but she could try to gauge just how morally flexible he might be. He had a security clearance because he had worked for the Justice Department before his career as a lobbyist, but his clearance didn't touch something on the level of Null:Echo.

Pragmatism wasn't the only thing Madison saw on his face, and that was what truly surprised her. No one else would have caught it, but she'd

been with the man for over sixteen years, and she was trained to observe people. Charles thought about the possibility of Madison *doing what it takes*, and it excited him. Surely it was on some wild fantasy level, like if she dressed up as a sexy librarian for Halloween, but it was there. He was wearing the loose, dad, cargo shorts he'd changed into after work, but she was sure she saw a twitch there. *Is this conversation actually getting him hard?*

"It wouldn't be infidelity if you knew about it," she said, knowing she could never tell him what she might have to do.

"I suppose that's true," he agreed. Madison saw his wheels turning, but didn't believe he was actually considering the reality of her doing it.

Madison laid her hand on his thigh but didn't touch where she knew he was hard. Not yet. "So, hon, which part turns you on? Is it the idea of me running around in a bathing suit and flirting in front of the world? Or is it something more?"

"I don't know what you're talking about, Maddy."

Charles groaned when her hand slid higher and she gripped him. He flushed. "Something has you turned on. Care to enlighten me?"

eight

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“Maddy... It’s not...”

“Not what I think?” She smiled. She didn’t want to be mean, but she wanted the truth and knew her husband didn’t talk about these things easily. Fortunately, she was trained in extracting information. “What do I think?”

“Maddy...please...”

She put his hand on her, sliding it up her—mostly—flat tummy to the curve of her breast. His fingers tightened into her softness, rougher than usual in his desperation. Madison was braless and felt the heat on his grip through her tank top. Her nipple pebbled through the thin cotton. Their little game—whatever it was—turned her on as much as it did him. She kissed him, teasing with her tongue.

“Please, honey, just tell me.” Her grip tightened, and she slowly stroked him through his shorts, pleased when she felt a wet spot. *If I can’t seduce the truth out of my own husband, I have no chance with the prince. My skills can’t be that rusty*, she thought.

“Maddy...I know you never would...don’t want you to...but...the thought of you...putting it out there...”

“It’s okay, honey, that’s hot,” she whispered, kissing him again. “I love that you can think of me that way.”

Charles looked surprised, and she was pleased by that. For a moment, she'd thought he had her all figured out. Maybe she had let too much of her other side slip through. But his surprise proved that he hadn't quite decoded her yet. Madison still had some secrets.

"It is? Maddy...you need to stop that or we...ohhh...need to go upstairs..."

"I don't want to go upstairs," she insisted, pulling at the canvas belt that held his shorts closed.

"Maddy..." Charles weakly moaned. He thought she'd lost her mind, but he didn't try to stop her.

Shooting a look at the doorway, he helped Madison unwind the belt from its simple metal buckle, allowing her to get to his button and undo it. Something was clearly going on with her, but that was not the time to discuss it. Clear thinking was impossible when her hand was in his shorts, wrapped around his shaft. He moaned her name, thinking few women he'd known went for it the way Madison did when she really wanted it.

"It's okay to have dirty thoughts about me, even though I'm your wife. Don't you miss when we used to be more...fun?" she whispered it all between kisses while she tried to yank his shorts over his hips.

Did we stop being fun? he wondered. Charles didn't want to admit they had, but sex on the living room couch had stopped happening years ago. He just chalked that up to being parents. Doing it where the kids could walk in on you was just irresponsible, but if Madison wanted to duck down and give him another quick blowjob—and unfortunately, he was pretty sure it would be quick—he wasn't going to stop her.

Madison would have loved surprising him with another blowjob, but she wanted more. Beneath the worry and the moral wrangling, she'd felt a distant buzz of excitement since her sit-down with Deputy Director Bristow. The possibility of getting back out in the field and finding her seductive side again reawakened a spark inside her. That restlessness she couldn't

place had built into a low throb in her core, and Madison needed to satisfy it. She wiggled out of her loose shorts.

“Maddy, hold on, we really can’t do that here,” Charles complained. He still stammered when she swung a leg across his lap and straddled him. “Maddy... Wait...” He only stopped when she sank onto his cock. “*Ohhh... sweet lord...Maddy...*”

“*Stop...ahhh...worrying and thinking...and fuck me...Charles...*” she moaned, tightening around him.

“*Maddy...dammit...*”

It was an offer Charles couldn’t refuse. He gripped her hips, urging her to move faster on him. Her sheath rippled around him. Madison had always been able to do things with her body that he didn’t even know were possible. When they met, she had the flexibility of a circus performer. He suspected she still did, but he didn’t get to experience it the way he used to. Her hips rolled in a steady rhythm, pulling him as deep as possible. The pulsing heat made him dizzy.

Madison leaned back, hands on his shoulders, using his hands on her hips as an anchor. Her eyes were closed, and her pale, freckled cheeks were flushed. Her hips parted, venting increasingly urgent moans. Charles had the strangest feeling that her mind was somewhere else—maybe seducing strangers on *Castaway*—and this wasn’t entirely about him. Or maybe he was projecting because his mind went there, too.

Charles pushed the tank top over her tits, letting them sway freely as she rocked on his cock. He massaged them, thumbs teasing over her nipples. “*Oh god...yes...Charles...honey...like that...ahhh yesss...*”

Her hips worked faster, thrusting onto him harder. He was right. Her mind was a jumble. She was there with him, making love to her husband, but so many other things flitted through her brain, making her need burn hotter. Madison thought about strutting into that sex club, every eye on her, peeling the slinky black cocktail dress she’d chosen right off her body. She

imagined her younger, slimmer self, the version who could definitely pull it off. The version who craved that attention and knew what to do with it. Madison imagined the young prince tripping over his words when he saw her. And then she imagined his strong, dark hands on her pale body...

“Maddy... ohhh god...yeah...yeah...”

“Harder...harder...fuck me...Charles...fuck me...harder...ohhh god...don’t...stop...”

Madison pulled his face into her chest, and he smothered her tits in kisses before latching onto a nipple, suckling. Her nails dug into his shoulders, and she whimpered, *“Harder, honey...harder...”* Her unspoken desire was, *rougher! Give it to me rougher!*

Charles thought she was doing all the fucking, but he lifted his hips from the couch, used whatever leverage he could muster to drive up into her. The motion threw their rhythm off for a moment, but then he found it, and their bodies were crashing together. Madison moaned louder, desperate, and his balls tightened. His tongue wildly flicked her nipple, and she tried to cram more of her breast into his mouth, smothering him.

“Maddy...the kids will hear...” his warning a garbled moan.

“Charles...honey...I...” She was so close, she nearly moaned, *I don’t care.* And then she was there. A quick shriek escaped her lips.

Acting without thinking, he slapped a hand over her mouth. They were not going to be caught fucking on the couch by their teenagers. Madison threw her head forward, pressing her mouth hard against his hand, and he swore she was trying to scream louder. Her entire body trembled while her pussy locked around him like a vice, hips grinding, like she demanded his release. She got it. With a shudder, Charles finished, his cum rocketing up into her. The orgasm was so intense, it felt like every bit of him went into Madison with his essence, like she was a Succubus, leaving him drained.

“Ohmygod, honey... That was so good...” she gushed, pressing her sweaty forehead to his when she peeled his hand away from her mouth. She

put it on her tits, encouraging him to keep touching her. Every nerve ending was alive. Madison was already up for round two. Her hair had come out of the messy ponytail she'd put it up in, and she lifted it to cool the back of her neck.

"It was something," he panted. "It was incredible, Maddy." Feeling her pulse around him gave Charles shivers, even though he'd gone soft, but he still shifted her off him. "But we've got to cover up."

Madison smiled and paused to kiss him. "They know we've done it at least twice. Besides, my reflexes are very good. I can hide if I hear them coming."

"Have you lost your mind, Maddy? We do not want to get caught like this." He pulled his shorts up from his knees.

"I feel like a teenager again myself," she laughed, pulling her tank top down and retrieving her shorts from the floor. "Remember keeping an ear out for your parents coming down the basement stairs?"

"I didn't, uh, do that sort of thing."

She winked and kissed him. "You would have if I'd known you."

Did she get high tonight? he wondered. Of course, she didn't. Government employees were drug tested. But something was going on. This was the wild, reckless Madison Byrne he'd met almost twenty years ago, not the Madison Sinclair he was married to. That Madison was a force of nature, but Charles didn't know if his fifty-four-year-old self could handle her.

"Wouldn't you have dropped dead if you'd walked in on your parents having sex?" he asked.

"Who says I never did? Well, my parents were divorced, but my mom had a lot of *friends* who dropped by at night."

"I know you had a couple of stepfathers, but you've never mentioned that."

“It was between the stepdads. I don’t know if that’s the sort of thing you bring up about your mother, but yeah, I guess she was fun. I never walked in on them, but our row home wasn’t big, and the walls were thin.”

“That must have been weird...traumatic.”

“I wouldn’t go as far as traumatic, but I guess it was formative. You never overheard Winston and Kitty having fun?”

Charles recoiled at the thought before ruefully smiling. “I’m pretty sure the last time they had sex was when they conceived me. With each other, anyway...” His father was discreet, but Charles wasn’t a fool. He’d heard the whispers, as had his mother. Kitty Sinclair responded by taking a lot of *tennis lessons* at the club.

“Well, thank you for indulging me. I think a little danger every once in a while is a good thing,” she said.

“Maybe next time, we can at least go down to the basement. Less chance of discovery there.”

“You’ve got a deal. Feel free to drag me down to the basement any time you want to ravage me. But right now, I think you should follow me up to the bedroom and see if we can keep this going.

Madison put an extra swish into her hips as she walked to the steps, leading Charles like the Pied Piper. *Castaway* was forgotten.

nine

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Madison sat in front of Doc Zimmerman's desk and stared at his view of the courtyard while waiting for the physician to return. He'd been the man who signed off on agents' field fitness for as long as she'd been at the Agency. A short, slender, haughty man with a ring of now-gray hair, the doctor was efficient, but not unkind. He just didn't coddle his patients because his decisions often meant the difference between life and death.

The testing had gone fine, in Madison's opinion. There were always the little noises and looks that left one questioning, but no one rushed from the room. Her examination included a thorough gynecological exam, which wasn't great, but she understood why. Her own doctor said everything was fine down there at her last check-up four months ago. The cardiac stress test left her more winded than she'd expected, but she wasn't concerned. She'd showered afterward at Langley's onsite gym and was changed back into her everyday work clothes.

This is all moving so quickly, she thought. It had only been three days since she'd been called into Bristow's office. She informed the Deputy Director the following day that she would take the mission. Madison wanted to discuss guidelines, but Bristow told her they would get to that.

"Ms. Sinclair. Madison," Doc Zimmerman said, coming into the office. He took his place behind the desk.

“Good to see you again, Doc.”

“I don’t have much occasion to examine Langley analysts without a specific cause. And usually that has to do with mental fitness. I see the reports from The Farm for your annual field certification come across my desk, but only to sign off on them. It’s not often that I see someone who’s been on a desk for so long looking to go back into the field. I imagine that many of our current operations officers were in elementary school the last time you did a field mission.”

“Thanks, Doc.” She smirked. “I’d like to think I can still keep up.” She thought about that stress test.

Doc Zimmerman gave her a wry look. “Sometimes experience and judgment count for more than good reflexes, Madison. I think you’ll be fine.”

“I’m not worried,” she lied, thinking about how she nearly tripped over the cat and tumbled down the stairs last week.

“Everything is within normal ranges,” he said, flipping through her file. “Your blood work came back fine. Cholesterol is excellent. Blood pressure is fine. Resting heart rate is excellent.” His eyebrows went up. “Your hormonal levels are surprisingly robust for...a woman your age.”

Madison smiled. “I know I’m on the wrong side of forty-five, Doc. You don’t have to worry about hurting my feelings.” *For a woman my age... Ouch*, she thought.

“We did a full pelvic due to the nature of this assignment, and you’re all clear there. I’m not privy to the nature of your assignment, but I’ve been told it will likely require you to be sexually active. Obviously, if condoms are feasible, you should insist on them. Even so...” He paused to read a page in her chart. “I see here that you are not currently using any form of birth control. Understandable, I suppose,” he paused for a quick smile, “*at your age, however...*”

“My husband had a vasectomy after our son was born. We knew he only wanted two children.”

“Right. Details of your personal sex life are irrelevant, Madison. I’d suggest you begin both a hormonal birth control regimen and implant an IUD, just to be safe. I’d also like you to start a PrEP course to protect against an HIV exposure, and we’ll do regular STD screenings and pregnancy tests, however unlikely the latter may be.”

Madison nervously laughed. “I get it, Doc. You don’t have to keep telling me I’m past my prime.”

“I’m sure this is all very difficult. Ideally, you have time to prepare yourself before a mission, not only physically, but mentally. It doesn’t sound like that’s the case here, but you’re a capable officer. They wouldn’t ask you to undertake this mission if you weren’t.”

Or if young Prince Zayden didn’t have a MILF fetish, she thought. I guess he didn’t have a wet nurse. She sighed.

He looked up. “Is something wrong, Madison?”

“Sorry, Doc. It’s just all so real. I’ve barely wrapped my head around the fact that I’m doing this, and now we’re talking IUDs and PrEP and STD screenings. This all makes the things I might have to do very real.”

Doc Zimmerman held up a hand. “Please, no details, Madison. I can’t know what this mission involves.”

“I know that, Doc. Just... We didn’t talk about these things back when I started with the Agency, not like this.”

Madison always had an IUD during her first stint in the field, and STD screenings were mandatory. The CIA didn’t want an officer sidelined by an illness or a baby conceived on a mission, but back then, she just never seriously considered those risks. She was a single woman—mostly—and her life was her own.

She did what she did on missions because it had to be done. Sometimes she enjoyed it, but that was never the point. Madison wasn’t prudish in her

personal life either, but she was always safe there. Making a bar hook-up wear a condom was not the same thing as trying to insist a Russian arms dealer slip one on. All of that had been a lifetime ago, and she wasn't the young woman who'd go home with a cute guy from the bar. She never even considered safe sex in her marriage because Charles was as solid as they come. He would never cheat on her.

Doc Zimmerman sighed. "It's a different world, Madison. Operations officers still need to take the same risks, but we try to do better in protecting them now, when we can. We don't just expect you to take all the risks, put your body on the line, and just live with the consequences. At least, we try not to."

Female agents often had to bear the costs of their field work in a way their male counterparts didn't. She'd heard the horror stories. They all had. The Agency had a special doctor to take care of *problems*. Madison routinely carried the Plan B pill just like many other female agents. *I guess I will again*, she thought.

"I appreciate your frankness, Doc. I really do. I'd probably be more worried if you were trying to hold my hand."

"I know promiscuity is not in the nature of most women, even if it is in the line of duty. That's why so few are suited to do it. Asking you to put your body on the line in that way may be even worse than putting your life at risk. But you're suited to this. We have a battery of psychological tests to prove it. I know you'll be fine once you put yourself in the proper mindset."

"Thanks, Doc," she said, thinking, *Wow, that is some of the most patriarchal bullshit I've heard in a long time.*

Madison never had a problem being *promiscuous* when she was a young officer. Everything was different now because she had a husband and children. She hoped a male agent would feel the same way about having to go out and sleep with a stranger.

“I’ll file my report and arrange for the prophylactics we discussed. Unless you need anything else, you’re free to go.”

She left Doc Zimmerman’s office in an even stranger headspace than she’d entered and wondered how she was going to get through this. He was right about one thing. She had to get her head straight if she was going back into the field.

“ARE YOU READY, MADISON?” The disembodied voice was harsh in the spare anteroom. Harsh fluorescent lighting added to the disorienting feeling. She knew it would only get worse from there. Three loud *beeps* sounded, and the course was live. She gripped her pistol tightly and shouldered through the door.

The narrow corridor was dimly lit and painted a dark gray to make visibility even more difficult. Doors lined both sides of the hallway. Her heart raced, and she focused on controlling her breathing. Not only did she need to clear the rooms, but she had to be prepared for whatever might come through one of those doors before she reached it. The end of the hallway dog-legged to the right, promising further surprises around the corner.

The urban warfare tactical course was designed to simulate a hotel or apartment building. Madison hadn’t been on that course since she was in the field. There was no reason for her to be since she’d been riding a desk. The course, and others like it at The Farm, the casual name for the CIA’s training center at Camp Peary, were generally reserved for Clandestine Service Trainees and field officers who needed to brush up on their skills. Running the course was not part of her regular testing to maintain her field certification.

The first doorknob on her left gave when she turned it. Not all the doors would be unlocked. She mentally counted to three and burst into the room. The bright lights were disorienting. Madison cursed as she realized she could have been shot three times over in the time it took to blink her eyes clear. Fortunately, the room was clear. The sense of relief was supposed to take her guard down. She allowed a deep breath and moved to the next room across the hallway.

Madison directed a hard kick at the lock, and the thin door flew into the room as the jamb splintered. Even with her heavy boot, she felt the shock of the impact up her shin. A large, masked man swung out into a doorway on the other side of the room, and she swiftly put three rounds from her Glock 19 into his center mass, where they bloomed into splotches of red dye. A round from his weapon splatted blue on the wall to her right. The recoil and noise felt real, but she did not fire live rounds. The Simunition was safe and effective. She swept the rest of the room with her weapon, but it was clean.

The next two rooms were cleared with ease. The first was nearly pitch black, and she was forced to pick out her target with the dim light from the hallway. The other was cluttered, forcing Madison to expend extra rounds as she hit a chair and a pillar when trying to shoot her targets. At least she had cover as return fire came her way. She only narrowly avoided shooting a civilian. Her racing heart made Madison feel like was would float out of her body at any second. She didn't remember real-life and death situations rattling her so.

Music kicked on in the next room, startling her. Adrenaline spiked, and she reacted without thinking, snapping up the Glock and putting the red splat of a hit right into her target's face shield. But the distraction was too much. While she frantically swept her weapon from side to side, a thick arm went around her neck. She hadn't cleared the room behind her.

Madison propelled them backward, slamming her assailant into a wall that shook with the impact. The training course was well-built, but it was

not a real structure. He grunted and tightened his arm around her neck. His other hand came up to cover her nose and mouth. She tried to hammer back with the butt of the Glock, but only made glancing contact. The weapon was dropped, so she had both hands free to fight back. Shooting him was impossible while they grappled.

She pulled at the arm, but his grip was like iron. Her airflow became restricted, and her panic rose. She wouldn't be killed on the training course, but she could be choked unconscious if the course instructor didn't end the exercise, and she would be given every opportunity to fight her attacker off before that was done.

The assailant grunted when she drove her heel into his shin. He grunted, and she clung to his restraining arm, lifting her feet while clinging to his arm with both hands. She turned as he stumbled forward, swinging more momentum and ensuring she didn't land with him on top of her. They hit the floor in a heap.

Her knife slid smoothly from the sheath on her boot. The blade was rubber and telescoped into the handle, but it was coated with dye from the sheath to mark where she stabbed and slashed. The impact with the floor loosened the grip on her neck enough to provide wiggle room, and she twisted and slashed at the man holding her as he tried to roll onto his back and pull her with him.

The struggle was very real. Madison scrambled when the assailant began to tighten his arm at her throat again and try to pin her other arm against her body so that she couldn't stab back at him. The angle was all wrong. She could not make contact with the blade and fight off his restraining arm. *He's going to choke me out. I'm going to lose*, she thought.

Madison slammed her head back into his face. Neither her ponytail nor his face shield softened the blow enough to protect the man.

"What the fuck?" the man cursed. Technically, there were no rules on the training course, but intentionally trying to injure someone was frowned

upon.

She took the opportunity she'd given herself, *stabbing* her knife into his leg. He cursed again, and his hold loosened enough for Madison to pull away and elbow him in the ribs. Slipping free, she rapidly turned and slashed the knife across his neck, leaving an angry red dye mark. His eyes were furious behind his mask.

Her Glock was gone, and she rose to her feet with the knife ready. Multiple shots impacted her chest, leaving bright blue splotches on her white t-shirt. The impact of the Simunition rounds stung, like being hit by an over-pressurized paintball gun. A klaxon sounded, signaling that the simulation was over. Lights came up, brightening the room.

"Dammit!" she cursed. "Shit!" Madison panted and wiped away at the sweat on her forehead.

"I was there the whole time, waiting to see if you could work your way free."

It was the man who'd shot her. He pulled off his face shield and mask to reveal a handsome Hispanic man in his twenties. "But hey, you should be proud that you got away from Dentiger there. He's a beast."

"Fuck! You'd better not have broken my nose." That would be Dentiger, who tossed his creased face shield away and stood. He peeled off the mask underneath it, smearing blood on his dark face.

The man was huge. She'd failed the course, but Madison was proud that she'd gotten free of the mountainous Black man. He looked like he wanted to take a swing, and he might have, if she weren't a woman.

"Sorry, I didn't mean to hit you that hard," she said. "It was just...heat of the moment."

"Shoulda fuckin' choked you right out." Dentiger glared at her.

"Now, now. Don't be a pussy," Bristow said, walking into the room. Dentiger looked like he was going to snap back until he realized who'd

commented. The Deputy Director seemed amused by his anger. “Sinclair did exactly what she was supposed to. Well, right up until she got shot.”

Everyone stared at Bristow with shock. The Deputy Director of the CIA rarely visited The Farm, and certainly not to the tactical training course. It was akin to Jeff Bezos walking into an Amazon warehouse in Indiana.

“Let’s reset and go again,” Madison said, closing her fists so Bristow wouldn’t see her hands shaking.

“Let’s go again. Let’s do it,” Dentiger replied, looking like he couldn’t wait for another shot to take Madison down. That look from the large, handsome man stirred something deep within her.

“I think that’s enough for one day. Could we have the room, boys? You should probably go to medical and have that looked at anyway, Dentiger.”

Dentiger looked like he wanted to tell the Deputy Director to go fuck herself, but instead, he filed out with the other man. Bristow asked Madison if she needed a minute, observing that the redhead was flushed and wired. When Madison shook her head, Bristow gestured to one of the old, worn armchairs decorating the room and took the other for herself. Madison didn’t sit. She paced.

Bristow’s cool, confident demeanor was a contrast to the nervous energy that came off Madison in waves. Neither woman had been in the field in years, but Bristow seemed like she could step right back out there like no time had passed, while Madison was all over the place. If not for her recognizability, the Deputy Director seemed better suited to the proposed mission than Madison. Bristow studied the redhead like she was still evaluating if the analyst was suited to go back into the field, even though the decision had been made.

“I assume you were watching on the monitors,” Madison said. “I told you that sending me back out there is a terrible idea. I’m not ready, Jen. I’m going to get killed out there.” She noted Bristow’s thin smile. “I know that’s

not the worst outcome for you, losing Null:Echo would be, but I don't want to leave my children motherless."

"Losing an agent is always terrible," Bristow began. "But yes, the mission is the most important thing, and I wouldn't be sending you out there if I didn't think you were the best person to secure Null:Echo."

"Maybe if I had time to come back here and retrain—to acclimate myself."

"We both know there isn't that kind of time, Madison." She gestured around the room. "And this doesn't concern me. If you do your job right, you'll never have to touch a weapon."

"I'll just have to do other things..."

"Which, hopefully, you're more up to date on." The insinuation about Madison's sex life hung between the two women. Such a comment would be grounds for a lawsuit in any other context. When Madison didn't dignify it with a response, Bristow continued. "And it's not like you'll be out there alone. A handler will be running the mission. There will be support people every step of the way. And you'll have a partner on the inside. Your legend requires that you have a husband, obviously."

"Who?"

"You'll be meeting the team tomorrow when we have our first briefing. I'd rather not hand out information piecemeal. My point is that you'll have support, and your partner is an experienced Clandestine Service officer. Everyone, including you, Madison, knows what they're doing. I think as soon as you stop overthinking everything and go back into mission mode, you'll be fine. Even this stuff..." Bristow waved her hand at the room again. "Even the combat skills will come right back to you, if you need them. Some things are just embedded in us, Madison. They don't go away, no matter how much we may want them to."

Madison wanted to believe her as much as she feared Bristow was right. She needed to believe she could still handle herself in the field, but she

didn't want to discover that the woman she'd been, the one who'd throw herself into bed with strangers with abandon, who seemed to get off on the danger, had always been there lurking just under the surface.

She'd made a choice sixteen years ago to be someone different. Someone better. What if it was all a lie? She already felt a tingle of arousal from grappling with Dentiger. Danger had always been her drug. Back in her training days, she may have even offered to make up for hurting him. Perhaps Madison's biggest fear was that once she unleashed that side of herself again that she'd never be able to bury her again.

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The nondescript conference room was in an even more secure section of Langley than the SCIF floor that Madison ordinarily worked on. The windowless room contained a long, oval table. Its beige, undecorated walls were barren, but for a large monitor on the narrow wall opposite the door.

The room was dim, but small, directional gooseneck lamps were placed at each of the seats around the table. Four of those seats were occupied, leaving two empty. Bristow was the only familiar face—at first glance anyway. After a moment, Madison recognized her new friend from the training course the day before. The large Black man whose nose she'd nearly broken sat at the table, his thick arms crossed. Peter White was not invited to the briefing.

“Madison,” Bristow said. “We’ll be getting started shortly. I’d prefer to save the introductions until we’re all here.”

“Of course,” she replied, taking a seat.

The others around the table regarded Madison with suspicion or disdain—particularly Tayshawn “Tay” Dentiger. His dark, hostile eyes spoke volumes. *You don’t belong here. You’re over the hill. I don’t know why we’re here backing you up.*

Cassandra Gale, a bright up-and-comer from the cyberterrorism section seemed to be evaluating Madison to decide if the older woman could really

do this. The bright MIT graduate was on the fast track, and overseeing an operation like the retrieval of Null:Echo could make Cassandra's career. Or completely detail it if Madison wasn't up to the task.

The other member of the team, Manny Sanz, was tech support, on loan from DS&T. He eyed Madison like he couldn't wait to see her seduce Prince Zaydan. Everyone on the team was at least a decade younger than Madison. She wondered if they'd found her a younger "husband," too.

She smiled at everyone and took one of the remaining seats, setting the leather folio that Charles had bought her for Christmas down on the polished surface of the table. Madison didn't want to dwell on her insecurities, but the skeptical looks increased her fears that going back into the field was a terrible idea. She was staring at her pink, freshly manicured nails when the final member of the team burst into the room.

"Sorry, I'm late, chief. It took a minute to clear security to get down here."

Madison froze at that voice. It was deeper and gruffer from sixteen years of wear and tear, but she'd know it anywhere. Looking up, she was confronted with a slightly disheveled Damien Kane. His presence was such a shock, she thought he was a mirage.

"Should have accounted for that, Mr. Kane. Close the door and take your seat," Bristow instructed.

Kane closed the doors, activating a white noise machine in the hallway. The SCIF conference room was soundproof, but they didn't take chances with the most sensitive intelligence. He only seemed to register Madison's presence when he sat. Even then, he did a double-take, like he wasn't sure it was her. *Have the years made me unrecognizable?* she wondered. *I haven't aged that much.* The vanity felt silly at such a weighty moment.

"Now that everyone is here, we can get started," Bristow said. "Would you all introduce yourselves?"

One by one, they went around the table giving their names, but no details. Madison introduced herself with a little wave that felt silly, but she was still reeling from Kane's presence. He somehow gave his name with a swagger that shouldn't have been possible in a simple sentence.

Madison grudgingly admitted that he looked good. Worn, but good. He still had most of his thick hair, although it was shot with gray and started further back on his forehead. His stubble was thick enough that she could tell that it was dusted with gray, too. Even with the loose black denim shirt over his white t-shirt, Kane looked as fit as he'd ever been. Overall, the man could be described as ruggedly rumped. If one were asked to describe someone who'd been a CIA field agent for over twenty years, and they didn't picture a James Bond type, it would be Damien Kane.

"Are we keeping you from something, Madison?" Bristow asked, glaring across the table.

"No, ma'am. I'm following. Yes, I've read all the files. I don't need to be briefed again," she replied defensively. She felt everyone's eyes on her—everyone's except for Kane's. He seemed to purposely *not* look at her. She'd only barely been following along, her mind filled with the last time she saw Kane in London.

"So, we're all clear on the importance of obtaining Null:Echo for the United States?" Bristow asked. "This isn't just about keeping it out of the Kharabatis' hands. It's about keeping it from everyone else."

"Yes, we want to make sure we're the only ones who can exploit the world's most dangerous hacking tool," Kane dryly commented.

"No one said anything about our government exploiting Null:Echo, Mr. Kane. The point is to make sure that no one can."

Kane scoffed. "Does anyone really believe that if we hand the United States government a weapon like Null:Echo that they won't use it? They're not just going to drop it down a hole and forget it exists."

“That’s not our decision, or our problem. We’re solely concerned with obtaining it,” Bristow said.

“But he has a point. Null:Echo is scary,” Manny added. “Are we just keeping it safe, or are we planning to deploy it ourselves? I’m not sure anyone should have that kind of power.”

The tension around the table notched up. What had seemed like a bland corporate team meeting took on the air of a group that knew they were making a Faustian bargain. Everyone sitting at the table was experienced enough to know exactly what a Pandora’s Box Null:Echo could be.

“Do you think Null:Echo is something we can just toss into the shredder, Manny?” Cassandra Gale asked the question, fixing the team’s tech guy with every bit of disdain she could muster. She was a *means justify the ends* kind of woman, like Bristow. The Asian woman was beautiful, but cool and direct, like the engineer she’d once planned to be.

“That cat is out of the bag,” she continued. “If the Russians have developed something like Null:Echo, it’s only a matter of time before someone else—*everyone else*—develops their own version. The Russians developed atomic weapons only four years after we did. The Brits followed just a couple of years later in 1952. Then France. Then China and India. We not only need to understand how this thing works, but we have to have this weapon in our arsenal if it comes to needing it.”

“None of that means we shouldn’t be asking the question,” Kane replied. “I like to have some understanding of what I’m involved in.”

Dentiger chuckled. “All of this is above my pay grade, man. Tell me what needs to be gotten, and I’ll get it.”

“I was like that once. But I’ve got too many years behind me to just be anyone’s blunt weapon anymore.” Kane’s smile didn’t reach his eyes. He finally spared a look at Madison, as if she understood what he was saying.

“If the stakes are too high for you, Mr. Kane...” Bristow said.

“I never said that. I think I’ve proved I’ll do whatever it takes to get the job done. I just like to be clear on the job.”

“The job—*your* job—is to keep Null:Echo out of the hands of terrorists. That’s all you need to worry about, Mr. Kane.”

“I’m sure your experience is an asset, Damien, but you’re here because we thought you’d be a good fit for this particular mission,” Cassandra interjected. “However, I don’t want anyone on this team who isn’t a hundred percent.”

“Oh, trust me. When I commit, no one goes harder than me. Isn’t that right, Madison?”

“Do you have to antagonize them, Damien?” Madison replied, his smirk taking her right back to their days in the field together.” She may as well have told him, *Don’t be an asshole*. “I think we can all agree that Prince Zaydan cannot get his hands on Null:Echo. What happens to it afterward is out of our hands. We can only control what we can control.”

“And you were always so good at control,” he shot back.

“Can we get back on track?” Bristow asked. It wasn’t a question. “Cassandra, since you’ll be running point on this operation, can you go over the broad strokes of how we plan to acquire Null:Echo?”

“Right. Thank you, ma’am,” Cassandra replied. “We are now commencing Operation Scarlet Phantom. Since everyone has read the briefing, I don’t have to go into deep detail. Here are the broad strokes.”

She clicked a remote, and a paparazzi image of Prince Zaydan bin Zaman al-Kharabati came on the screen. He was tall and broad, at least as built as either of the men in the briefing. The black shirt, open lower than any normal man would dare, and the blue blazer were custom-tailored to show off exactly how fit he was. His thick black hair was raked straight back, almost forming a pompadour. His beard was thick but impeccably groomed. Even in a photograph, he carried himself like a man who knew he could have anything he wanted.

“The prince. Girls around the world love him, and the royal family regards him as a black sheep. He’s more interested in brunch at Granger & Co. than he is in making morning prayers. He spends the family money like it’s endless. Because it is. But we know that’s not the full story. We’ve seen under the sheets, if you will.”

Cassandra spoke about Zaydan with obvious distaste. A frivolous playboy was the antithesis of everything she believed in, even if she knew he was a terrorist underneath that hedonistic exterior.

“The prince divides most of his time between London, Hong Kong, and New York. He only seems to return to the Kingdom when summoned. Right now, he’s in New York City, and that is where he will be connecting with the Russians selling Null:Echo on behalf of Glacier Flame.”

“Do we know who these Russians are yet? I didn’t see that noted in the file,” Madison asked.

“We do not. But we’re working on it,” Bristow interjected. “Obviously, one of the more powerful syndicates, but the dynamics shift so frequently over there that it’s nearly impossible to keep track of who’s on top.”

“The who doesn’t matter to us. We just need to be there and be ready,” Cassandra continued.

“I’m more than ready,” Kane said, bravado washing away his earlier reservations about the mission.

“Like I said, just tell me where to go and what to grab,” Dentiger added. “And who to shoot.”

“We know you’re ready to put a bullet into whoever needs shooting, but let’s take the testosterone down a notch, gentleman,” Bristow said. “This mission will be more about finesse than brute force.”

Cassandra clicked the remote again, and the screen filled with the image of a stylized silver fox head. Beneath it, the words *Nox Venari*. “If you all did your homework, you know that one of the prince’s favorite haunts is

Nox Venari. That is where he will be meeting with the Russians, and that is where we will insert to disrupt the deal.”

Madison had been so stunned by Damien Kane’s presence that she hadn’t done the math and realized why he was on the team. Someone would be playing her husband on the mission. Tay Dentiger was only in his early thirties, but she didn’t think they made a believable couple for obvious reasons. The realization that she would be playing house with Kane was unsettling. Getting too close to him had always been dangerous, and she had so much more to lose now.

Dentiger laughed. “A kinky sex club for the rich and famous is more fun than most of the places the Agency sends me. The Wizards will give us eyes in there, right? I’m looking forward to watching those feeds.” The Directorate of Science and Technology was often referred to as the *Wizards of Langley* inside the Agency.

“Yes, we have several options to conceal video surveillance and have comms up on Madison and Damien,” Manny confirmed. “Al-Kharabati chose the club because security is so tight and any type of recording device is prohibited, but the owners of Nox Venari aren’t prepared for our tech.”

Madison was disgusted by the way Dentiger looked at her. *Is he picturing me having sex in the club?* She still hoped she’d find a way to avoid going that far.

“Down boy,” Bristow commented.

“The depraved way these people conduct themselves is nothing to get excited over, Tay,” Cassandra told him. “Prince Zaydan is particularly despicable. His country is busy suppressing its women in the name of Islam while he’s drinking and screwing his way across the Western world. There’s a special place in hell for men like him, if you ask me.”

“Unfortunately, hypocritical men in power are as old as human civilization,” Madison replied. “The wealthy and powerful will always live by their own rules.”

“Hey, let’s not bag too much on men. I don’t think women in power are any better,” Kane said. “Look at Marie Antoinette. Al-Kharabati is a scumbag, but don’t tell me you don’t see the allure of a place with no limits like Nox Venari. Sounds like you can find a pleasure for every taste, if you can find a willing partner to entertain it.”

“I guess you’re enthusiastic about some parts of this mission after all,” Bristow replied.

Kane grinned, sparing a glance at Madison. “I’m prepared for whatever sacrifices the mission may require.”

Everyone at the table could read Madison’s body language, but not everyone showed the detachment Bristow modeled. Madison’s apprehension was the yin to the yang of Kane’s excitement. Manny had the grace to appear uncomfortable about whatever he might witness between the field agents, but the other men seemed downright giddy about working in and around the sex club—particularly about whatever may be required of Madison. Cassandra’s apparent disgust only grew, but it wasn’t because she was protective of Madison. Everything about Nox Venari and its patrons was alien and immoral to her.

“As you all know,” Cassandra continued, ignoring the men, “Madison and Damien will be entering Nox Venari as a married couple, Melissa and David Richardson. David made his money in venture capital. Melissa was a teacher but left that profession to be a mother and pursue her charitable interests. Now that the Richardsons are empty nesters, they’re exploring their kinky side. Melissa should be catnip to Prince Zaydan.”

“And you’re convinced he’ll keep me close, even when he’s talking to the Russians? Why wouldn’t he dismiss me when it’s time for business?” Madison asked.

“Because of the way he views women,” Cassandra answered. “Women are not a threat in his world, as long as they remember their place. And

you'll be a conquest. He'll want to show you off to his new Russian friends to demonstrate how easily he gets what he wants."

"Which is why it will be important for you to make it a challenge for him, Madison," Bristow added. "You need to be a worthy conquest."

Madison laughed humorlessly. "Did you expect I'll just spread my legs for him? I intend to be very hard to get."

"But not too hard to get," Bristow warned.

"Do you remember what it was to be gettable?" Tay asked, smirking.

The man was still angry about how she took him out on the training course, but that didn't give him an excuse for the jab. Before she could hit back, Kane intervened.

"Madison knows how to play the game better than anyone," he said, giving Tay a warning glance. "No one needs to worry about her end of it. She'll work al-Kharabati like a puppet."

She was torn between telling Kane that she didn't need him to stand up for her and that he didn't know her anymore. The Madison Byrne he knew was long buried.

"Anyway, those are the broad strokes," Bristow said. "You all have your briefing packets. I wish we had more time to plan and prepare, but we don't get to set the timetable. We need Damien and Madison in place by next week."

"That's awfully sudden," Madison complained, panic rising.

"We need you embedded with Prince Zaydan before the Russians arrive, and our intelligence suggests that will be sometime toward the end of next week, or perhaps early the following one. The deputy director and I both believe it's best if you have the prince's undivided attention before the Russians arrive," Cassandra said.

"And my role is to sit back like some cuck while this guy beds my wife?" Kane asked. "I'm not sure how believable that is."

“I’m sure you’re more than capable of playing whatever role we give you, Mr. Kane, just as Madison is,” Bristow replied. “However, David Richardson will be seeking his own pleasures at Nox Venari. You have read your legend, haven’t you?”

“Of course. This isn’t my first rodeo.”

Tay’s look and snort clearly said, *Yeah, we know, you old fuck.*

“Don’t we have to apply to Nox Venari for membership?” Madison asked.

“The Agency has already filed an electronic application on behalf of the Richardsons. You and Damien have an interview appointment on Friday,” Cassandra informed her. “One of the reasons we chose Damien for this mission was your, uhm, *familiarity* with each other. I’m confident you two can convincingly get through the interview. Afterward, we’ll spend the weekend working on your chemistry.”

“Friday? I have obligations this weekend,” Madison objected. Penny had another soccer tournament. Chazz was performing in his school musical on Saturday night. She couldn’t think of a plausible reason to miss it. He knew her work sometimes required odd hours, but she promised him she would be there.

“Cancel them, Madison. You know the job. Whatever else you have going on takes a backseat. Null:Echo must be the priority. Is that clear?” Bristow asked.

“Crystal.”

“It’ll be fine, Madison. We’ve got this. It’s like riding a bike,” Kane said.

Madison wasn’t reassured. She fell off her bicycle and broke her arm when she was eleven. She didn’t try to get back on it again until she was fourteen, and it felt like she had to learn the skill all over again.

eleven

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Bristow watched Madison work the banquet room like a natural. In another life, with a different start that didn't include an absent father and a loose, alcoholic mother, Madison may have been a successful politician. Washington D.C.'s loss was the CIA's gain.

The charm that came naturally to the redhead was something that Bristow had to work at. Working the D.C. cocktail circuit to get ahead took a toll on her. Madison was made for it. Bristow had used her body in the field when required, and it worked because she was an attractive woman, but she couldn't twist a man the way Madison could.

Watching her smile and chat, and flirt with various congressional aides, donors, and lobbyists was a marvel to behold. Her husband, Charles, was a nice man, an attractive man, and he knew how to backslap with the best of them, but he was stiff. Madison was his secret weapon. Bristow assumed he knew that. *He'll have to get along without her for a while*, she thought. *We need her talents. I need her talents*, she thought.

Bristow wondered if Charles Sinclair knew who he was married to. She'd read Madison's file from cover to cover before selecting her for the mission and knew everything there was to know about the Sinclairs, which meant he knew Charles had a security clearance high enough from his time at the Justice Department that Madison could have shared some of her

background with the Agency. She was supposed to maintain the cover that she worked a dull job at the State Department—so dull that no one would torture themselves by asking questions—but Bristow wasn't a fool. She understood that spouses shared things. She had when she'd been married.

There were things Madison wouldn't want Charles to know. Bristow had done things she would never share with another soul. Not many husbands would—or could—understand the sorts of things Madison had done in the line of duty. The killing and violence were understandable, but the other stuff? Madison spending her twenties and early thirties seducing half of the world's most awful men was much harder to comprehend for a man.

Bristow got it because she was a pragmatic woman, and the men who'd sent Madison out there to do it had only seen her as a tool, but no civilian man could accept it. Even the men who'd used Madison to do their dirty work wouldn't accept *their* women doing the same.

Madison didn't look like that woman at her husband's side as she smiled and touched Rep. Shelby's arm. In her short, black Western dress, with its pearl snaps down the front and floral embroidery, and her white cowboy boots, she looked like any of the other well-off wives doing anything they could to support their husbands at a political fundraiser. She even had her lustrous copper hair tucked under a cowboy hat. The girl from Boston had become Annie Oakley.

Bristow knew that Madison fit in just as well with the Pilates-sculpted moms at the soccer games and school events in their tony Virginia suburb. That was her superpower. Charles couldn't suspect that his charming wife was also a woman who could pull Rep. Shelby into the cloakroom, go to her knees, and get the old man to agree to anything she wanted.

Still, watching her play this role so perfectly, Bristow wondered if Madison could become the woman she'd need to be to enthrall Prince

Zaydan bin Zaman al-Kharabati at Nox Venari. Maybe she had changed, and the cloakroom was out of the question now.

The small ballroom was packed. A three-piece band, comprised of a fiddle player, guitarist, and drummer, played background music from the small stage. Rep. Daniel Shelby had been in Congress for decades, which meant he had a lot of juice, and a lot of people owed him favors. As he prepared to enter his fourth decade in the House, people lined up to write checks to help him do it. A who's who of Washington's top lobbyists, corporate representatives, and attorneys had set aside how ridiculous they looked playing cowboy and came to kiss the ring. Even Archbishop McAllister was there to fete his old friend and drink the congressman's expensive bourbon, although His Grace had skipped the cowboy hat and boots for his expensive loafers and frock.

Rep. Daniel Shelby looked like a caricature of an aging Texas politician in his giant cowboy hat and tan, western-style suit, although he looked more like he'd stepped out of an oil company boardroom in Dallas than off a dusty ranch. He was a tall, thick man, his gut straining against his platter-sized silver belt buckle. His fleshy face was perpetually crimson, and tufts of white hair escaped the cowboy hat.

Madison was very aware of how Rep. Shelby and Archbishop McAllister stared at her tits when Charles introduced her to the powerful men. She'd spent a good five minutes calculating how many snaps to leave open at the top of her dress while getting ready for the fundraiser, and thought she'd chosen an acceptable amount of cleavage. Charles was surely aware of it too, but then he never minded it when men ogled his wife—especially when he stood to benefit from it. He was a good man, but he got how the world worked.

His Grace, in particular, seemed to be imagining all the things he'd like to do to her back at the rectory. He was as short as Rep. Shelby was tall, but just as round and red-faced. His snowy hair was closely-cropped beneath

his crimson zucchetto. What would the archbishop do to her if she were pliant? She smiled as she pictured her boots discarded in the center aisle of the cathedral and her dress tossed onto the altar. There had been a lot of priests on the south side of Boston, and she'd learned to avoid them at an early age.

"It's always a pleasure to see you, Maddy," Rep Shelby said, eyes straining behind his glasses to see how deep he could see into her cleavage. She leaned in just enough to encourage him. It would be funny if his head tilted forward enough to make his hat and the ill-fitting toupee he always wore slide off his head.

"I can't tell you how thrilled I am that you're running for another term, sir," she lied, feeling herself start to match his northern Texas drawl and pulling it back. "We need good men like you in Washington."

Rep. Shelby took her hand in his sweaty paw and laid his other on her exposed wrist. She swore she could feel his old cock twitch with life from the simple touch. She'd seen Mrs. Shelby, who spent most of her time back in the great state of Texas, so she understood his enthusiasm for her. She doubted Mrs. Shelby would.

"How many times do I have to tell you, Maddy? It's Dan."

"I guess we just don't see each other enough for me to remember, *Dan*. I promise I'll try harder." If she poured on the sugar any thicker, she'd give the man diabetes.

"We need to do something about that. I should have you—the two of you—out to the house for dinner."

"That would be great, Dan," Charles said. "There are a few things I've wanted to talk to you about."

"Always about business, Charles. Good thing you have this little lady here to keep things interesting, son." Rep. Shelby moved close enough for Madison to smell the sickly sweet bourbon and brisket blending on his breath.

“Make sure to call me if you invite them over, Daniel,” the Archbishop interjected. “We can make it a foursome.”

Madison threw up a little in her mouth. Even her long-dormant, dirty streak was reviled by the thought of those old hypocrites’ hands all over her. Although the idea even surfacing meant that participating in Operation Scarlet Phantom was already having an effect on her. The Archbishop tore himself away from staring at the snaps on her dress like he was praying for the Lord to pop them open, to smile at her. His creepy smile somehow made it all worse.

“We wouldn’t want to pull you away from the archdiocese, Your Grace,” Madison said, placing her other hand on his arm. Her revulsion for the man didn’t stop her from toying with him. Perhaps it was even the reason that she did.

Archbishop McAllister reminded her of that old French pig she seduced in Provence. The bastard had been selling arms to terrorist groups. He’d been too easy to twist for her to even enjoy the game. Back in her field days, Madison often enjoyed the challenge, even when the men had been disgusting. The Frenchman had been as eager as the archbishop was now, but she suspected His Grace was even more depraved than the arms dealer.

“Nonsense, child. I always have time for my flock, although even priests need the night off. I wouldn’t be there in my official capacity.”

Rep. Shelby laughed. “Trust me, Maddy. His Grace knows how to cut loose. Let’s get something on the calendar, Charles.”

Only Madison caught her husband’s *sorry* look. “Of course, Dan. I can have my assistant get in touch with yours,” Charles said.

“Yes, have your girl call mine,” Rep. Shelby replied.

And with that, Madison was out. “Why don’t you gentlemen discuss whatever business you have to attend to. I’m going to go top off my drink.” She downed the rest of her dirty martini and waggled the glass for the men.

“Hurry on back now, darlin’,” Rep. Shelby said.

Madison felt him leering at her ass as she departed. *Charles owes me big for this*, she thought. She slapped her glass down on the bar so hard that she nearly snapped the stem. She apologized to the bartender and ordered another.

“Well, don’t you look cute tonight, Madison? Is your horse parked outside?”

She turned, and it took her a second to recognize Deputy Director Bristow outside of her regular context. The woman had not dressed for the theme. She wore a classic little black dress that skimmed her athletic body. The only nod to the evening was a pair of black cowboy boots. Bristow wasn’t the sort of woman who enjoyed playing along.

“Are you stalking me, ma’am? Does Scarlet Phantom mean you need to keep tabs on me?” She dropped her voice when she mentioned the name of the operation.

“Daniel Shelby sits on the House Permanent Select Committee on Intelligence. I have a reason to be here. I didn’t expect to run into you. And you really should call me *Jen* here,” Bristow replied, giving her western outfit a longer look. “Do you enjoy playing dress up, Madison?”

“I enjoy supporting my husband. I’d rather be home watching a movie with my kids or going for ice cream.”

“It’s important that you have your priorities straight and that you hold onto that in undercover work. I’m sure I don’t need to remind you how easy it is to get lost when you’re playing the role.”

“You don’t. My family is my North Star. They’re the reason I’m doing this. I don’t want my kids growing up in a world with...” Madison nearly said *Null:Echo* and paused. “With *that* out there. They’re worth the sacrifice.”

Despite her assurances, Madison had concerns. It was so easy to let go and fully commit to whatever role the mission required because the Agency

was her life. She wasn't risking much, except for her life. She had everything to lose now. Could she come back if she crossed too many lines?

"You could have warned me that my partner would be Damien," she said.

"Warned? Is that a problem?" Bristow was enigmatic. She gave away nothing, but she had to know what Madison meant.

"Not a problem, no. I understand the logic, however flawed it is. We had a rapport, but that was sixteen years ago. There's no reason to believe we can just slip right back into it."

"*Rapport* is a word for it, Madison. I'm aware that you and Mr. Kane were more than partners. Neither of you ever reported it, but the Agency knows everything. You need to be a convincing wife to whoever you go in with. The chemistry you and Damien shared doesn't just fade away. I'm sure that once you've spent some time together..."

"I swear, if you tell me that it's like riding a bike again, I'll throw this martini in your face, Jen." She lifted her fresh drink from the bar and sipped it.

Bristow laughed. "I wouldn't dream of it, Madison. Just make sure to take out the olives first if you're going to toss that drink. I'd hate to take the toothpick to the eye. But you have something to build on with Damien. We don't have time to train and build your chemistry with anyone else. It's not like Charles can go in there with you."

"Charles?" It was Madison's turn to laugh. "Forget about the danger. I think he'd short-circuit if I took him to somewhere like Nox Venari. He isn't the kinky type. He certainly couldn't handle seeing...the things I might have to do."

"Did I hear my name?"

Charles seemed to materialize out of nowhere, like the mention of his name summoned him. Madison worried about what he'd overheard. He slid a possessive arm around her waist.

“Yes, we were just talking about you. And here you are,” Bristow said, turning on a charming smile that Madison didn’t know she had.

“Aren’t you... I know I recognize you from somewhere,” Charles said.

“Maybe you’ve seen me on C-SPAN briefing Congress. You look like the type that watches C-SPAN. Jen Bristow.”

Madison watched her extend a hand and wondered, *Who is this woman?* Bristow may have been as much of a chameleon as she was. Charles was taken in by the charm offensive. He didn’t stare at her boss the way the Archbishop and Rep. Shelby had undressed her with their eyes, but she still felt a stab of jealousy.

“The Deputy Director of the CIA. Right. I am not a C-SPAN watcher—sorry to disappoint—but I do get around on Capitol Hill. I’m a lobbyist for Paxton Lowry. Charles Sinclair.”

Bristow used her fingers to put a cross between them. “A lobbyist. You people are the bane of my existence.”

“I’m one of the good ones. I swear.”

“That’s what they all say,” Bristow laughed.

Charles looked between the women, narrowing his eyes. “Do you two know each other?”

“No, uh, not really. We were just chatting,” Madison stammered.

“I have reason to get over to State now and then. Maddy and I have crossed paths, but it’s not like we’re spin class buddies. Although if you want to go sometime, Maddy, hit me up.”

“I’m more of a Pilates girl, but that could be fun,” Madison replied, marveling at how Bristow switched to calling her *Maddy* like she did it all the time. She shifted to sound like she and Charles were talking to one of their friends from the neighborhood, not her boss. “Jen and I were just sharing our impressions of the Representative.”

“And I was complimenting Maddy on her cosplay.”

“Are you above playing the game, Jen?” Charles asked. He was wearing a western shirt with a bolo tie, western-style jeans, and cowboy boots. It was an outfit he only dragged out once a year for Rep. Shelby’s barbecue fundraiser.

“I can turn it on when I have to. This isn’t one of those occasions. I’m not sure anyone would take me seriously as the Deputy Director of the CIA if I were dressed up like one of those girls that they’re always running through the bunkhouse on *Yellowstone*. No one wants to see that.”

“I don’t know,” Madison said. “I think it could be fun.”

“Maybe next time,” Bristow replied.

Charles looked between the women again, like he sensed an undercurrent, but couldn’t understand what it meant. “Anyway, there’s someone I’d love to introduce you to from the Speaker’s office, Maddy.”

Madison retrieved her dirty martini from the bar. “Lead the way. It was great seeing you again, Jen.”

“Go off, do your thing. We’ll catch up another time, Maddy.”

Bristow watched the happy couple depart and thought about what a perfect match they made—if one knew nothing about the real Madison Sinclair. Or perhaps this really was who she’d become, and Bristow had made a huge mistake. She doubted it. She didn’t question her instincts.

No, the real Madison was still there. She’d seen it when she’d watched the redhead handle Archbishop McAllister and Rep. Shelby. Madison didn’t just let their attention wash over her like it was an obligation. She’d let it sink in, found a way to enjoy it, and toy with them.

The powerful men thought they were turning her into an object of lust—and enjoying the bonus of establishing dominance by doing it right in front of Charles Sinclair—but they’d been eating out of Madison’s hand. She’d been in charge the entire time. She could have led those men by the nose to wherever she pleased. Bristow was impressed. *It’s just who she is*, she thought. *You can’t teach that*. Madison might fight it because she thought

she was supposed to, but something inside her craved the game. Bristow was sure of it.

Bristow hoped the Sinclairs could survive what came next, but that was not her problem. Her only priority was obtaining Null:Echo for the United States, and she was willing to sacrifice anything to make that happen.

twelve

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Madison ducked her head into the kids' rooms to make sure they were there, while Charles turned out the lights and set the alarm. Penny was still awake, scrolling on her phone, and Madison had to tell her daughter to put it down and go to bed. Chazz was dead asleep and didn't even lift his head when she looked in.

"Took you long enough," she said when Charles finally joined her in their bedroom. "Thought I was going to have to go out and lasso you." She added an intentionally bad Texas accent to the last part. She could have done it flawlessly.

He laughed. "As long as you don't hogtie me."

"That might be fun."

A strange moment passed between the couple when it seemed that Charles considered the possibility, and Madison wondered if he had a hidden kinky side after all. If he did, it was *very* hidden because she'd never seen a hint of it in sixteen years of marriage. But the way he looked at her in that dress made it seem like he wanted to play cowboy.

"Letting you make me that helpless could be dangerous," he replied, unbuttoning his shirt.

Madison grinned. She walked toward him, slowly opening snaps on her dress. The swell of her breasts pushed it open wider. She dropped the belt

on the floor. By the time she stood right in front of him, the front of the dress hung open. Charles's eyes were drawn to the black lace beneath. She pushed it off her shoulders, and his breath caught when her sheer, expensive bra-and-panty set was fully exposed.

His mouth moved wordlessly for a moment before he finally asked, "Is, uh, that new, honey?"

"That's all you have to say?" she laughed.

"I'm a bit speechless. I haven't seen... You look incredible..."

Madison finished unbuttoning his shirt and pushed it off, softly kissing his chest, the graying hairs there tickling her nose. His hands landed on her hips, and she stepped close enough for her breasts to brush his chest. His fingertips teased at the lace edge of her panties on her round ass.

"Imagine if Shelby had seen me like this," she teased, blue eyes shining up at him.

Charles chuckled. "He probably would have had a stroke and keeled over right there. He couldn't handle you."

"And you think you can?"

"I've been doing it all these years, haven't I?"

He fiercely kissed her. She purred around his tongue, nails digging into the back of his neck to spur him on. He fully gripped her ass, kneading the soft cheeks. Madison didn't have the rock-hard ass of her younger days, but she thought it was still pretty good. Charles loved it. But the big question was what would Prince Zaydan think? Would her larger, rounder, forty-eight-year-old ass appeal to the twentysomething prince? *What did Damien think when he saw me?* The question came unbidden to her mind, and she kissed her husband harder to push it away.

"Let's see if you can back up that boast," she said, between kisses, steering him toward the bed. She pushed him down onto it, and his legs hung over the side. The lust in his gaze enflamed her. She was glad the lingerie was worth every penny because it had cost a lot of pennies.

“Just leave on the cowboy hat and boots,” he said, grinning. He hurriedly worked on his pants. She pulled off his boots. His jeans followed.

“I didn’t know you liked to play dress up, babe,” she replied.

He laughed. “I do when you look like that. Damn, Maddy, I swear you’re hotter than you were the day we met.”

She returned his laughter. “I know that’s not true. For one thing, I couldn’t fit into that dress I was wearing now.” She stepped between his legs and grabbed his thickening cock, which lay up along his stomach.

“I find that hard to believe. You’re hot, honey. I swear you had Shelby and that priest sweating.” He groaned when she stroked him.

“I think this outfit broke your brain.” Palming his balls, she added, “I guess I did good tonight, then, being your arm candy?”

Charles sat up on the edge of the bed, brushing her hair back from her face. “You know you’re not just that to me, right?”

“I know I’m not *just* that,” she smirked. “But you do like taking me out for a spin and showing me off. Don’t deny it. I’m not offended. I’m proud that you still think I’m worth being shown off after all these years.”

He palmed her full tits like he was weighing them, fingers working at her nipples, which strained against the flattening effect of the sheer bra. His thumb rubbed the shiny, gold V hardware between the cups. She pushed into his hands and gripped his shaft tighter.

“Sure, I’m proud that I have such a hot wife, and I’m not going to complain if that hotness disarms the people I do business with, but you make it sound like I’m pimping you out. I’m not doing that. I’d never...”

“Never? We’ve already established you wouldn’t mind if I did what it took to win *Castaway*.”

Madison mashed her lips to his, attacking with her tongue, showing how badly she needed him. His hands tightened on her, and she moaned. She fantasized about her husband being rougher, taking charge, maybe even pimping her out like she suggested. Why not? Their government was doing

it. Perhaps she was just there for people to use her body to get whatever they wanted. She reached back and unhooked her bra for him.

Charles tossed the bra away and buried his face in her breasts. He'd always loved that. While not a man to overanalyze his feelings, he had wondered if his obsession with tits was borne from a lack of breastfeeding. He also was not the sort of man who'd ever ask his mother that sort of thing. But he'd always loved tits, and Madison had the best tits he'd ever seen. They hung a little lower sixteen years on, but they were fuller and still perfect teardrops. His hunger for her supple flesh elicited a deep moan from his wife.

Madison swayed on her feet, body strumming with a need that was only stoked by Charles's intense focus on her throbbing nipples. He soon had her entire body throbbing, and her nails dug into his scalp while she tried to stuff more of her tits into his mouth. His need for her seemed to have risen to match her own. She was so consumed by it that she staggered when he tore his mouth away.

Charles turned Madison and pulled her down onto the bed. They were both so eager that they were clumsy, making them both laugh. When her cowboy hat went askew, she righted it while he rolled her panties down her legs and struggled to get them off over her cowboy boots.

"You can take them off," she laughed.

"The boots stay on," he replied with mock seriousness.

She was sure he was going to slide up between her thighs and inside her, but instead he went the other way, kissing her thighs and moving downward. It had been a while since he'd spontaneously gone down on her, which was a shame because he was particularly good at it. She arched her back and cried out when his lips touched hers.

"*Yesss...baby...please...*" she moaned, grabbing fistfuls of the sheets while arching her back off the mattress. Her hips rolled up to meet his eager mouth.

“I want to show you just how much I appreciate you being there for me tonight.” He grinned up from between her thighs. The sentiment was nice, but she didn’t want him to pause to speak.

Charles loved it when she was like that. Madison was a force of nature in bed when they met. That never completely went away, but it had faltered with time. He wished he knew how to inspire her to be that girl again all the time, but he suspected it had less to do with him than whatever was going on inside her. She was soaked before his tongue even dipped inside to taste her.

He wasn’t a fool. He saw how much she enjoyed toying with their host and the Archbishop. And it wasn’t about them either—not specifically—but about their attention and how she enjoyed holding it and using it to keep them in the palm of her hand.

Nor was it just those two men. She charmed everyone they encountered at the fundraiser. She flirted so effortlessly, sometimes he wondered if she realized she was doing it. They’d never spoken of it, but Madison was a woman who loved attention and always had been. Fortunately for her, Charles was not a jealous man. Rather, he was the sort who quite enjoyed it when she held court. His world was so rigid and straightlaced—at least on the surface—and he got an intense thrill from being with a sensual woman like Madison, that someone like her wanted him when she could obviously have whoever she wanted.

“Baby...yesss...yesss...god yesss...right there, babe...ahhh god...”

Madison ground her pussy against his mouth, both hands on the back of his head directing him to focus on her clit. He didn’t need it. Charles loved nothing more than making his wife come like this. The more she twisted and moaned, the harder she sucked her clit, tongue whirling over it like a whippoorwill.

“Ahhh yeah...ahhh yeah...oh god...god...Yes! Baby...oh god yes!”

Her thighs crushed his head, muffling the intense sounds of her orgasm. She twisted back and forth, like she was trying to snap his neck. God, she had powerful thighs! Charles was thankful they had a big house, because as loud as her cries were with her thighs crushed against his ears, he could only imagine what she sounded like unencumbered. He did not think the kids should hear their mother like that. Madison never seemed to worry about that. She was always lost in the moment.

She pulled his face away from her pussy as forcefully as she'd held it there. Her blue eyes blazed with lust. Just seeing her flushed, freckled face like that nearly made him come without being touched.

"I need you..." she panted.

Charles was ready to slide on up and inside, but she smoothly lifted her leg around his head and turned onto her knees. She'd always been graceful like a ballerina. He willingly let her position him on his back and straddle him. They'd had sex three times in the past week—Madison had been on fire—and this was the second time she'd insisted on being on top. The other time she'd surprised him in the shower, and he pinned her against the wall.

"Ahhh...god...yesss...baby...you feel so good..." she moaned, sliding down on his length.

"Ride 'em, cowgirl," he groaned, staring up at her with wonder.

Madison smirked. *"So...that's why...ahhh...you wanted me to leave the boots and hat...ahhh...on..."*

"If you could...ohhh...see this...you wouldn't...ohhh...blame me..."

The sway of her tits was hypnotic as she rolled her hips, working her molten sheath around him like a pro. She could do more with less obvious movement than any woman he'd ever been with. Charles kneaded her breasts, plucking at her nipples like he was picking ripe cherries. She tossed her head back, nearly losing her hat, mashing her tits into his hands.

"Ohmygod...baby...yesss...yesss...god, baby...sooo good..."

Madison rocked harder, and he was sure she was just about there, but then she dismounted him. He groaned in frustration because he was so close. He nearly shot his load anyway, painting her stomach and tits. But she wasn't done. She quickly flipped around, that marvelous full ass pointed back at him, and settled back onto his cock. *What the hell is she doing?* he wondered. The question died in his head when Madison was rocking on his cock again. She was putting the *cowgirl* in reverse cowgirl.

"*God...damn...Maddy...ohhh god...holy shit...*" he moaned, grabbing her ass with both hands, fingers digging in, pulling her down harder onto his cock.

"*Yesss, baby...take me...use...oh god, yesss...*"

Charles was stunned. *Use me?* She never asked him to use her. Yes, sometimes they were rougher like this, but they were always making love. He never *used* his wife. But it set something off in him. Looking at her perfect silhouette riding him, recalling the way she leaned in to encourage Rep. Shelby to look down her dress, he did want to use her. Charles wanted to show her what she got for being such a little flirt.

"*Yeah...ride me...ride me, cowgirl...*" he grunted, thrusting off the mattress while he mauled her ass.

"*Yesss...oh fuck yesss...buck me...buck me, you bronco...buck me harder, you fucking bull...*"

The night had taken a bizarre turn, but Charles oddly loved every second of it. He shoved his thick root up into Madison, and she slammed back down on it as hard as she could. They were definitely fucking. He didn't know if it qualified as making love anymore. He didn't care. His balls were tightening. The view of her ass while she rode him like that was incredible. She was milking the cum right out of him.

"*Maddy...honey...god damn...*"

Charles pulled her hard onto his cock and held her there while his balls pulsed his essence up into her. Madison immediately tightened around him

and milked every last drop from his cock. She gave a sharp cry and came right with him. She seemed to spasm with every spurt of his seed until she was finished. She sagged forward onto her forearms but still worked her ass back at him like she could urge him right back to hardness. It didn't matter how sexy she was. At fifty-four, that was not going to happen.

Madison flung the cowboy hat away and crawled up to cuddle against him. He welcomed her flushed, sweaty body and traced subtle patterns on her hip with his fingers until she squirmed from the tickle. He should have known better.

"Listen, I hate to drop this on you at the last minute, but I need to go up to New York on Friday. And I'm probably going to be tied up most of the weekend. I only found out today, but some foreign bigwig is coming to town and we have to roll out the red carpet."

"Who is it?"

"Sorry, I can't say. The other part is that we need to keep it under the radar."

"But Chazz has his show this weekend. Penny's got her tournament."

"We both know Penny won't miss me. I doubt she'd even know I wasn't there if we didn't normally all ride to the game together."

"That's not true, Maddy. I know there's some mother-daughter thing between you two now that she's sixteen, but she loves you."

"She'll be fine. But I do feel terrible about Chazz. I'll tell him tomorrow. I'll get him to understand."

Charles sighed. He was hurt for the kids and annoyed for himself. He hated it when he had to do the parenting things on his own. She was so much better at it. Her work at State required occasional unexpected late hours, but she'd never cancelled on anything important before.

"I know your work is important, but he won't understand. He's a fourteen-year-old boy. He's just going to know that something else was more important than seeing his show."

“I’m sorry. I really am. There is no way I’d miss it if this weren’t urgent. I promise.”

Madison sounded upset, and he felt guilty. Some of his anger was projection. Charles had too many experiences of his parents missing games and school events because something else was more important. Absentee parents were something they’d bonded over early on, and they’d promised each other they’d never be those parents. But then life happened.

“I know you are, honey. But this isn’t great.”

“I know, babe. I’ll fix it. I promise. I’ll make it up to all of you.”

Charles sighed. “You’re going to catch hell from the kids. I hope this really is life or death, Maddy.”

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Madison was uneasy sitting beside Kane on the Acela from Washington to New York. Cassandra sat across from them. They didn't bring the entire team for the Richardsons' membership interview with Nox Venari. There was no danger in a sex club interview. The worst that could happen was that the Richardsons would be rejected for membership. Cassandra had a Plan B for that contingency.

How many times had Madison and Kane been seated on a train together in Europe, or a plane to some far-off corner of the world? It was hard for her not to be taken back to those days. She knew she shouldn't fight it. The more comfortable she was around him, the better. They were playing a long-married couple. She thought of her easy rapport with Charles, their casual affection, and wondered how she was supposed to fake that with Kane. Madison hadn't played that kind of role with another man in so long.

She used most of the three-hour train ride to go over their legend—the story of who Melissa and David Richardson were. Madison thought of how the kids' teachers presented themselves and how Melissa was a former teacher. She needed to project a softer, nurturing aura that didn't come naturally for her. Not every teacher was like that, but she decided Melissa was. Melissa worked with local literacy programs and food banks in the Philadelphia area, where the Richardsons had recently downsized to a

condo on Rittenhouse Square from the Main Line. They would be traveling to New York for Nox Venari events, which helped with their cover. Melissa was clearly a loving, caring woman. Madison decided to model herself on her sister-in-law, Catherine, who was a sweet but fairly uptight woman. Catherine also spent most of her time on charitable endeavors.

The Richardsons' Nox Venari application was included in the file. The boys in DS&T did an excellent job of mocking up photographs of the couple. In the old days, she would have had to go into a studio at Langley and have photos taken to fit her legend, but time was of the essence, and they could do amazing things with AI these days.

In the first photo, *Melissa* was posed by a curving, mahogany staircase in a black evening gown with a plunging neckline. Her bouncy, shiny red hair was swept to one side, and a diamond necklace adorned her impressive cleavage. *I guess Melissa isn't that reserved*, she thought. The second was a photo of *Melissa* and *David* arm-in-arm on a bluff overlooking the impossibly azure Mediterranean Sea in Greece. She wore a breezy, light summer dress and a wide-brimmed hat to protect her fair skin from the sun. The third photo showed *Melissa* accepting a charity award. She was dressed demurely that time, but her jewel-toned sheath flattered her figure.

The final two photographs were more intimate. One looked like a glamor shot, and *Melissa* wore a white merrywidow, skimpy panties, stockings, and shiny pumps. The lingerie pushed her up, putting her assets front and center. *Melissa* smiled shyly, like she wasn't entirely comfortable with the photo. The final photo was of *Melissa* in a black bra and tight jeans, cradling her tits with her arms and slightly turned away from the camera to show off how the jeans flattered her ass.

Damn, they made me look amazing. I don't know how I'm going to live up to that, she thought. The photographs were so real, she would have sworn she'd actually posed for them. Thinking of one of the Wizards down in DS&T trying to picture her naked, or nearly so, made her both

uncomfortable and gave her an unexpected stir of excitement. She wondered if he had created any photos for personal use.

David's photo array featured the same vacation shot, one of him in a tux, another of him in jeans and a nice shirt on horseback, and finally a shot of him shirtless in jeans and a shot of him wearing nothing but skintight black boxer briefs. *David* looked good in every photo, rugged and handsome, but refined. The Wizards made him very impressive in those boxer briefs. Madison tried not to think about how accurate they were.

Kane was certainly still handsome, but she naturally wondered if he still looked as ripped as *David* with his shirt off. She glanced at him but quickly looked away before her mind wandered to places it shouldn't go. She hated that he still affected her like that after so many years apart. She focused on being annoyed that he wasn't poring over his legend, but he'd always been more of a fly by the seat of his pants kind of guy.

The couple hadn't seen each other since that last night, over sixteen years ago, in London. She'd kept tabs on him over the years. She wanted to know he was still out there, safe. But they had no reason to see each other, and she didn't seek one out.

The threesome mostly rode the train in silence. The contrasts between them were fascinating. Tension crackled between Madison and Kane, but not sexual tension, which could be a problem for the mission. She was cautious around him, constantly waiting for something to happen. He was wary of her, which was very unlike the confident officer. Cassandra worried what it all meant for Operation Scarlet Phantom. They were professionals, and all she could do was hope they would pull it together in time for the interview.

Kane felt Madison turn and look at him, but she was looking back down at the file when he tried to meet her gaze. It had been that way ever since he had walked into the SCIF room. She defiantly looked at him a couple of times during the briefing, but when it ended, she kept people between them

and left before he could catch her. Kane wasn't a big feelings guy, but he knew they had to talk.

The look on Madison's face in that SCIF room had said it all. They hadn't briefed her that he would be her partner on the mission. That was awful, but par for the course from the Agency. Too often, they doled out information on a need-to-know basis—when they wanted you to know, not when you actually needed to know it.

Kane had to wonder if Madison would have refused the mission if she'd known he was involved. When she walked out of his life sixteen years ago, it had been for good. She'd told him that whatever they were, it was finished. She was in love with another man. She was going to marry him.

They'd never defined what they were, but he knew how he'd felt. Kane was in love with Madison. Maybe if he'd been able to tell her, things would have been different, but he'd always feared the confession would send her running. That made it all the more galling when she fell in love with someone else. Kane checked him out, of course. He seemed to be a decent guy.

Charles Sinclair. Some D.C. lawyer. Kane couldn't believe she'd be happy with someone like him. She lived for danger. Her heart beat for the thrill of seduction. Kane would have let her be who she needed to be. He doubted Charles Sinclair could handle who Madison really was. Knowing she'd stayed with the man all those years was some consolation. She didn't move on for a man who only lasted a year or two.

Kane wanted Madison to be happy, even if that meant she had to be with someone else. He thought he'd put all of that behind him, but then he walked into that SCIF room and there she was, and it all came rushing back. He had to believe she'd felt that, too.

Madison looked good. He lied so much for the Agency that he didn't like to lie in his personal life, so he'd never utter the cliché that she hadn't aged a day, but the years looked good on her. She was even sexier in her

maturity than she had been as a wild young woman. And Madison was the hottest woman he'd ever encountered. She was one of a kind. Kane knew because he'd spent a lot of years trying to prove that wrong.

Her curves were fuller—ass rounder, tits hanging heavier—but damn, she still looked tight. Madison had to be the hottest thing in her PTA, or church choir, or Cub Scout pack—whatever suburban cliché she'd settled into. He knew the suburban dads in their polos and sandals were creaming their cargo shorts every time they looked at her. Kane was proud that he'd never voluntarily worn a polo shirt in his life. *Does her stuffy lawyer husband appreciate what he has? Does he even know how to give Madison what she needs?* Kane wondered.

Maybe it was wrong, but he was going to enjoy playing her husband. It was the do-over he never thought would happen. David Richardson—Dave to his friends—knew exactly what he had in Melissa. Melissa Richardson never felt taken for granted. That wasn't why they were exploring Nox Venari. David wanted to see his wife in all her glory. She deserved it. And Kane knew that while playing the Richardsons, he could ignite the old fire in Madison. She would insist she was just playing a role, but she would feel it. He knew she would.

MADISON AND KANE were greeted at the double doors of the club by a stunning woman of Indian descent with a cultured British accent who introduced herself as Syma. Her black hair was pulled back into a severe ponytail, which only accentuated her beautiful features, full, pale-pink painted lips, a noble nose, high cheekbones, and curious, dark eyes. Madison wasn't small, but no lingerie could have given her the valley of cleavage created by Syma's black bustier. It almost distracted from the silver fox head that hung from her black velvet choker. The fox head was

Nox Venari's symbol. Syma's pencil skirt was so tight it looked like sitting would be impossible. Her black heels clicked as she led them down the dimly lit hallway. Madison didn't like the way Kane's eyes followed the sway of Syma's round ass.

Nox Venari occupied two combined brownstones on the Upper West Side. The quiet, wealthy neighborhood was the last place anyone would expect to find a sex club, but the location of Nox Venari was a closely guarded secret. In that way, it was the perfect location for a clientele who valued their privacy above all else. The club was empty and eerily quiet at ten am on a Friday, but still somehow exuded wealth and whispered secrets.

Most of the doors off the hallway were closed, but the pocket doors of a large drawing room to the left were open. The room had been converted to a lounge with several large, comfortable couches. A daybed was located by the large bay window that would have overlooked the street had it not been veiled with heavy blackout curtains. An ornate wooden bar on the back wall was lined with stools.

They were shown to a large study decorated in the same dark, bespoke style as the rest of the club. The mahogany bookshelves lining the walls featured as many kinky objects d'art as books, although an early edition of *Justine*, by the Marquis de Sade, was prominently featured. The dark fireplace was topped by an oil painting of a handsome couple, the man wearing a black robe and the woman barely covered by her black lingerie. Half of that couple sat behind the wide mahogany desk, joined by a massive Black man.

"Thank you, Syma. Could you bring coffee?"

"Of course, madam," she answered.

"You must be the Richardsons. Welcome to Nox Venari. Please, come in. I'm Cora."

They knew exactly who their host was. It had all been in their briefing packet. Cora and Anthony Ludolf founded Nox Venari over a decade earlier

in London, the capital city of the world's kinky elite. Cora was the child of minor British nobility and a former model who'd once appeared in *Victoria's Secret* catalogs and a *Sports Illustrated* swimsuit issue. She'd met Anthony Ludolf, an American film and theater producer, while on vacation in Barbados. The couple bonded over their libertine attitudes toward sex and complementary fetishes and quickly fell in love.

Nox Venari started as a series of house parties the Ludolfs threw for their beautiful, rich friends at their stately Kensington home back in London. Soon, Anthony's show business friends and clients demanded they bring the party to LA, and it migrated to the Ludolfs' Hollywood Hills mansion.

When Cora's modeling career waned and a design career faltered, she was at loose ends and looking for her next chapter. Turning the Ludolfs' passion for orgies with the rich and beautiful into a business was a natural fit. Nox Venari was born. The first club opened on their home turf in London. A second in LA followed, and then they moved to the East Coast. Nox Venari now had locations around the world, wherever the wealthy and beautiful gathered. Rumor had it that the clubs had been designed by an award-winning motion picture set designer and founding club member.

Cora came around the desk to shake both of their hands with a warm smile that was at odds with her overall demeanor, clapping each of their hands in both of hers. She was the definition of an icy, upper-crust English blonde. The haughty, unobtainable look had gotten her into modeling, but hadn't been enough to propel her to the next level. Cora wore a tight black leather sheath that just came to her knees and showed off her slender body. She wore the Nox Venari symbol as a silver pin on her dress.

"Please, take a seat," Cora directed, indicating the two black leather chairs in front of her desk. "This is Casius. He'll be joining me for their interview since my husband is in Atlanta working at the moment. It's inconvenient that so much production has moved down there."

“How do you do?” Casius rumbled, hands clasped in front of him. The ebony-skinned man had a shaved head and goatee and was built like a linebacker. His black suit was tailored to perfectly fit his muscular body. He wore the silver fox head on his lapel.

“Just fine. I’m Dave, this is my wife, Melissa.” Kane offered his hand across the desk, but Casius didn’t move.

Madison made a show of looking around the intimidating office as she took her seat. “This place is something. I don’t know what I expected. I don’t know what I should expect from a place like this. We’ve...” She paused shyly. “Dave and I, we’ve never done anything like this before.” She took Kane’s hand like it was her lifeline.

They’d checked into a hotel to freshen up and transform into the Richardsons. Kane wore a subtle herringbone blazer over a crisp white shirt and expensive jeans with black boots. He looked like the wealthy man trying to be casual that David Richardson was.

Madison’s black dress had a tiny floral print and a sweetheart neckline that showed tasteful cleavage beneath her pearls. It skimmed her figure and fell above the knee, projecting that Melissa Richardson was a well-off suburban mom trying to be sexy. Cassandra had inspected them at the hotel and given them a thumbs-up. She waited there now for a report.

Cora’s polite laugh was musical and conveyed that she was familiar with stories like the Richardsons’. “Most people haven’t, Melissa. Of course, many of our members are quite experienced in the Lifestyle and with various kinks, but we welcome individuals of all experience levels—even those who just want a voyeuristic thrill. There is never any pressure to participate in anything at Nox Venari. Respect and consent always come first.”

“That’s good to know,” Madison replied, offering a warm smile. *Is she buying this?* she wondered. She hadn’t had much time to slip into Melissa Richardson’s skin and get used to it.

Kane leaned over and kissed her cheek, squeezing her hand. The familiarity of his lips, his stubble brushing her cheek, was unnerving. It was like those sixteen years apart had washed away. His touch was also distinctly different from Charles's.

"Don't worry, sweetheart," he said with a warmth Madison didn't know he was capable of, "I'll be there every step of the way. We're in this together."

Madison squeezed his hand, thinking, *Maybe, but you won't be cheating on an actual spouse*. She assumed that anyway. Kane hadn't been wearing a wedding ring before slipping on David Richardson's. Her wedding ring was locked in the safe at the hotel, so she could wear Melissa's.

"Aren't you two darling?" Cora said. She glanced at an iPad. "And so much sexier in person. Your pictures didn't do you justice. Melissa, you're quite beautiful. I love your hair. Redheads are quite popular here, you'll find. And David, what can I say?" He looked at her iPad again, clearly looking at the photos in their application. "I'm sure our discerning members will enjoy getting to know you."

"Oh, my goodness," Madison replied, forcing a blush into her cheeks.

"I guess what you filled out in your application is true. You haven't dabbled in the Lifestyle at all? No kinks?"

"Well," Madison replied, making of show of meeting the blonde's eyes, "I did let Dave tie me up once or twice, back when *50 Shades* was all the rage. It was...fun."

"I'll say," he confirmed, sounding overly enthusiastic like Richardson should. "I just know Mel here has an inner fire, and I'd love to see her tap into it."

"Or see others tap her? Tap into it, I mean," Cora said, looking between them to size up the couple. "Your love for each other is evident. And I see you communicate well. Those are the bedrocks of successful ethical non-monogamy."

“Excuse me, *ethical* non-monogamy?” Madison asked, playing dumb. Melissa wouldn’t know what that was. She knew it was having a cultural moment, especially among the upper-middle-class.

“There are many forms of non-monogamy, Melissa. Cheating is technically non-monogamy. Many open marriages—many swingers—don’t even go about it ethically. But when deceit is introduced, it’s corrosive. We do not tolerate drama at Nox Venari. Security is always on hand to remove guests who may need a cooling-off period.”

“That’s good to know. Personally, I can’t stand drama. A man should be able to handle his business,” Kane said. “And do it in private. But you don’t need to worry about us. Mel and I are both excited to explore this new chapter of our marriage. Aren’t we, sweetheart?”

Laying it on a little thick, aren’t you? Madison thought. “I think that maybe Dave is a little more enthusiastic...no, that’s not right...*daring* than I am, but yes, we’re both excited.”

“I believe you’ll discover that Nox Venari is the perfect environment to learn what *interests* you, Melissa. We’ll take you on a tour of the club in a few minutes.” Cora scrolled on her iPad. “Casius has vetted your application. Your charitable work is quite impressive, Melissa. And Dave, you’ve done quite well for yourself in tech. I’m quite impressed. I’m sure Anthony will want to bend your ear about investing.”

“I’ve been lucky. I got out of real estate at the right time back in 2007, and I got in very early on some tech stocks.” Kane faked humility well.

“Oh, it wasn’t luck, honey,” Madison said. Calling another man *honey* felt so wrong, but she kept it rolling. “Dave is such a good businessman. He’s built an incredible life for our family. If he wants to be more adventurous now that we’re on our own, I think he’s earned it.”

Madison gave Kane what was meant to be a peck, but he took advantage, pressing his lips harder to hers. Her gasp was spontaneous, and only her training kept her from pulling away and punching him. He knew

exactly what he was doing, and it wasn't about playing the Richardsons. But even with all that, the kiss flooded her with heat. She'd always had trouble resisting Kane—especially when she knew she should. Madison only pulled back when he tried to flick his tongue between her lips.

“Honey, we're not alone,” she whispered, hoping Cora would take the flush of her freckled cheeks as embarrassment.

“Sweetheart, we're going to have to get used to doing things...being around other people,” he replied, his smile saying something entirely different to Madison than was meant for Cora.

“As I said, you can take your journey as slowly as you need, Melissa,” Cora commented.

“I saw you guys live on Rittenhouse Square. Do you like Oro Bianco? I try to hit it every time I'm in Philly,” Casius said. “Their white truffle sauce is an experience.”

“Don't you know? They closed last fall,” Madison said. “I think a new Asian fusion place is in that space.”

Nice try, she thought. *Did something in our legend raise a red flag?* The Agency's workups were usually bulletproof. The Richardsons' story certainly should have withstood a sex club's background check, even a place like Nox Venari.

“That's right, sweetheart. Lotus & Ember is there now,” Kane confirmed.

Casius nodded. “That's a shame. I guess I'll have to try the new place when I'm in town.”

“We love it,” Madison gushed. “Well, I do. Dave isn't the most adventurous eater. Are you, honey?”

Kane shrugged. “What can I say? I'm a pretty basic meat-and-potatoes kind of guy. You should let us know when you're in town. We could all have dinner together.”

“Never apologize for who you are, David,” Cora said. “Always live your truth.”

The British blonde looked at Kane like she’d love to discover his truth for herself, and Madison felt a flare of jealousy, which she instantly hated. She blamed it on slipping too much into her role as Melissa Richardson.

“Now, I’m sorry to be indelicate, but there is the issue of money. You’ve done well, so I don’t suppose the issue of membership fees will be an issue,” Cora continued.

“Of course not, Cora. I can write a check now, if you’d like.” Kane pulled a leather checkbook from his jacket.

“We can take care of business after the tour, David. I just want to be sure you will not blanch at the cost of membership. To us, that cost is but a small consideration. We consider membership in Nox Venari to be a privilege. The fee is simply our assurance that you are serious. As new members, you will join at our Argentum level, which is \$25,000 per couple, annually. Once you’re comfortable and have established yourselves, you’re welcome to apply to become Obsidianus members. Obsidianus membership is limited, but fortunately for you, there is currently no waitlist.”

“My Melissa is top tier all the way, Cora. Hopefully, the wait isn’t long to bump up,” Kane said.

Cora smiled. He could see she was already counting the Richardsons’ money. And \$25,000 was proof of very serious intent where Kane came from. Madison probably didn’t blink at that kind of money these days with her lobbyist husband, but Kane was a lifetime CIA officer. He did well after so many years, but he didn’t crack six figures. He didn’t make *living in McLean, Virginia* money.

“We’ll know once we have the measure of you,” Casius said. He seemed to be trying to decide who the Richardsons were. He obviously already liked what he saw in Madison. Kane didn’t blame him. Every man did.

Cora frowned at Casius's comment. "The timeline is different for everyone. I'd say it's more of a feel thing, really. And I already have a good feeling about both of you. Why don't we take that tour?"

"Sounds great," Madison said.

"Lead the way," Kane added.

fourteen

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The tour was informative. Madison liked to think that she was worldly, but Nox Venari catered to kinks she'd never even heard of. The medical exam room took playing doctor to a whole other level—one she found creepy. Sex was the last thing on her mind when her legs were up in stirrups. She'd been in dungeons before, but the one in the basement of Nox Venari was particularly well-appointed. The other portions of the basement were dedicated to locker rooms and a pool with a hot tub. During the tour, Cora explained that members were expected to wear masks whenever in a public section of the club.

“Sort of like *Eyes Wide Shut*,” Kane suggested with a chuckle.

Cora frowned. “That film was silly and exploitive. That is not what we do at Nox Venari.”

Besides the drawing room and office, the main floor held another large parlor that had been turned into a performance space that featured a large, round bed on a raised dais. Casius explained that while there were performers at Nox Venari events, guests who enjoyed exhibitionism were welcome to join the show or even take the dais themselves afterward.

No, thank you, Madison thought. Back in her wild days, she'd had sex in plenty of public and semi-public places, but she had never done it on a stage for everyone's enjoyment. Melissa Richardson turned deep crimson

and laughed out loud at the suggestion. She spent a lot of time blushing during the tour. *Maybe Damien would like to get up there*, Madison thought. He'd always been a showoff.

The second floor held a large bedroom with the floor covered in mattresses and the walls lined with mirrors. Cora explained it was the public play area, although Madison doubted public misbehavior was limited to that room. *The orgy room*, she decided.

"Everyone just piles in here?" she asked as Melissa, trying to sound horrified. Kane pulled her closer for reassurance. She'd been in an orgy room or two as well, but she'd been a different person then.

"Don't worry, Melissa. Consent is strictly enforced, especially in here. No one touches without asking. Everyone understands that no means no. Consequences for those who don't are severe," Casius said. He moved closer to Madison as well, as if to offer another steadying presence. His size was reassuring—if he was on her side. He would be frightening if he were not.

"Yes, the public playroom is only for a certain type of individual," Cora explained, "which is why we have several private bedrooms. A few more of them are themed, but not all. Perhaps it would be best if we split up for the rest of the tour. Unless you object, of course."

"What do you think, sweetheart?" Kane asked. He didn't want to be parted from Madison. He was enjoying her reactions to the club. He liked to imagine what trouble she'd get into there.

"It will be fine, honey. We're in good hands," she said.

Madison was the one to initiate a hot kiss that time. She wanted to show the tour was making an impression on Melissa, but also didn't want Kane to think he had the upper hand. His grip tightened on her waist, and he pulled her tight against him. She didn't like how good it felt and pushed back.

"See you soon then," he replied.

“Shall we?” Cora asked, extending her arm to Kane. He was as surprised as Madison. They both assumed they’d be gender matched. They both understood this was a test.

“WE HAVE four private bedrooms on this floor, and five more upstairs,” Cora explained, leading Kane into one of them. “Each has a private bath.”

The bedroom was smaller than he’d expected, which meant the California king bed occupied most of it. The furnishings and general decor were all dark, like the rest of the club, although he noted a mirror on the ceiling and a massive mirror above the long, narrow dresser.

“And anyone can just come into a bedroom if they find someone they like?” he asked.

“Or if you and Melissa would like some privacy, although I don’t think you two will be simply observing for long. I was watching Melissa through the tour. I can see she is interested in exploring. She just needs to give herself permission to do so.”

Kane smiled. “It sounds like you have ideas on helping her with that.”

“I have so many ideas, David, but most of them are not about her.” Cora returned the smile, took his hand, and led him toward the large bed while returning to business. “The bedrooms are reserved in time blocks for events. Obsidianus members have priority, naturally. Members who would like to reserve a bedroom for the entire evening may do so, for a fee. Rooms are cleaned between...*bookings*. Linens are replaced. Our members always feel pampered.”

“I imagine these rooms are very busy during your parties.” He brushed his hand across the black silk sheets. “Mel will appreciate this quality. She had concerns that a club like this would be seedy.”

“There are many Lifestyle clubs out there, and yes, many of them are quite seedy. I believe you have at least two in Philadelphia. They are not selective about membership. You may see your child’s teacher there, or mechanic, possibly even your pastor. There is no quality control. Our members appreciate that they will encounter a certain type of person when they come to Nox Venari.”

“I gathered as much from your website and the fact that we had to submit bios and pictures. I’m quite a discerning man myself. I appreciate that. I have an idea in my head of what a place like Nox Venari should be, and it doesn’t include my son’s high school English teacher.”

“No? What are you hoping to find here, David? What is your type, then?” The heat of her body was impossible to ignore when she stood so close. Her hand trailed over his chest, fingers pausing by his buttons while she decided if she wanted to unfasten them. “You know, I was quite impressed by your photographs, especially the last one. Between you and I, we’re lenient on the men we admit than the women, when it comes to physicality.”

Kane laid a hand on her slender hip. Cora didn’t have Madison’s curves, but her body felt gym-sculpted under that leather. No one needed to lower their standards for Cora. “I’m sure the size of the men’s *bank accounts* is more important than the size of their... I know many of my peers have let themselves go. There’s less incentive, for some men, to work on themselves when they know they can get beautiful women anyway.”

“And you feel differently, David?” Her fingers played with the hair in his open collar.

“I want to keep living well, and fitness is part of that. I don’t understand these men who just surrender to gluttony and hope for the best. I certainly don’t want a woman who is just with me for my wallet.”

“A woman should just want you for your body?”

Kane smirked. “Something like that.”

Cora's forwardness gave him license to explore. His hand slid up her side from the slight swell of her hip to the curve of her breast. Her tits were probably about a handful, but who didn't know how much heavy lifting her bra was doing. He didn't grope her because he wasn't a barbarian, but simply *felt* her.

Kane knew it was another test. He just didn't know how to pass or fail it. Was he supposed to fuck Cora to prove he and *Melissa* were truly looking to be open? Or was he supposed to turn her down to prove he was a loyal, loving husband? His thickening cock did not want to turn her down. Cora was a sexy woman, and what man didn't want to sleep with a former model? But as much as he wanted to bend the blonde over that bed and see that tight ass while he hammered away, doing it with Madison somewhere in the building felt wrong. *She's not really your wife*, he reminded himself.

"You have nice hands, David. You don't need to be shy with me." Cora began unbuttoning his shirt.

"Is this part of the interview? Do you need to confirm that I can perform to your standards?" His hand formed to the curve of her breast. He didn't feel padding under the dress. It was all Cora.

"This isn't about proving anything. Maybe I just want you. We encourage going for what you want here at Nox Venari. We're both consenting adults. If we want to fuck, David, what's stopping us?" She grabbed him through his jeans, bringing a grunt. She moaned approvingly at what she found.

Kane grabbed the back of her head and kissed her hard. Cora forced her tongue into his mouth. Her grip tightened on his cock, and his tightened on the nape of her neck. She moaned louder into the kiss. He suspected that beneath the ice queen exterior, Cora wanted a man to take charge.

"I want you to fuck me, David. Show me how much you want me." The dirty words sounded so polite in her posh British accent. She tugged at his belt.

“So direct. I love it,” he replied, using her ponytail to steer her lips back to his.

Cora pushed his jacket off and went right back to work on his belt. His jeans were unbuttoned next. He unzipped the back of her dress and didn’t feel a bra strap when it parted. The dress pooled at her feet. The pale beauty only wore a tiny black thong beneath it. Her body was flawless—slender, toned, with a gentle swell of the hips and high, tight tits, capped by pale, puffy nipples. She was waxed smooth. Cora was in her mid-forties, but she still looked like she’d just stepped off the runway.

She smirked at his reaction to her body. A woman like Cora Ludolf was used to it. “I’ve shown you mine...”

“I stripped your dress. If you want it, take it out.” Kane felt powerful, commanding such a uniquely stunning woman.

“You’re used to getting what you want, aren’t you?”

“Usually.”

Instead of arguing, Cora went to her knees on the dark, hardwood floor.

Her thin, vivid pink lips brushed his tip while she slowly pumped his shaft. Her crystal blue eyes never broke contact. Kane shivered. It hadn’t been too long since he’d had a blowjob, but it had been a while since a woman like Cora had gotten onto her knees for him. The tip of her tongue peeked out to capture the sticky precum she pumped out of him. *Jesus, she’s fucking hot*, he thought, resting his hand on the top of her head.

Only when his cock was halfway into her mouth did he remember the role he was playing. Would David Richardson get a blowjob on their Nox Venari interview? The Richardsons wouldn’t have considered this possibility and talked about it. They would have assumed it was an interview. With a groan, Kane tugged Cora’s ponytail, pulling her mouth off his cock.

“Sorry, I can’t do this. Mel and I didn’t discuss this... I’m sure she’s not... I can’t have sex with you, Cora.” He hoped he sounded as hesitant

and conflicted as Richardson would. Kane was only conflicted about following the mission. He was sure he wanted to shove his cock down the woman's throat.

Cora surprised him by smiling. He fully expected a scolding. "I admire your love for your wife and your loyalty. I will take a raincheck on the fucking."

"Thank you. I appreciate that, Cora."

He offered a hand to help her up, but she didn't take it.

"I can't leave you like this, David. I don't think you could even get this thing back into your jeans anyway."

Cora plunged his cock back into her mouth. Kane moaned and tightened his grip on her ponytail, urging her to take more of him in her mouth. He was going to let her finish him. But while she sucked his cock, he had a very David Richardson thought. He wondered where Madison was at that moment, and if she was being tested, did she succumb to the large Black man?

"IS THIS ANOTHER DUNGEON?" Madison asked, pouring on the wide-eyed innocent act.

"Not quite. It's the toy room. We have a wide selection of toys for our members to experiment with," Casius said, his hand on the small of her back, guiding her into the room.

The bedroom did not have a bed, but instead a Sybian sat on a small platform in the middle of the room. It was clearly intended to display its rider. Madison was familiar with vibrators—she had a favorite—but she'd never seen a Sybian before. She only surmised it was some kind of sex machine based on the dildo that protruded from the top of the half-barrel-shaped base.

A rack on the wall held a variety of implements: dildos of all shapes, sizes, and colors, from slender glass cylinders to an incredibly realistic purple phallus—realistic except for its color and enormous size. Madison was confident no real man was that large, not even her companion Casius. The rack also held a strap-on harness with several realistic cock attachments. She giggled, thinking about chasing Kane around the room wearing it.

“What has you tickled, Melissa?”

“Oh, nothing. Just imagining being in here with Dave. I think it would be fun.”

“Do the two of you play with toys together?”

“Oh, no,” Madison laughed. The Richardsons were not a couple who used toys on each other. She was sure of that.

“Do you use any on your own?” Casius smiled slyly when he asked.

Okay, we’re going there, she thought. “That’s sort of a personal question, isn’t it, Casius?” Did I sound as surprised as Melissa would be? But I need to be playful, too. Melissa needs to be interested in branching out.

“Of course, you don’t have to answer. You just seem rather interested in this room.”

Madison walked to the wall and hesitated with her hand hovering near a rabbit-style vibrator.

“Don’t worry, they are all clean. On party nights, we ask members to place the used toys in a bin after use. They are sterilized before they’re returned to the wall. You’re safe to touch anything you like.”

“Anything? Good to know,” she replied, smiling back over her shoulder at him.

She lifted the vibrator from the wall, selecting her personal longtime favorite as Melissa’s preferred sex toy. The heavy base had several soft

buttons to activate its settings. “I’ve used this one at home for years, when Dave is away on business.”

“Just when he’s away? Your love life is active enough that you’re never tempted to slip away for a quick one on your own?”

Madison shyly glanced away, feeling silly to play it so coy. It wasn’t all acting. She’d been with Charles for a very long time, and standing in a sex club discussing her sex toys with a handsome stranger felt odd indeed. She tried to lose herself in Melissa Richardson, but every part of her kept screaming, *This is wrong!*

Casius covered her hands with his, helping Madison cradle the vibrator. She jumped when he switched it on. He clicked it to a higher setting, and she felt the vibrations all the way up her arms. She rarely took it that high. Madison—as Melissa—bit her lower lip when she looked at Casius.

“*Mostly* when he’s away. But I always had to be careful when the kids were still at home.”

“Because you get loud when you come, Melissa?”

“The *toy* is loud. I don’t know if you have kids, but a mother learns pretty early to keep it down when she’s...*finishing*.”

Madison thought of how she used to bury her face in the pillows when she came after Penny banged on the door as a toddler. She’d been mortified and vowed to be a more upstanding mother. After a while, she trained herself to come quietly. She’d only become more reckless again recently. Sex in the living room had been so out of character, at least for the woman she’d become—not the woman she’d been with Kane.

“I have a twelve-year-old son. He’s my world.” Casius had a charming smile. She thought he should use it more often. He was so close now. His thumb stroked her hand while they held the buzzing vibrator.

“That’s wonderful. I don’t quite know what to do with myself now that all the kids are off on their own or in college.”

Casius raised the toy so that it was nearly in her face. Madison thought that she could almost slip her mouth over it to show off, except that Melissa would never do that. Not yet. She didn't know why she even thought it. Madison wouldn't do that either. It would rattle the teeth out of her head anyway.

"Well, you have more time for this if Dave is off working a lot—even if he takes care of you when he's home. And you don't have to worry about being quiet anymore."

"I guess I don't, do I? And yes, Dave takes very good care of me. That's not why we're here. I don't feel like I'm lacking anything."

He tilted the vibrator so the tip bounced against her chest. She didn't jump that time but smiled and waited to see what Casius would do to her next. *He doesn't seriously think he's going to use this—or anything else—on me, does he?* Melissa would never allow that, even if she enjoyed the fresh attention of an attractive man like Casius. Madison had no intention of doing anything physical unless strictly necessary. Still, the toy sent vibrations deep into her chest, and the sensation started a tingle she knew she should fight.

"Good. As we said, we prefer solid couples here."

"Dave and I are as solid as they come. We'd never even consider anything like this if we weren't. I wasn't with, uhm, many people before we met. He thinks I missed out on something, but I've never felt that way."

"That's commendable, Melissa. It takes a secure man to want to give his wife that kind of pleasure."

The vibrator was still in both their hands, but Casius had taken control. Madison wanted to toss the toy away, but Melissa would be spellbound. She didn't like what was building inside her—especially not with Charles almost four hours away. She may need to steal the toy. Casius rubbed it across her tits, and the vibrations made her nipples pop. Her moan was not a performance.

“Tell me, what’s your favorite thing about this one. How do you use it?”

“Casius, I don’t know... I probably shouldn’t...” Madison wasn’t any more comfortable discussing that with him than Melissa would be, but she’d also be more direct about it. However, somehow she found herself answering. Almost like his massive presence and the vibrations were hypnotizing her.

“I usually start by teasing myself with just the end.” Her voice was a breathy whisper. She guided the toy, tracing the tip over her tits. She tried to avoid her nipples, but they were dying for attention. “When I get more... excited...I start to put it in inside me...”

“Deep? Hard?” He pressed it tight against her chest. She ignored the way it made her nipples beg for attention.

“I get it all the way in...eventually. I don’t like to rush.”

Casius guided it down toward her navel. She wished the material of her dress were thicker, although it probably wouldn’t offer any protection. She’d need a tactical vest for that. But her nipples became obvious dents in the floral pattern when the vibrator pulled the fabric tighter against her tits.

“It’s so big, Melissa. I’m impressed. Good to know what you can handle.”

“Is it?” she dumbly asked.

He smiled. “And once it’s in?”

“I like it deep because then the little ears,” she said, thumbing the fork-like protrusion halfway up the shaft, “hit just the right spot.”

“Mmm, do you come the hardest when your clit is being rubbed, Melissa?”

“Casius, that isn’t something I should share. You’re not my... We hardly know each other.”

He went for it. Pushing the toy lower, he dug it into her pussy through her dress. Madison gasped, then moaned, the reactions genuine. She was soaked. The deep arousal had snuck up on her. She pushed back against the

vibrator, rolling her hips, and his strong grip kept it in place. Casius planted his other hand on the small of her back, keeping her pinned right there. Madison swooned and hoped he didn't kiss her, because she knew she'd kiss him back.

His eyes widened when her strength surprised him. She grasped his wrist and pulled the toy away while pushing his hand from her back. *You cannot do this, for so many reasons*, she told herself.

"We should go find Dave and Cora, don't you think?" She hated how shaky her voice was. That wasn't acting either.

"By all means."

Casius turned the vibrator off and returned it to the wall. He smiled like nothing had occurred between them, but they both knew she'd been eating out of the palm of his hand. Madison was sure the man wanted to fuck her, but more importantly, she knew it was a test. She hoped her response had been correct because, for a moment there, the line between Madison and Melissa had blurred completely.

fifteen

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Madison and Kane were both eager to leave when they came back together, but still projected an enthusiasm to join Nox Venari that wasn't false—at least on his side. The small temptation with Casius upstairs proved she was right to be concerned about keeping control while in the sex club.

It wasn't that she was an unrepentant slut. At forty-eight, she was *too* repentant, if anything. She didn't know how she'd ever tell Charles what she'd done with Casius, and she'd done hardly anything at all. Being teased with a vibrator was only the beginning of what Scarlet Phantom would require of her. Her husband would never understand. How could he? Fortunately, all of it was classified, and she *couldn't* tell him. But that didn't mean she wouldn't carry the guilt of being unfaithful.

Kane wrote their \$25,000 check, knowing it would clear. Agency bank accounts and other financial records were all well-established. Cora's glee when she took the check reminded them that Nox Venari was a business and not just a collection of rich married people who liked to fuck others. Syma returned and showed them to the door. Their coffee had never arrived, but the last thing Madison needed was a jolt of caffeine.

The CIA officers were silent in the back of the Uber to the hotel. Madison was curious about how Kane's time with Cora had gone, but had

no desire to share her experience with Casius. She squeezed her thighs together, hoping the throbbing would go away before they got to the hotel.

A note from Cassandra waited for them in the suite. She'd run out for a bite and would be back. She told them to stay there until she returned. Madison paced and looked at the NYC skyline outside the windows.

"I don't want to sound like that person, but does it ever rub you the wrong way to take orders from someone so much younger than us? I know a lot of younger people at Langley. I'm sure you do, too. But I've never reported to one of them before," she said.

Kane shrugged and took a tiny bottle of scotch from the minibar. "I don't know. Maybe it's more common in the field. My last three handlers were all younger than me. Maybe not as young as Cassandra, but she's ambitious. I'm not surprised she's rising quickly." He cracked the seal and sipped from the bottle.

"Scarlet Phantom could make her career, no doubt."

"Or end it, if we fuck this up. Do you think we should compare notes from our visit to Nox Venari before she debriefs us? Make sure we're on the same page?"

Madison laughed. "When did you become so prepared?" She was angry that she didn't suggest it herself, but there were things she would not be sharing in the debriefing.

"We haven't seen each other in over sixteen years, Maddy. I'm sure a lot has changed for both of us. I can tell you've changed."

"If that's an age joke, remember, you're older than I am," she snapped back.

"Hey, you're hotter than ever." He abruptly stopped speaking, and she stared at him. "Sorry, didn't mean to say that."

"So, I *do* look old?" She laughed, hoping to defuse the moment.

"No, you're still hot." His gaze swept over her. She still wore Melissa Richardson's dress. "But I just meant you don't look old. Listen, we haven't

really talked since we got back together.” Kane stopped again, realizing it was another poor choice of words. “Is it going to be awkward like this the whole time?”

“You’re the one making it awkward, Damien. I’m fine working with you,” she lied.

“You would be,” he muttered under his breath.

“What was that?” She walked toward him.

“Nothing.” He downed the rest of the tiny booze bottle. “Fuck it. I said you would be. You’re the one who moved on and never looked back.”

“What was I supposed to do, Damien?” Her temper flared. “I was leaving the field. I fell in love with someone else. I was... Our...whatever it was...was unsanctioned. We never told the Agency. They knew, by the way.”

“Of course, they didn’t. I never really believed they didn’t.”

“But I was moving onto another phase of my life. I thought it might be easier for you—for both of us—if I just left. If we had a clean break.”

“Best for you, for sure. You left me in that safe house in London. I was still recovering from Russia.”

“I stayed with you as long as I could, Damien. I had to get back.”

“To him.”

Madison looked away. “I’m sorry if I hurt you. It wasn’t easy for me either. But what were we, Damien? What future did we have? We never even said...”

“I said it, Maddy.”

“Right at the end. I was in love with Charles then.”

“So, I was too late? You knew how I felt, whether I said it or not.”

“It’s not that simple.”

Madison turned away from him, and Kane grabbed her arm. She shook off his hand. “Don’t,” she warned.

“You’re right, Maddy. We’re not archeologists. Why dig up ancient history? We should just talk about the mission.”

“Fine.” She walked over and leaned against the couch. The living room area of the suite was spacious. The Agency was sparing no expense on Operation Scarlet Phantom. She crossed her arms and ignored the way Kane looked at the way it pushed her tits up. “It went well, obviously. We’re in. But for a moment there, I thought Casius was suspicious.”

“Yeah, what was with that restaurant question? Why would they have any reason to think we’re infiltrating their sex club? I think we played the Richardsons well.”

“Who knows? Maybe they thought we were journalists trying to pierce their veil of secrecy. I’m sure it’s happened before. Secrets do leak out of Nox Venari, despite their best efforts.”

“Casius is definitely some kind of security,” Kane said. “And he looked too smart to just be muscle. We need to get Cassandra to ID him.”

“Agreed. Did you learn anything from Cora on your private tour?” Madison hated the jealousy that crept into her voice—especially after their brief fight.

“The ice queen threw herself at me. That was unexpected. Could have been another test to make sure we are who we say we are. Or to just make sure we’re rock solid enough to be upstanding Nox Venari members.”

“All possibilities. Did she let anything slip while she was succumbing to your charms?”

Kane smirked. “You don’t have to sound so surprised she wanted me. Cora’s dress slipped to the floor. I learned she swallows.”

“You fucked her! Damien!” She blurted it out.

“You’re not Melissa right now, Maddy. You don’t have to act jealous.”

“I am not...jealous. I just don’t think you should have reverted to being a man whore. David wouldn’t have fucked her. Otherwise, whatever you do is your business. I’ll only pretend to be caring when we’re at the club.”

“I didn’t fuck her, Maddy. I...Dave...told her that he couldn’t. Not without talking to you...Melissa.”

“Oh.” *I’m not relieved, am I? Why would I be?* “Good. That goes with our cover. But you still let her suck your dick?”

Kane grinned. She’d always hated that cocky grin, and not just because he looked like a boy who was getting away with something—even in his fifties. No, she hated the effect it had always had on her. And Madison still felt it—even in her forties.

“She insisted. And as she pointed out, it would have been hard to get it back in my jeans if she hadn’t taken care of it.”

Madison made a face. “Cora’s a giver. Good for you. I’m glad someone cleaned your pipes. It should get you to calm down.”

“Why? So, you don’t have to do it?”

She bark laughed. “Excuse me? I do not plan on *cleaning your pipes* or doing any more than I have to with you, Damien. We must be affectionate enough in front of other people to sell the cover, but that’s all. Nothing else is happening between us. I’m married. I love Charles.

“I know, Maddy. You’ve told me many times. Listen, I have no desire to drag you kicking and screaming into bed—although you’re fun when you’re aggressive—but Nox Venari is a sex club. We’re going to have to do more than hold hands to sell this. Didn’t that occur to you?”

He got in her face, and Madison blanched. He was probably right, but she’d held onto the false hope that she could tease her way through the mission—maybe fool around a little to keep Prince Zaydan on the hook—but she didn’t think about sleeping with Kane again at all.

“We’ll play it by ear. But don’t worry, I’ll do whatever I need to do to get Null:Echo.”

“The old Maddy would for sure. I don’t know about this version of you. No disrespect, but you’ve been out of the game for a long time. Maybe your priorities have shifted.”

She leaned in, cheeks flushed with heat. Their faces were inches apart. “My priorities are right where they need to be. I’m doing this for my family. For my kids. To protect them. Bristow is right. We can’t let Null:Echo get out.”

“There’s a flash of the Maddy I knew. Maybe you do still have it.”

“I don’t have to prove anything to you, Damien.”

“Maybe just to yourself. Tell me, did Casius test you the way Cora tested me? Did you pass?”

“I didn’t suck his dick,” she defiantly replied.

“Like I said, you haven’t been out there in a long time. Could you even handle a big man like him?”

Kane showed the smirk again, and she almost blurted, *I could swallow him whole*. In that instant, she imagined Casius guiding her to her knees, taking out his gigantic black cock, and pressing it to her lips. And then Kane was there when she unhinged her jaw to prove just how much cock she could take. Madison shook the image out of her head.

“Don’t worry about me. I’ll handle my end. Again, I have nothing to prove to you. Hoping I’ll fuck you just to prove I can, Damien?”

“That would be for you, Maddy, not me.” The smirk grew.

“Fuck you, Damien.”

“Exactly.”

Madison’s hand snapped up, but Kane caught her wrist before she could smack him. He used it to haul her in and kiss her. She was just as shocked as she’d been at Nox Venari, but this time she threw herself into it. Her pussy only throbbed harder as they argued and the forbidden, dirty thoughts filled her head. She cursed Casius and his vibrator.

Kane growled and crushed her in his arms. He pulled at her dress, and several buttons went flying. Melissa Richardson’s sweet/sexy dress was tugged down over Madison’s shoulder, exposing the white lace of her bra beneath. She pulled at his belt like she could just rip it off. The thought of

his cock in Cora's mouth drove her crazy. His thumb brushed her nipple through the bra. Her body lurched with a shot of pleasure. Madison bit his lip. They both tasted blood, and she went at it with her tongue.

Madison was about to go to her knees when they heard the key card unlock the door. She shoved Kane so hard he stumbled backward and nearly knocked over a table. He struggled to his feet while she frantically pulled her dress back into place. She had to cross her arms to keep it there.

Cassandra walked into the suite and looked between Kane and Madison. They'd been doing something they shouldn't have been. The redhead's dress was barely hanging on. She was flushed, and her hair was a mess. Kane was panting and clumsy, hardly the deadly CIA officer he claimed to be. She didn't know if they were fighting or fucking. Neither was good. Either meant their history was a problem. But at least if they were fucking it meant they still had chemistry. *Did visiting the sex club get you two all horned up*, she thought. Kane was an attractive man, but Cassandra did not want to think about the GenXers doing it. *Gross*.

"I don't know what I walked in on, and I don't want to know, but figure it the fuck out before it derails my mission. Got it?"

"It's nothing," Madison unconvincingly replied. "We were just going over our notes from Nox Venari."

"Yeah. We wanted to be ready for your debrief," Kane added.

"Right. I get it if Nox Venari stirred your old *Eyes Wide Shut* fantasies, but don't make it my problem."

"There's no problem. We're professionals," Kane said, shooting Madison a look.

Cassandra eyed them skeptically. *Should I be insulted that they think they can lie to a trained CIA officer?* "Okay. Tell me about Nox Venari. Are the Richardsons their newest members?" She sat at the table and opened her folio.

Madison pushed off the back of the couch and sat across from her, still carefully holding her dress closed. “He wrote the check. We both seem to be hot enough, so if it clears, we’re in. I think the money matters the most.”

“Good news,” Cassandra replied, refusing to bite on their *hotness*. They were probably closer in age to her parents than they were to her.

“What else? Did you learn anything that will help us with Prince Zaydan?”

“He’s probably an Obsidianus member, so we may need to jump up if we want full access to him. That level has access to a private lounge,” Madison said.

“Is that just another check?” Cassandra asked.

“Seems to be more than that. It sounds like you need to prove yourself worthy. Something ridiculous like that. These rich people’s clubs love their secrecy and rituals.”

“Does your country club have a secret handshake?” Kane jabbed.

Madison gave him the finger and felt juvenile.

“Oh, good, I know that one. I guess I’m a member, too. Whatever it is, I have no doubt Maddy will get us in there. She’s willing to do whatever it takes. I think the men throw most of the money around at Nox Venari, but the women hold the real power. We were interviewed by Cora Ludolf and some flunky. We’ll need a workup on him.”

“Don’t worry. I’ll have whatever access I need to the prince.” Madison ignored Kane’s smirk that time.

“Give me what you know about this other guy, and I’ll get it over to Manny.”

“Maddy got to know him much better than I did. She has all his details.”

“And Damien has Cora Ludolf wrapped around his...*something*.”

Cassandra slammed her pen down. “For fuck’s sake, you two. Enough! It’s a good thing we have this weekend to work on your chemistry. Your

next excursion to Nox Venari isn't going to be a quick visit, and you two need to be a loving couple. You need to be the Richardsons."

"We've got it. I promise," Madison said, properly chastised.

"Well, I'm going to make sure. Get ready to roll up your sleeves and become David and Melissa Richardson. By the time I'm done with you, even you'll believe you're madly in love with each other."

"I know how to play my role, Cassie. You don't need to worry about me. And I'm sure Maddy can fake it."

The Asian woman narrowed her eyes at *Cassie*. "Go get yourselves cleaned up and go over your legends again. Then we're going to hit the Met and Central Park, so Melissa and post some fun new pictures to her Insta."

There were two bedrooms off the living room. Madison went to the one with their bags and closed the door. She hoped Kane planned to sleep on the couch. Bonding as the Richardsons shouldn't involve sharing a bed. She couldn't handle that.

Madison sagged back against the door. She still felt the burn of Kane's lips on hers. Still tasted his blood. Her skin was scorched where he'd touched her. God, her core tightened when he tore her dress. Their old fire was still there. Deep down, that was what she feared the most. Her initial fears about seducing Prince Zaydan had been dwarfed by her terror at pretending to be Kane's wife and losing herself in it.

Charles felt farther away than an Acela train ride. It felt like he was on another planet. She wasn't even wearing his ring. She still wore Melissa's wedding rings. She grabbed her personal phone and shot him a text. *Miss you. Sorry again about this weekend. Can't wait to get home. Love you, babe.*

How can I do this? I have to, but what will it cost me? Can I go home again? Can I still be Charles's wife, Penny and Chazz's mother when this is all over?

Madison closed her eyes and sat on the bed. When she pushed the fear down and locked it in the place she always had in the field, all that was left was the adrenaline rush of teasing Casius, feeling Kane's hands on her again.

One trembling hand pulled up her dress. The other went between her thighs and slipped into her panties. She'd have to change them. They were soaked. A moan tore from deep inside when her fingers circled her clit. She wished she had her favorite toy with her. She could take care of this so quickly.

And then it was Casius's dark hand on the vibrator, guiding it. He teased her while asking about Madison's darkest desires, and she confessed them all. He pushed the vibrator deep inside her, and it rattled her core. His dark cock was out, and she opened her mouth, eager to prove she could handle him. It was as big as that purple dildo on the wall in Nox Venari, but she slurped at it, pushing it into her throat. Casius cooed his pleasure, telling her what a good little married slut she was. Madison agreed.

The vibrator in her pussy was replaced by Kane. His cock plunged deep inside her while Casius held her head and fed her his cock. Madison let the men use her. She hadn't had a threesome since that wild night in Qatar in 2005, when they were working that intelligence officer to turn him. She'd changed his life in more ways than one.

She turned her face into the pillow when she came, disproving what she'd told Casius about being quiet. It was so swift and so strong that she couldn't help herself. The orgasm seared through her, and Madison sobbed with pleasure. God, she needed that.

She lay breathless on the bed, willing her heart to stop pounding. The post-orgasm clarity only laid out her reality more starkly. She had to be Kane's loving wife, for who knew how long, and she had to do it without disappearing into the role. She had to seduce Prince Zaydan and do whatever was required to be an Obsidianus member of Nox Venari. Deep

down, she knew she could, but would she still be herself when it was all over? She envied Kane. He didn't have any of her complications.

You're going to do this. You're going to complete this mission, and you'll go home to Charles and the kids and slip back into your life like none of it happened. None of this is real. Penny and Chazz are real.

Madison clung to that. She would keep repeating it in her head until she believed it.

undercover wife: nox venari



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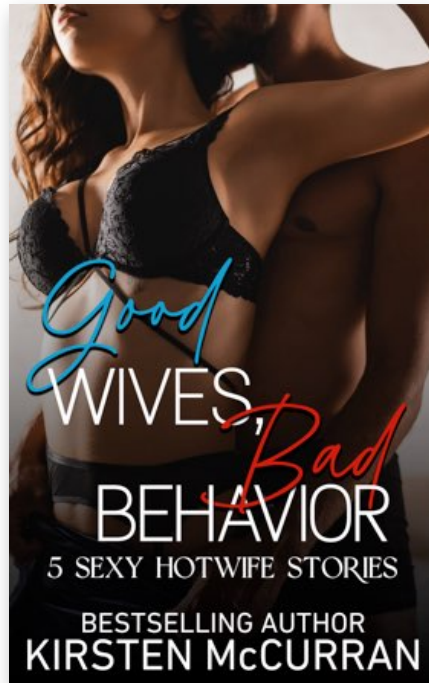
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good wives, bad behavior



From the mind of one of hotwife erotica's most loved writers comes this bestselling collection of 5 sultry stories featuring sexy suburban couples exploring their sexuality with their friends and neighbors. These very good wives behaving very badly could be the woman you see at the grocery store or the president of your local PTA. Kirsten McCurran specializes in pulling back the curtain on everyday couples' most forbidden desires.

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picking forbidden fruit



Lauren Curry is a skilled massage therapist who finds joy in relieving her clients' pains. If anything, she's too giving, putting her clients first whenever she can. When a longtime family friend, Dylan, injures himself working for his father during college summer break, Lauren offers to treat him without hesitation.

Lauren is always the consummate professional, even when an attractive man is on her table—not that she sees Dylan as attractive. He's just a family friend. She's known the young man for ages. But once she gets her hands on the college athlete's body, Lauren discovers just how sculpted it is. Lauren admires his physique with professional detachment until Dylan turns over, and she discovers that he's enjoying her treatment *a little too much*.

Can Lauren do the right thing and keep it professional? Or will a hot college baseball player help this suburban wife find her inner cougar? Dylan is a family friend. He's forbidden fruit. Can she resist picking it?

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tara's homecoming



Tara usually passes on her husband's bro weekend with all his buddies at the Lockley University homecoming game, even though she knows all of them from their college days. She was a staple in their apartment when she started dating Mark. But it's their 20th year of tailgating, and she decides to see if the boys are as wild as they used to be.

The boys, Austin, Danny, and Shaun, were always like family to her, but Tara learns they see her very differently when their old drinking game, Heads or Tails, gets going. It doesn't matter that they're in the middle of a parking lot filled with tailgaters. The challenges keep getting wilder and more daring. Next thing she knows, Tara is crossing lines she never imagined and experiencing things she didn't think possible for a 44-year-old married woman from the suburbs.

A weekend away can change everything. Tara and Mark will be tested like never before. Can their marriage ever be the same after all their limits are shattered? **Tara's Homecoming** is another pulse-pounding shared wife adventure from celebrated author Kirsten McCurran!

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sam surrenders to the neighbors



Corey and Sam Matthews thought they'd found their new best friends when they met their neighbors, Hank and Tina DeSimone. The couples got along so well...a little too well.

Corey can't help feeling jealous when Hank begins flirting with Sam, especially when his wife eats up the attention. He knows Sam liked older men in the past, but he won't believe Hank's attention is dangerous. Everything changes when Tina makes Hank's intentions clear. Hank means to have Sam for himself, and Tina couldn't be more thrilled!

Sam willingly—enthusiastically—gives herself to Hank that first night and Corey feels something he never expected. Watching his wife taken by a powerful man makes him harder than he's ever been in his life. Sam isn't the only one who gets something she didn't know she needed that night.

Corey hopes that night is a one-off experience, and they can return to their normal lives, but it's not that easy. Sam is a sexy wife and Hank wants more. She doesn't want to hurt her husband, but she can't resist their hung neighbor. A day out on the bay provides the perfect chance for Hank to enjoy Sam at his leisure and it seals the deal. Sam's body will belong to the neighbor as long as he wants her. Corey must sort out his feelings and stop it or learn to truly enjoy it.

Sam Surrenders to the Neighbors is a scorching new trilogy from one of hotwife erotica's most popular authors that explores what happens to a marriage when the wife just can't say no to another

man and the husband can't stop watching her do it.

ORDER NOW!

about the author

“Kirsten McCurran” is the pen name of a wife and husband team exploring the sexy secrets of middle-class, suburban couples. This couple has their own dirty little secret: they have lots of fantasies about what all their friends and neighbors are up to behind closed doors, and they turn those sexy fantasies into the stories they love to share with the world. The Mrs. could be the sweet mom you see in the stands at the soccer game or the pretty woman at the supermarket you wonder about as she's squeezing the melons. The Mr. could be your kid's little league coach.

Most of their stories are about married women looking to bust out and explore their wild side, often with the encouragement of their husbands—and sometimes without it. The strength of the couple behind Kirsten McCurran is that husband and wife writing together can uniquely capture the feelings of both partners in their couples as they explore their most forbidden desires. The Mrs. is all about exploring stories of daring women of a certain age exploring their sexuality, and the Mr. captures the feelings of the men who love them.

Kirsten McCurran has written over 60 ebooks, which can be found at major booksellers. You can reach Ms. McCurran by email at kmccurran@gmail.com.

If you'd like other ways to support Kirsten McCurran's writing, visit her website for links, books.kirstenmccurran.com.

